Reconciliation: Exchanges in Grief

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/35602726.

Rating:
Explicit

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

Categories:
F/F, F/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Entrapta/Hordak (She-Ra), Catra & Hordak (She-Ra), All the canon ships

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Double Trouble (She-Ra), Wrong Hordak (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Horde Prime Clones (She-Ra), Micah (She-Ra), Castaspella (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Angst, Hurt/Comfort, Post-Canon, Post-War, Fluff, Aftermath of Violence, Damaged People Being Damaged, Spacebats, Catra (She-Ra) Redemption, Hordak Redemption (She-Ra), war-weary Catra, war-weary Adora, Light dusting of crack, smattering of smut, [catradora smut ch3], [entrapdak smut ch7]

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English

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Part 5 of Season of the Survivor

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by AintGonnaHauntItself

Summary

While reconstruction continues and the BFS keep daydreaming about their coming roadtrip, trouble builds and ominous signs further threaten their plans for the future. Adora's relationship with She-Ra is shifting, and Entrapta can do little about a situation that's hurting them both. Catra knows she must reconcile with her time in the war and find a meaningful path forward, and unresolved issues create strains in her relationship with Adora. Hordak struggles to comprehend the pain he's caused and faces Mermista's and Micah's grief in turn while the alliance gets used to having him around. Unfortunately, he's so busy with the past that it clouds his ability to navigate the present, complicating things between Entrapta and himself.
Meanwhile, news filtering in from other worlds in combination with what they're learning from the clones paints an ever darker picture of the universe just outside their orbit, but the alliance starts to wonder if their deadliest threat is from within, rather than from our space. They can all sense big events headed their way, but the alliance is, for the most part, still flying blind.

Notes

Story continuation, but like, definitely from a post-cult/post-victimization angle. So uh, expect all the horrible shit that goes with those themes, and be careful if you’re dealing with tough stuff. Take care of yourselves and remember that you don't have to forgive anybody for anything.
Centered around Catra and Hordak. Aged up significantly for super adult themes, but it's still set in the canon universe so truth spells are a thing and the only sociopath involved was Prime.

"It's affecting you this time too, isn't it?"

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

There wasn’t much left of her.

Catra shifted weakly on the floor as a large, gentle hand stroked her hair over her ears. Her body felt broken and was wracked with pain, every movement a new ache. The physical pain, however, didn’t compare with how shattered she felt inside. Her soul was dead, it had to be. Her motives and weaknesses had been crushed, her very identity, everything she ever was, had been shredded down to nothing. Even her name had lost all its meaning, because names were for things that were real and present. She would never be whole again. She was nothing but the pitiful remains of a person. Why fight it? Why bother remembering things that only reminded her of everything she’d ever lost. Rather, she only remembered everything she’d ever destroyed and thrown away. The incomprehensible waste of it all… the waste of a life that she was. Why remember? Prime said he still had use for her. That was more than she’d been able to make for herself.

Prime really was the bringer of the day and the night. Terrible, eternal, and cruel. He terrorized with one hand and comforted with the other, dismantled body, mind and spirit so as to build it back up according to his whim. He didn’t just destroy, he used. He was the bringer of death, the giver of life, and he was utterly inescapable.

It didn’t matter if he was good or evil, he was all there was. He was power itself, the most advanced predator in the entire universe. And for all his repugnance, he existed well and above the smoking wreckage of her life, clean and crisp and free of the calamity she trailed with her wherever she went. Prime was so far beyond her, beyond what war and betrayal and spite could touch,

beyond what even Catra could destroy. And he said… he said he could make it stop hurting, could make her whole… give her peace.

The gentle strokes on her short hair stilled as he spoke softly. “Hush now, my wayward child. Turn to me and let me wipe away your wrongs, give you a new beginning.” He went back to stroking her hair in silence.

Though she was loath to admit it, Prime was right about her weary spirit. She was so, so, so tired of fighting. If he really could give her peace, then the price didn’t matter. Whatever the cost, it just didn’t matter anymore. She took a shaky breath and nodded her head beneath his caress.

“Then I urge you, sister, in view of my mercy, offer your body as a living sacrifice, sacred and pleasing to me. This is your true and proper worship.” She let out a small, weak sob. “Do not cling to the trappings of your old life,” Prime cajoled in his oil-smooth manner, “but be transformed by the renewing of your mind. Then you will be able to take up your role in service of my will- my good, pleasing and perfect will.” She sniffed and nodded again. He hooked a metal-clad talon under her chin and forced her to look up at him. “Soon you will be ready for purification.”

Her stomach dropped and icy dread flooded her body. “Soon?” she asked. “Why not now?”

“You aren’t done learning yet.” Fresh tears formed in her eyes and she tried to turn away, but he didn’t let her. “Catra,” he said her name in a tone somewhere between a purr and a growl, and she suppressed another sob. “Are you ready to receive the sacrament?”

Catra gasped for air when she woke up and started coughing. She cringed at the sickly feeling of sweat rolling down every part of her body, and the sheets around her were damp and chilly. She

looked down at Adora beside her and focused on her breathing, reminding herself forcefully of when and where she was. *It's over*, she insisted at herself firmly, *it's over, and it's time to move on*.

The light coming through the window was starting to brighten and Catra knew it would soon be dawn. There was no point in trying to go back to sleep now. She extricated herself as quietly as she could so as not to wake Adora, who stirred and muttered, kicking her legs beneath the covers. She'd gotten to be a grumpy riser and Catra wasn't in the mood to ignore her bullshit. In fact, Adora had gotten grumpier in general, and to Catra's shock was developing a bit of a temper.

She was dressed and out the door in minutes, shutting it softly, using both hands to try and muffle any knock or click. When she turned around to make her way down the hall though, she jumped and felt her tail puff out. Melog was sitting a foot away, waiting and staring.

"Fuck Melog, you can't sneak up on me like that," she breathed in a whisper. They blinked and meowed. "Oh for… my nerves are fine." She shoved her hands into the pockets of her old horde uniform and started off down the hall, Melog at her side. "So where have you been? I haven't seen you in days."

Melog explained that they'd been establishing a perimeter to patrol around the city and its holdings, including the entire agricultural complex across the delta. It was incredibly unnecessary, but she was glad they were keeping busy and, perhaps in a small way, relieved that their keen senses were still trained on defense, even in peacetime.

Then it was her turn to fill them in on her past few days in the city proper and guarding the surrounding roads.

She heaved a sigh and blew a long, low raspberry. "The engineers aren't afraid of Hordak anymore, which certainly makes meetings less awkward. Honestly, I thought it would take them longer than a week to get this far, but Hordak's been making an effort too.

And the whole city seems to have calmed the fuck down for the most part. Especially now that they're getting some pretty cool shit done. They've put up tons of future-y, hydro-powered shit. Plus Hordak has them figuring out how to recycle all kinds of old crap, so efficiency is up in lots of fields."

Melog flicked their tail and shook out their mane, meowing again. Their strange, echoing voice bounced off the halls along with the faint sound of their soft footsteps.

"Yeah, I don't think they're ever going to stop being angry. But no more chanting mobs at least. Although I did see Hordak catch a pretty big chunk of concrete before it hit him in the head a couple days back, but that seemed like a passer-by thing. I'm not worried. His reflexes are still crazy and I feel like I remember Entrapta saying something about his skull being, like, *medically* thick." She heaved another heavy sigh as Melog waited for her to continue. "Unfortunately, protecting the roads has not gotten better. I've pretty much been pretending to be productive, anybody could do the job. It seems like Mermista is kind of just finding things for me to do to keep me busy, community service style. It's a lot better than nothing but it's not very fulfilling." She scrunched her nose before shrugging as they came to a large spiral staircase. She decided to go up and observe moonrise before starting her day, and began to ascend the beautifully tiled steps. "On the bright side, I get to play forest ranger and climb lots of trees, which is fun."

As she stepped onto the next landing, Catra was mildly surprised to see Bow standing at the large stained-glass window, gazing out on the sea with his back to her. She let her feet fall heavier than usual and he turned at the sound, smiling as he met her gaze. "Oh, hi Catra."

"You're up early."

He sighed and looked down with a tired expression. "Yeah, neither Glimmer or I have been sleeping great." He looked back up at her. "Lots to think about these days."

“Dish. What ghosts are haunting Bow lately?”

He huffed a bitter chuckle and smiled. “Do you really want to know?”

Not as much as she should, to be sure. “You’d do the same for me.”

He sighed again and went back to gazing out the window. “My dads didn’t want me to be a soldier.” She frowned and leaned against the wall. “They specifically didn’t want me anywhere near the war. I lied to them about how I was living until like, a year ago.”

“Damn,” Catra said in genuine surprise.

He smiled again. “Yeah…” his smile faded slowly as he thought for a moment. “They didn’t want me in the war because they were afraid of what it would do to me. Death and maiming, obviously, but… they were worried about… my soul? I never knew what that meant before.” A chill ran down her spine and she folded her arms. “I thought, ‘no way, I’ll never go numb, I’ll never give up, I won't let the violence core me out like they’re afraid of’ … but I just didn’t get it.” He shut his eyes and shook his head slowly. “I guess I’m just… I don’t know.” He heaved yet another heavy sigh and Catra was alarmed to hear a tremble in his voice. “Their Bow is never coming home.” She gulped hard. “I survived, but he’s gone forever. The me that made it is…” he sighed again, “home doesn’t feel like home anymore. Nothing that used to give me comfort feels real… just tinker toys. And I’m not sure how to handle it.”

“Yeah. I know what you mean.”

Bow spoke again, but his voice was a whisper. “I’m scared that I ended up exactly like they were afraid I would.”

“No.” She said firmly, and he looked around. “You’re not hollow. You’re Bow. You’re our Bow.”

He looked back out the window without smiling. “But I’m not home anymore. I don’t know if I ever will be again.”

She thought of the Fright Zone, of lying at the foot of Adora’s bed, of the feeling she got now that they finally shared a bed again. “I guess we’re just going to have to be each other’s homes.”

Bow looked up at her and gave her another tired smile, which she returned. “Thanks, Catra.”

She looked out the window as well before she continued. “How’s everything with the clones? I know the plan was for you to leave that to others and focus on tech, but you and Glimmer seem pretty invested.”

Another pained sigh. “Its… incredibly difficult. Not really in a bad way, everyone involved is very supportive and positive. It’s just… intense. We’ve gotten more clones from other planets, just like the star siblings said we would. They’re in a similar state as the ones that were here, thankfully they accept their brother’s accounts of Prime’s death. I’m not sure they’d believe it otherwise.”

“Okay, but how about *you*?”

He scrunched his face. “It’s great, watching them encounter the concept that they have value as individuals, not obligated to feel guilty or unworthy by merely existing.” He looked away and shifted his weight slightly. When he spoke again, his voice was a little quieter. “But, my dads and siblings have been collecting what they can remember, and we’re learning a lot about the universe outside of Etheria. The empire was…” he trailed off and shook his head. “Not just Prime, either. The cruelty of others, too. What people are capable of… what we’re all capable of, I guess. Maybe Glimmer and I are struggling with the fact that even after all we’ve been through, we’re *so* sheltered. So sheltered. The clones make the outside universe seem like a pretty dark place.”

"I uh… I wouldn't beat yourself up too bad. It's kind of an Etherian thing. Sometimes it feels like *everybody* outside of the Fright Zone and the Crimson Waste were childishly naive. I know I say this a lot, but I can't fucking believe you guys were able to match us in war."

"Yeah," he muttered before lapsing into silence. They both simply looked out the window for several minutes, both lost in their own thoughts. Eventually, however, Bow brightened. "But!" She raised her eyebrows. "It is so heartwarming to watch the ones that are bonding with Etherians. Everyone involved has clones they've gotten especially close to. Perfuma and Scorpia have two new best friends that want to get into botany. They follow them around like giant, adorable, deadly puppies." He grinned. "They just named themselves Moonshine and Daisy." Catra snorted and he chuckled warmly. "The three that have been working with Entrapta and I are still settling on names, but they want them, unlike most of their brothers." His face fell slowly, and Catra waited. "About a third of them are still *really* struggling with what their existences have been. And all those who came and went before them… it's a nightmare I can't even wrap my head around." Catra nodded slowly." He sighed again and shook himself visibly. "But they'll be alright. I know it. They've been so strong."

"So you've got groups of clones who've like, fully broken off into new roles? Like Scorpia's and Perfuma's?"

"Kind of. Mine, for instance… er… not mine. The three clones I've been working with. They prefer to eat and sleep with their brothers when they're not on a project, but their daily activities are fully centered around their work, as opposed to… others. Some are having a really hard time seeing a future for themselves in our world. And I don't know how to help them."

"How's working with those three? The sciency ones?" she asked. '*See* ?' she added silently to Melog. '*I'm asking questions. I'm being a listener*.' They meowed passively back at her.

Bow sighed again, but this time the sound was more contemplative than sad. "They're developing their senses of curiosity, you know? It's really incredible to be a part of it, watching them sort of wake up to the joy of learning. And learning for the sake of learning, you know? Rather than to serve the specific aims of a dark god and whatnot. Entrapta's been great when she's around, of course. She really brings the thrill of discovery to the table." He smiled again, but this time she caught a hint of strain at the corners of his eyes. Catra imagined he was thinking of the various other thrills Entrapta added to a work environment.

Her focus was caught by something else he'd said. "What do you mean, when Entrapta's been around?" she asked, cocking her head.

"Oh," he looked taken aback. "I assumed she's been with Hordak, because she hasn't been working on the portal circuit or transportation tech very often. She pops over with space questions fairly regularly, but she's always in a big hurry. That's actually why I'm in Salineas this morning," he said pulling out his data pad and gesturing vaguely. "I've got a couple of questions for Entrapta and/or Hordak that I wanted to ask in person. Math-heavy stuff."

She grunted and frowned, but had nothing else to add. She was curious about whatever Entrapta was up to, but at the same time the odd scientist had been even more unpredictable and weird ever since Beast Island. Scarier, at least. Bow had gone back to gazing out of the window when his communicator started ringing. "I'll let you go," she said, turning to climb higher in the palace. Melog continued to follow behind her.

"Good talk, Catra," he said in a bracing tone. She heard a few beeps before he said, "Glimmer, I know intergenerational communication can be challenging, but you can't just flip a table and tell your entire counsel you're going to lock them in a nursing home."

Catra snickered as she continued up the staircase and his voice drifted off below her, likely soothing Glimmer about an argument with her counsel over clones and housing again. The kingdom's capacities and services were stretched thin, and the richest citizens were starting to rail against the losses that Glimmer's aggressive public service actions were costing their bottom line. Glimmer had little patience for their complaints, to say the least. After hearing enough old people complain about their lives from the comfort and security of salaries and retirement, Catra was ready to start having a few conversations of her own with the council members. She, like Glimmer and Bow, was haunted by the idea of what might have befallen the many clones who did not wind up in the care of Bright Moon, and she wanted them to extend their guardianship over as many as possible.

As far as the ache she saw behind Bow's eyes, Catra felt for him and Glimmer, she really did. The disillusionment they faced was brutal, and the lessons they were learning from the clones were difficult for anyone to swallow. But at the same time, she couldn't help a small, bitter feeling that it was about damned time they wise up. Certainly before they made their road trip into a freshly post-colonial, post-terror universe. They had seen and were still seeing Prime's evil, but most of Etheria had yet to realize the magnitude of evil that was comfortably rooted in the mundane.

Melog mewled at her lazily. "You know it," she answered. "Always to the highest rooftop."

Her thoughts turned to Adora and she smiled at the day's prospects. They were scheduled to clear a minor wagon road that had been buried in a massive landslide when a spire had landed on the mountain above it. Knowing She-Ra's power, it probably wouldn't take long, but she and Adora had left the day clear so they could finally spend some free time together. Adora had been testy lately, but an entire afternoon spent raising hell in the lands around Salines together was bound to be a good time. Not that their nights together hadn't been awesome, and the sex was only getting better, but as far as actually hanging out, they hadn't gotten much chance in the weeks since the end of the war.

As she neared the top of the tower, faint noises drew her down a hallway that branched off into the main palace. Drawing closer, she recognized Mermista's bored drawl and Sea Hawk's enthusiastic sword-fighting sound effects. She didn't really feel like talking to either of them, but curiosity brought her to a door around which to peek. Melog crept up to the open door to poke his face around below Catra. Inside, Mermista sat comfortably in a big fancy armchair, wearing a quilted turquoise robe and sporting impressive bedhead. On her lap was a large stack of papers and envelopes, and she seemed to be reading them one by one. Some kind of attendant stood behind a table next to her, sorting documents into stacks. On the other side of the room, Sea Hawk stood between Mermista and a crackling fireplace with his glowing sword out, smiling at the princess.

"Hate mail about Hordak," Mermista said lazily before balling up a paper and throwing it at Sea Hawk.

"Ha ha!" Sea Hawk declared loudly as he stabbed it out of the air and slung it around into the crackling purple flames.

"Hate mail about Hordak," she repeated, crumpling another paper for him to slash into two before kicking them into the fireplace to burn.

"Hate mail about Catra *and* Hordak," the two repeated their system. "Ooh!" Mermista brightened. "A trade proposal," she handed it to the attendant, who placed it carefully on one of the piles. She didn't bother announcing the next paper she scrunched and threw at Sea Hawk, just rolled her eyes and sighed.

Catra smiled to herself as she and Melog turned and left them to their early morning routine. She still had at least an hour before Adora woke up, so they returned to the staircase to finish the ascent to the tower's roof.

When she'd found her perch, Catra stared into morning moonrise over Salineas. Nearly all the priceless ancient art that had been reduced to rubble had been collected and was being painstakingly

sorted and recorded. What could be salvaged and reused would be. The rest was lost. Such remains would end up in museums, symbols of a bygone era rather than the living culture of Salineas. New houses were being built up in the wide swaths their army had carved through entire neighborhoods, all except for a large open space where, just after the war, Mermista and She-Ra had erected a large, colorless coral memorial. The base of it was piled high with colorful flowers and notes, though, and the space was rarely empty. Catra got goosebumps any time she looked at it for too long.

* * * * *

Later that day, Hordak soldered busily at a worktable in his lab at Salineas. The morning was beginning to grow late, but Entrapta still hadn't emerged from their bedroom after arriving in the small hours before dawn. He'd been awake and working himself, and just barely managed to shut down the interview that had been playing on his screen when he heard Emily noisily announcing their presence.

At this thought, a niggling sense of worry sounded at the back of his mind. Entrapta was still exhibiting the habits that had concerned him weeks before- the overworking, the lack of rest or routine… and, if he were being honest with himself about his more selfish impulses, he missed her. She hadn't been spending much time around him outside of her preference for sleeping together. He had no room to complain, of course, but the idea of her potentially hiding something from him or her friends bothered him immensely.

Thinking of Entrapta's friends made his worry turn to agitation. Despite her fondness for them, and despite them proving themselves to be extremely merciful and generous, some of the treatment she'd received at their hands didn't sit well with him at all. The idea of anyone behaving toward Entrapta as if she was a burden brought all too familiar flickers of rage to his chest, but he clamped down on the feeling tightly. He had no room for wasteful or pointless anger in his life anymore. He had other duties to attend to.

"Hordak?"

He turned around to see a bleary-eyed Entrapta standing in the doorway to their bedroom in an oversized shirt. Her hair was down and trailed on the ground behind her, and a small smile graced her lips as she rubbed an eye sleepily. "Yes, Princess?" He set down his work and crossed the floor to her side, where she rose up on her hair.

"I love you," she said, kissing his cheek. "That's all." He felt a low purr start in his chest and she sighed deeply against him before lowering herself back down to the ground. "Have you eaten yet?"

"Have you?"

"I just woke up!" she protested. "And don't be evasive. I'll eat if you do."

He sighed and smiled at her again. "Alright. A small break then."

They ate on their feet, as they often did. He followed her around the lab, munching on fruit as she checked up on his work and chattered about her adventures in spaceship technology between tiny portions. She kept talking after they were finished with their food, beckoning at him to follow her so that she wouldn't have to shout. Not that she wasn't already speaking at a completely unnecessary volume. Hordak often wondered if, after so many explosions, her hearing wasn't as sharp as it might have been.

She was still talking after she'd gotten dressed and ready for her day, but Imp managed to distract her with a show of small, shiny treasures he'd collected from around the palace. A few screws, nuts, and other broken bits of metal and glass twinkled up at Hordak from the dull metal work table and he couldn't help but smile. Entrapta cooed and praised the beast while Hordak quickly looked over the assortment to make sure nothing too valuable had been pilfered. "Oooooh," Entrapta said lowly, picking up an odd-looking bolt. "This looks old. Where'd you get it?"

Imp giggled, pointing upward, and Entrapta eagerly followed him up into the lofty ductwork. They set to clattering about up above, causing who knew what chaos among the pipes, jabbering to one another and exchanging obnoxious, high-pitched noises. Meanwhile, Emily stomped around on the ground below them, beeping and whirring in curiosity. Hazardous and jarring and chaotic as his strange little family was, he wouldn't have had it any other way. He couldn't deny that the strain of familiarizing himself with his deeds was growing with every story he processed, but how could he complain? He had everything he'd ever wanted. He just hoped what he was doing wouldn't drive her away.

After their first night together after war's end, he'd embarrassingly assumed that physically intimate activities with Entrapta would provide fairly frequent distraction. But both he and Entrapta had been so busy and caught up in their own goings-on that neither had felt up to such activities, and their nights together were almost entirely spent in sleep. Or at least, Entrapta would sleep for about six hours or less. Sometimes Hordak would sleep too, between nightmares. He was dreaming about his victims more and more.

The hiss and whoosh of the automatic doors to the lab pulled him from his thoughts abruptly, and he looked up to see a small crowd of people walking toward him. Princess Mermista was in the lead, looking bored as ever. Close behind her were Catra, Adora, Melog, Bow, and a small entourage of royal attendants. He sighed and considered making the effort to smile, but instead he raised a

brow at them as they approached. “To what do I owe the honor of this visit?” he asked Mermista drily.

“Bow has nerd questions and I wanted to check in,” she said in a flat voice, though not unfriendly by Mermista standards.

“Is Entrapta around?” Bow asked.

“She’s on the ceiling with Imp,” Hordak replied. A couple of attendants did double-takes at his words before looking upward warily.

“Hey Entrapta? You got a minute?” Bow called to her.

“Hang on, I’m almost done,” she called back down before they heard the sound of her circular saw start up. Mermista frowned but said nothing. Several moments passed in awkward silence between the intermittent buzz of Entrapta’s saw. After a while, Entrapta called, “just a second…” More time passed without her lowering from the shadowy ceiling and Mermista started tapping her foot.

A deep, sharp ache panged in the center of Hordak’s chest, sudden and strong. He winced slightly and touched a few fingers to the armor over the pain.

“What is it? You okay?” Bow asked, just as nosey as the rest of Etheria.

He sighed before begrudgingly replying, “One of my hearts has been acting up. I may need to replace part of it soon.”

Before anyone could respond, Entrapta swooped down and landed on the floor next to him. “Your heart’s doing that thing again? Is the pacemaker helping at all?”

Hordak opened his mouth to reply but Mermista addressed him with a dramatic groan. “Ugh, how do you get her attention so fast? Every single time!”

“It’s a matter of scientific prioritization,” Entrapta said, pulling off a glove to feel his pulse. “He’s my favorite subject.”

“Entrapta,” Hordak murmured, willing himself not to blush.

She gave a tiny gasp and looked up at him with knit eyebrows. “Oh I’m sorry, is that one of those intimate things I’m not supposed to share?” she asked earnestly before looking back down at her stethoscope on his chest. “I thought I was just supposed to avoid our emotional closeness and sexual activities.”

“No,” he said hurriedly to cut her off. “No you’ve done nothing wrong, just… please change the subject?” He shot a glance over at the group of visitors, many of whom were now smirking. Bow and Sea Hawk both held clasped hands to their mouths and their eyes were round and glassy.

“Oh! Before we do, I forgot to ask,” Entrapta continued. Now he heard the mischief in her tone and scowled. “Since Angella is back, am I allowed to talk about how much I love you? Only when it comes up organically of course.”

“Entrapta!” he protested weakly, and he heard an attendant snigger.

“Oh, come now Hordak, let the woman speak her truth!” He looked up in time to see one of the royal aides transform into Double Trouble before they continued. “I, for one, wouldn’t mind hearing a few juicy details from any of those topics.”

“Double Trouble,” Hordak acknowledged, giving them a venomous glare. They edged slightly behind Mermista but kept smirking.

“Ugh, would you stop disguising yourself?” asked an irritated Mermista. “You don’t have to hide anymore, you know.”

“Sorry darlings, force of habit.” They blinked and grinned. “I prefer to keep a low profile while I conduct character studies.”

“Who’s character are you studying?” Bow asked.

“Wouldn’t you like to know?” they asked, blinking again and grinning wickedly, sharp teeth glinting.

* * *

As Catra stood in the lab and enjoyed Hordak’s embarrassment, she glanced over at Adora. She’d found Catra on the roof, of course, and followed her to find Mermista. Mermista had already been neck-deep in princess affairs, ignoring Sea Hawk’s antics and talking fast with the people in blue robes that hurried in her wake. Catra had wanted to check in before clearing the road and Adora tagged along because she wanted to see Entrapta after many busy days apart.

When Adora wasn’t around during Catra’s free hours, she always checked to see if Entrapta was there. Much of this impulse was grounded in guilt over her horrible betrayal, but underneath that, she’d also missed her friend. After the years they’d spent at the Fright Zone, Catra hardly noticed the behavior that still seemed to annoy and confuse many of the princesses. She couldn’t understand why, though. They were all pretty weird on their own terms, and in much more boring ways. At least Catra could depend on Entrapta for a good time. And besides, the mad scientist never did blow her up in all the hours they’d spent together, so why worry?

Bow took mercy on Hordak and approached him and Entrapta, Adora at his side. Catra kept watching the room as she waited for Mermista to have a spare moment. Emily, who had forgiven her as easily as Entrapta had, made her noisy way over to Catra and waited patiently for a few friendly pats. As she ran her hand over the robot’s cold metal surface, she cast a quick glance around the dark ceiling high above. She’d received undeserved forgiveness from everyone she knew, all except for Imp. He still *really* hated her. Catra trusted Hordak to keep him from doing anything too

heinous, but his sheer hostility unnerved her. Thankfully he was small and she was fast, but the little bastard could also fly and cling to bare surfaces.

She heard Mermista sigh loudly and turned to watch her approach. Several of her aides had broken off to discuss reconstruction affairs with Hordak, and she was glad to see they looked fairly at ease. Mermista seemed less exhausted too, after a successful week of construction.

"You're clearing that little trade route to the north, right?" Mermista asked. Catra nodded. "'Kay, I definitely had a note about that…" she said, looking down at a pile of papers she was carrying and rifling through them quickly. "Right," she said, pulling one out and placing it on top. "Usual presence of magical beasts and hazards, looks like your main problem is just going to be the scale of material that needs to be moved. A friggin mountain fell on this thing, apparently."

"I'm sure She-Ra's up to it," Catra said lazily, looking over at Adora, who was listening to an animated Entrapta.

"Cool," Mermista said vacantly, handing the note off to an attendant and returning her attention to her papers. "What's next… right. Desalination plant and freshwater aquifer." Without another word, she sighed and turned toward Hordak.

Adora, who was smiling gently, made her way back to Catra's side. They turned and left the lab quietly, Melog in tow, as the lively conversation continued behind them. "Ready to fuck this road up?" Catra asked her.

She giggled in her delightfully sweet way and answered, "you know it, killer."

They reached the end of the hall and were about to start climbing the stairs to leave the palace when Entrapta dropped out of nowhere and landed directly in front of them. Both Adora and

Catra squeaked and jumped backward, but when they saw Entrapta's worried expression, they kept silent.

"Sorry, sorry," Entrapta said. She gripped her fists together and Catra pressed her lips at the troubling sign. "I just had a quick question for Adora."

"That you couldn't ask in the lab?" Catra asked in confusion. Melog mewled in suspicion.

Entrapta ignored her and turned to Adora. "Not to alarm anyone, but I uh… I was wondering… have you maybe been experiencing… any strange symptoms? Anything unusual since we went to destroy that disc in the Northern Reach?"

Catra's stomach sank. This was it. This was exactly what the fuck she'd been worried about. "Like what?" Adora asked slowly.

"Anything. Congestion, blackouts, rashes…"

Catra and Adora exchanged worried looks. "Actually," Adora said with knit brows, turning back to Entrapta, "yeah. My scars have been itching ever since and… like, I've been kind of irritable." Catra half expected Entrapta to clap her hands in excitement at the mystery, but instead she swore and scowled. Catra and Adora exchanged another, more alarmed look. "Entrapta?" Adora began, "what's going on?"

"I don't know," the other woman said, shaking her head in frustration. "I don't know yet, but I'm working on it."

"Entrapta, what do you think is going on?" Catra insisted. Melog flicked their tail in annoyance at the scientist's evasion.

"Nothing I can't handle," Entrapta assured her hurriedly. "I don't for sure know any more than you do yet, and there's a big chance that it's nothing."

Catra knew she wasn't giving them the whole truth, but she held her tongue. Instead, she asked, "And what does Hordak think?"

Entrapta scowled again. “That’s actually something else I wanted to ask you. Could you guys not tell him? Not yet, anyway.”

“Why?” Adora asked in confusion.

“I’m worried about him,” she replied, clasping her gloved hands together again. “Obviously he’s had a lot to deal with, but since he got to Salineas it’s been even worse. He’s got so much on his mind and I really don’t want to dump more onto his plate.”

Catra gave Adora a dubious look, but the other nodded slowly. “We won’t say anything yet.” Entrapta let out an audible sigh of relief. “But you need to tell us what you know as soon as you can,” Adora added.

Entrapta nodded and turned back toward the lab, but Catra stopped her. “Entrapta?” she turned back and waited. “Are you sure there’s nothing we can help you with?”

Entrapta smiled, and looked more tired than Catra had ever seen her. “I’ve got this,” she assured them, before turning again and walking away.

* * * * *

The road that Catra and Adora were walking and talking on was a small wagon route that was obviously well-traveled until recently. The spire was already visible in the distance above the tree line. The colorful, pastoral scenery was nothing short of enchanting, but both wore intense expressions. Their conversation had grown serious as topics from their past came up. Now Adora was asking about Catra’s years in the Horde without her, ready to hear more

about what it had been like. Catra appreciated that she cared, but she was feeling tense and agitated.

She started talking slowly, trying to ignore the feeling of too-old sorrow that slowed her tongue. “You weren't just my best friend, you were... it. You were all I had. At least you had your career and seemingly endless success under Shadow Weaver. What did I have? I had nothing, nothing between me and finally being squashed out of existence. I had no choice but to prove I didn't need you if I wanted to survive.”

Adora hesitated, but argued, “you could have come with me. I wanted you to, so badly.”

“And abandon everything I'd been raised to be for everything I'd been raised to hate? Maybe that made sense to you, but it didn't make any sense to me. The horde was still the closest thing I ever had to home. I thought that's the way it was for you too.” She ran a hand through her hair distractedly. “And if you’d wanted to run away, I would have followed you. We could have run off and kicked ass somewhere else… but you never even considered it, did you?”

“You think I never thought about it?” Catra snapped her gaze back to Adora. She looked as agitated as Catra felt and her expression was utterly incredulous. When she spoke again, her voice was shaky. “Leaving all that behind and running off with you? Figuring out where we come from, going wherever we wanted, doing whatever we wanted…” Catra stared back at her with a slightly opened mouth, confused and so, so fucking sad. “I just… couldn’t. I couldn’t do it. I wouldn’t do it.”

Catra sighed. “I know.”

Silence stretched between them while they walked. Finally, Adora spoke in a quiet voice. “I didn’t have faith in you. I was wrong, but that’s the truth. That’s why I left you when I realized the horde was evil. And that’s on me.” Catra didn’t know what to say. “You proved me wrong, though. Like, really wrong. You were

better in the Horde than I ever was and you can match me in everything."

Catra narrowed her eyes at the ground. "I don't think you were wrong to not have faith in me. I've always been kind of an asshole, and I became a *major* asshole pretty soon after you left. I was done playing the sidekick and went straight to villain."

"Catra, there is so much more to you than the things you've done wrong. You make me want to keep fighting. Always have." Catra raised her eyes to Adora's and saw that they were overbright, though her voice had evened. "You're not my sidekick. You were never my sidekick. You're my reason for trying to be the hero you saw me as- even when that hurt and made me angry. You're my reason for fighting."

Catra knew she should be touched, but old wounds were distracting her.

"Tell me," Adora murmured.

"You know when you woke me up because I was crying, that first night after everything went down?"

"Yeah."

"My nightmare wasn't about Prime, it was about us. You were sacrificing yourself for some kind of bullshit, and you wouldn't listen. I was begging you to stop, but you just wouldn't listen to me. You told me, "we both know you don't matter."

"Catra… Catra I owe you my life." Catra gave her an incredulous look. "You sacrificed yourself to save Glimmer and warn us about Prime. He would have killed us all if you hadn't done that." Catra still wasn't convinced. "You've sacrificed so much to protect me. I'm not always clever, but I do understand sacrifice."

Catra decided to plow on, getting caught up in her emotions. They'd never talked about what had happened between them in the First Ones' temple when Light Hope had trapped them in their

most painful memories of each other. Now the grief and confusion and rage from that day came bubbling up inside her again. She had to fight to keep her voice calm. “That's just it, though. Sacrifice is kind of your thing. Sometimes it… sometimes it feels like you were willing to sacrifice everything to protect anyone. Everyone.. . everyone but me. And you promised.” Tears threatened and her voice broke. “We were supposed to look out for each other. But you left me alone with Shadow Weaver and Hordak. Even though you said they were evil, you left me with them.”

Catra could tell she was touching a nerve in the way Adora was swinging her arms as they walked, fists clenched. “I'm so sorry.”

“And like, I didn't even *want* you to sacrifice anything for me. I just wanted to be by your side.” Adora stopped in her tracks beside her and Catra turned to face her. Her jaw was set and her fists were still clenched tight. For a moment Catra thought she might hit her, but instead she wrapped her in a tight hug, holding Catra’s head against her shoulder. Catra couldn’t help let out a choked sob before she continued. “That's still all I want.”

“That’s what I want, too.”

Catra waited with her arms pinned to her sides for Adora to finish her hug. As the seconds lengthened, however, Adora didn’t show any signs of loosening her grip. “Um, are you going to let me go?”

“No.”

“Just… no?”

“I'm never going to let you go again. Never. Not unless it becomes spousal abuse, in which case I'll be legally obligated to.”

Catra was ready to move past their emotion swap. “You're sweet, but we do have a job to do.”

Adora let her go and stepped back, sniffing and wiping at her eyes. “Right, right.”

They started back down the road toward the spire to which they drew near. The dappled light shining down through the trees was yellow/green and bright. “So,” Catra said lightly, “we’re way too young to be making plans, but does that mean you want to be my wife someday?” she teased. Adora flushed and pushed Catra sideways, knocking her toward some glowing bushes.

As they rounded a bend in the road, they were suddenly upon the slide. Before them was a massive slope of bare dirt piled high over the road, a light fuzz of new grass brushed over the top.

“Got a plan?” Catra asked Adora, standing with a hand on her hip as she surveyed the ground before them.

A flash of light heralded She-Ra’s appearance before she answered, “same plan I always have.”

“Gorilla fuck your way straight through the center?” Catra asked, smiling.

“Yep!” She took several breaths, focusing for a moment. Then she wielded the sword around in front of her, leaving a large X of pulsing energy in the air before she reared back for her final blow. Adora started into a low groan that grew into an extended shout as she brought the sword down with all her body weight. A blinding flash of light took over her vision and a deafening roar filled her ears. The sound of rock and soil being blown apart shook the ground beneath their feet, and Catra felt a stab of pain in her upper arm.

She gripped the source of the sting with her other hand and kept her ears folded back while the dust settled and she regained her bearings. When she looked up again, she saw that the slope before them had been cut in half. A gigantic gash that reached down to the wagon road beneath had severed the huge landslide into two pieces. Rocks and little slides of dirt slid down the sides of the two mounds as they settled and Catra looked over at Adora, who was panting and smiling.

“Nice,” she commented, genuinely impressed.

“Thanks,” Adora replied in a breathy voice. She looked over at Catra and winked before she noticed that she was gripping her upper arm. “Did you get hurt?” she asked, brow furrowing.

Catra pulled her hand away to examine the cut beneath. It had probably been caused by flying debris when She-Ra had blown through the landslide, and it was deep. Blood forced its way between Catra’s fingers, too thick and slippery.

“Hang on,” Adora murmured, drawing near. She took several deep breaths before she reached out and lay her hand on Catra’s shoulder. Slowly, she began to glow with golden light. It spread until they were both glowing, but instead of the relief Catra expected, she felt an uncomfortable buzzing feeling seep through her body from where Adora’s hand rested on her shoulder.

Adora’s brow furrowed more and she frowned at Catra. “Hang on,” she said, closing her eyes and pulling a face. The glowing intensified and Catra started to get nervous.

“Adora, what- ah!” An intense burning sensation burst through her wound and she jerked away from Adora.

Catra lost her balance and fell over backward, sprawling on the ground. She gripped her arm again and looked up at She-Ra in confusion. She-Ra stared back, equally confused and twice as alarmed. “Wha… what happened?” she asked as the glow faded away. With another flash of light, She-Ra turned back into Adora and she sank to her knees in front of Catra.

“No clue,” she responded, looking back down at her arm and pulling her hand away again. The flesh around the cut now looked severely burned, even blackened in places. She moaned in pain and cupped her hand back over the wound, though she didn’t touch it again.

“Fuck!” Adora hissed, leaning toward her. She reached out, hands hovering over Catra, but she didn’t seem to know what to do. “I

don’t understand… I tried to heal you. I thought I had a handle on this…”

“You did fine with the road… do you think it’s the healing part that’s tripping you up?” Catra asked.

“I don’t know,” the other replied, distress apparent. “No, no, no, this is bad. She-Ra needs to be able to heal. That’s like… a super important part of what She-Ra does. She looked around herself in growing dismay and whirled back around to face the ground she’d just carved through. She took a deep, calming breath and waved her sword before her. Catra figured she meant to grow plants to hold the hillsides together, and the green fuzz on the uncut slide seemed to shiver. But then it turned yellow and withered away. She-Ra stared down at her hands. “No,” she whispered. She spun to face a pine tree and pointed her sword at it. This time Catra got to her feet and crept behind her as the other woman breathed heavily, focusing hard. With a deafening bang, the pine exploded into a cloud of whizzing wood chunks and splinters. Catra ducked behind She-Ra and avoided the shrapnel, but when the dust settled and she moved around to look at She-Ra, the giant warrior was staring into the distance, distraught. “She-Ra can’t heal right now. I… fuck.”

Catra scowled and thought about the other princesses, who were still nervous about the outside universe and took great comfort in She-Ra’s ability to protect them.

“Your arm,” She-Ra said, reaching a ginger hand toward Catra.

“Whatever,” she shrugged, trying not to upset her. “It’s not that bad, let’s just bind it and move on.”

“Are you sure?”

Catra smiled and glanced down at her upper arm again. It looked bad and it felt worse, but she shrugged. “I’d rather enjoy the afternoon and worry about it later.”

"Worry…" Adora said absently. "Catra, do you think this has to do with whatever Entrapta was talking about earlier?

She did, but Catra held her tongue. "Whatever," she repeated. "Where'd you put the bag? It's time we had a little chat with Entrapta." As Adora went to retrieve their communication pad, Catra looked down at her arm again. "You know what this means, don't you?" she asked Adora, a grin slowly spreading on her face.

"That we're going to be lying to our best friends even after everything we've been through together?"

"What? No," Catra pulled an incredulous face. "It means I finally have an excuse to get new clothes."

Comprehension dawned on Adora's face before an idea made her light up. "Oh my gosh, Catra… have you ever gone *shopping*?"

"Like with money? I don't think I've paid for anything in my life."

Now it was Adora who gave Catra a sly grin. "I am going to buy you all the thigh-high boots you can stomach."

Entrapta had arrived quick as a flash and given them a ride to the coast where the best shops were, listening intently to their description of She-Ra's problems. When they'd landed just minutes later, she dressed Catra's wound quickly and efficiently. She'd opted for strips of adhesive rather than stitches, and the three women talked seriously about everything they had up in the air and how much the princesses had to worry about. Catra was relieved when they both agreed with her that there was no reason to announce that She-Ra had lost her healing abilities. Not until they had to, at least. Hopefully by then the planet would be feeling a bit more secure. Catra was also surprised that Entrapta stayed focused and clear for so long in a conversation that wasn't about science. It made her think that Entrapta was more worried than she was letting on.

When Entrapta patted Catra's shoulder to signal she was done, she rolled her arm experimentally. It hurt like a bitch, but felt solidly bound. However, the bandage on her arm was large and obvious. The last thing they needed was for somebody who recognized Adora to start asking why she hadn't healed her girlfriend. Adora took off her jacket and handed it over for her to wear, and Catra was glad they were both about to update their look.

"Alright then," Entrapta sighed, rubbing her eyes with gloved knuckles. "It'll have to be our secret for now."

"Entrapta?" Catra asked, easing her bad arm into the jacket first. The scientist looked up at her and blinked her eyes into focus. "This is the virus, right?"

Entrapta chewed her lip for a moment, but nodded. She heard Adora let out an odd huff. "Something weird happened when the magic was released." She kept her eyes turned toward the floor. "I haven't seen anything like it since Beast Island. The nature of the virus has changed somehow, but… I'm having a really hard time figuring it out."

Catra decided to press her further. "It's affecting you this time too, isn't it?"

Entrapta looked up at her with a scrunched nose, but nodded again. "What's happening, Entrapta?" Adora asked.

"Nothing crazy, I'm fine," she assured them hurriedly. "I've just been noticing some weird stuff with my hair is all. It's not quite as easy to use as it used to be, but it's not a big deal. It might even just be me aging, you know. Maybe the war is finally catching up with me." She gave them a half smile that neither returned.

"And you haven't told anyone else?" Catra asked.

Entrapta shook her head. "No. No, I'm sure I can fix this before it becomes a real problem." Adora and Catra exchanged worried

looks. “I’ve got this. I’ve got this, so there’s no need to make things harder.”

Adora sighed and ran a hand down her face. Catra groaned, “I really don’t appreciate you making me lie to Hordak again. We like, *just* got past trying to kill each other.”

“Okay, well,” Entrapta hesitated. “Just keep doing that.”

“Easy for you to say,” Catra grumbled. “You don’t have to cover for Adora, who’s worse at lying and secrets as Scorpia is.” Adora stuck her tongue out at her and she shrugged.

Chapter End Notes

> For the record, I don't care what religious beliefs anyone chooses, so long as it's not about hate or fear. Whatever it takes to get through the night, you know? But with these stories, I'm throwing around my own predatory cult baggage, and there's a lot of it. Now, some of the finest people I've ever known were well educated, infinitely kind, and chose to practice Christianity. And that's fine.
> That being said, Prime's bullshit up top is modeled on the following Bible verses:
>
> Repent, then, and turn to God, so that your sins may be wiped out, that times of refreshing may come from the Lord, (Acts 3:19)
> Therefore, I urge you, brothers and sisters, in view of God’s mercy, to offer your bodies as a living sacrifice, holy and pleasing to God—this is your true and proper worship. 2 Do not conform to the pattern of this world, but be transformed by the renewing of your mind. Then you will be able to test and approve what God’s will is—his good, pleasing and perfect will. (Romans12:1-2)
>
> (Like I said, so long as it doesn't hurt anyone, believe whatever you need to in order to find peace. Just... remember that if you entrust your kids to religious

institutions, you can't protect them from what hunts them there.)

Ummm... sorry about the upsetting shit, I promise I intend to focus on mercey and love in the face of hard times, not blame and grudges.

If it's convenient and you happen to have a thought or opinion, I humbly request any feedback you've got. It is very much appreciated.

“You’re being more depressing than usual.”

Chapter Summary

> The first group of clones leave the nest at Bright Moon and the alliance spends some time hanging out. Entrapta finds something that makes her angry.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Wrong Hordak and Emily found Hordak working quietly in his lab and came bounding in with his usual peppy air. He’d settled into handing Hordak tools as he requested them, sitting on Emily and expounding upon his recent adventures with Swift Wind, Scorpia, and Bows fathers as they prepared to start helping the clones who felt up to it start carving spaces for themselves in the various kingdoms around Etheria. Salinas still wasn’t on the list of places that wanted any ex-Horde, whether galactic or Etherian, but even Mermista was hopeful that after Hordak achieved more in reconstruction, public sentiment would further soften.

“Have you seen all the colors in his wings? They’re so beautiful! And he can fly incredibly high for an air-bound mammal,” Wrong Hordak rambled good naturedly. “He and Scorpia sing often. They have made several attempts to include me in such activities, but our brothers and I are as of yet quite tone-deaf.”

Hordak repressed a smile at the thought of his younger brother trying to hold a tune. He enjoyed a few minutes of silence as Wrong Hordak seemed to mull something over. Emily shifted idly beneath him, though not enough to unseat him.

Finally, he said hesitantly, “Brother?” Hordak looked up at him and raised a brow to signal he was listening. “Swift Wind was telling me about choosing a name. He named himself after the swift winds of justice, a declaration of his convictions, as it were.”

Hordak waited for him to continue, but eventually prompted, "And?"

"And I was thinking about my name."

Hordak grunted. Again, silence stretched. Eventually Hordak set down his tools so he could turn his attention fully to his brother. "What about your name?"

"Does it bother you?"

"Your name?"

Wrong Hordak nodded. "It was your name first. You named yourself before any of us. I… I don't know that I have the right to take it on myself."

Hordak snorted and looked back down at his work. "Names are important, brother, but I do not consider my name to be my property. It formed with time and experience."

"But it's still *your* name."

Hordak folded his arms and tilted his head in confusion. "And as such, it is a name which is drenched in the blood of the innocent. I am not proud of it, but I must bear the identity I forged. But… you." He frowned harder. "Why would you want such a name? Why wouldn't you choose a name more befitting of your person?"

Wrong Hordak's face fell. "Oh… you don't think it suits me?"

Hordak heaved a deep sigh and took a moment to think about his response. "It… calls to mind certain characteristics that are incongruent with the man you are. Even as the prefix 'Wrong' declares you are not me, it also denotes that you were meant to be me. But I am the one who is all wrong." The more he thought about it, the more he appreciated how much he'd helped Entrapta in her missions, and how deeply committed he was to their brothers. "Brother, you are so much more than any connection you might have to me." Hordak took the liberty of resting his

hands on the other's broad shoulders. "You are *everything* I should have been."

Wrong Hordak looked back up at him with an earnest expression, his green eyes piercing. "But… I like that my name connects me to you."

Hordak scowled. "For light's sake, why?"

Wrong Hordak lowered his face again and his ears dipped too. "We… our brothers and I… we…" Wrong Hordak trailed off and made a frustrated sound, searching for the right words. "You did much evil for love of Prime," he said, "as did we." Hordak pulled his hands away from the other's shoulders and started shaking his head sadly, but Wrong Hordak continued. "And those decades you spent alone, truly alone," Hordak crossed his arms, still shaking his head. "You have been so much stronger than any of us would have imagined we might be. You are living proof that we- each of us- are people. Individuals capable of dreaming and struggling and achieving for themselves." He looked back up into Hordak's eyes. "We are proud of you." Hordak took a shocked step back and stared in utter bewilderment. "I am proud of you."

Without giving him time to react, Wrong Hordak stood and wrapped his arms around Hordak in a tight hug. He stood stiff and awkward, trying to blink away the tears forming in his eyes.

"Besides, it's what our friends have been calling me for more than a month now." An odd feeling zinged in his chest at the word 'our.' "It feels right, even if the meaning doesn't match me."

Hordak slowly raised his arms to hug Wrong Hordak back. "Very well, then." He said softly. "I would be honored to share my name with you."

After another couple of seconds, Wrong Hordak released him and sat back down on Emily, folding his legs and looking at Hordak's worktable expectantly, ears upright and attentive. Hordak picked his tools up slowly, but before setting back to work he said, "Tell

me about our brothers." He glanced back at Wrong Hordak one more time before started cutting lengths of wire. "Even as Prime's general, I only interacted with them through the chain of command, and the only person I was ever close to was him." He clenched his jaw for a moment but kept his tone light. "I think I'd like to know you better, now that you're free to be people."

"Now that *we're* free," Wrong Hordak corrected. "And we will tell you everything. Our brothers are eager to know you too if it is agreeable."

* * * * *

The next time the majority of the alliance were together in one place, reconstruction had been underway for several weeks. Most of what was salvageable in Salineas had been rebuilt, and several new construction projects were nearly finished, so even Double Trouble, Hordak, and Catra had the morning set aside so as to offer their support. The occasion that gathered them was an exciting one for many- the first group of clones leaving Bright Moon were about to make the journey to Plumeria.

Catra sat beside Melog atop the large transport that awaited the migrating group and watched Adora mingle. Queen Angella leaned on a cane next to king Micah, watching the assembled Etherians bustle hither and thither. Glimmer and Bow were going over a long list with Swift Wind and Wrong Hordak while Perfuma and Scorpia ran around like a couple of mother hens, checking in with various clones and making sure everyone they needed was there. Moonshine and Daisy followed them dutifully, taking notes and flitting about their brothers. Moonshine was recognizable for the silvery roots of his hair and glittering grey eyes. Daisy's eyes were

a much softer green than Prime's acid shade, which only Wrong Hordak still wore. His hair was also growing roots a similar blonde to Double Trouble's, and both clones had chosen new clothing. Both clones had opted for pale shades, but their tunics and trousers fit loosely, quite different from Prime's form-fitting uniforms. All around them in a sprawling crowd, Etherians and clones stood talking together. Kyle, Lonnie and Rogelio were there, as were Castaspella and Juliet. Bright Moon guards, shop workers, farmers, and everything in between were beaming and wiping their eyes, chatting excitedly to their clone friends. The hum of conversation was loud and bittersweet.

"Remember, you can always come back if you don't feel comfortable there for any reason," Glimmer said, shooing several clones back toward their group.

"And our portal system is up and running, so you can arrange a visit any time you like," Bow continued, straightening another's Horde uniform fussily.

Catra lifted the hand that was scratching Melog's blue mane up to the place on her other arm where a bandage rested beneath her jacket. The healing wound only hurt to the touch now, and was well-hidden by a new jacket. Catra rubbed at the fabric absently, reminiscing for a moment. The day they'd realized She-Ra had lost her healing powers, Catra had done everything in her power not to dwell on it. She and Adora had romped around the coastal shops like kids in candy stores, loudly commenting on the outfits the other tried on as they went. They'd tarried for hours, agonizing over colors and patterns, and Catra had nearly had a full breakdown over the leather shop with its boots, jackets, belts and bags. Adora had spent far, far too much money on her, and no matter how much she insisted that she was grateful for the opportunity, Catra felt like she still needed to repay the many favors.

She ran her fingers over the soft, dark red leather of her sleeve and peered back down at Adora, who had stuck with her familiar color palette. However, Adora was drone-shy after what they'd

been through with Prime, and had opted for a jacket that included a spacious hood to hide her face in. Her pants were a practical upgrade as well, featuring more pockets than their skin-tight predecessors. Adora hadn't wanted to, but Catra had convinced her to upgrade her footwear as well, and now she sported sturdy red boots that were far better suited to climbing and off-road adventures than her previous pair had been. After she'd fastened her little golden alliance pin to her belt, she looked much the same as she always had.

Catra had chosen new clothing as well. First were a pair of stretchy leggings in a shade of maroon she'd come to admire after befriending Entrapta. Then she'd ventured away from her customary bodysuit and opted for a black crop top that left her shoulders and waist free to movement. She'd had to explain to Adora - *again* - that she did too much stretching and bending to wear anything too skimpy without a tit popping out now and again. But the blonde had been mollified by the slip of midriff that now peaked between her top and her old pointed belt, to which she'd finally affixed her own wing-shaped alliance pin. After that, she'd found a jacket in a much darker red than Adora's, with a soft black lining. She too had chosen one with a large hood, though this was more for the purposes of remaining anonymous in public than any drone-related traumas. She'd also found a pair of fingerless black leather gloves that she couldn't do without, and *then* she'd moved on to footwear.

The clone Adora was talking with bowed low, then caught her up in a brief hug before moving on to another group of people. Adora's shoulders heaved with a heavy sigh and she looked around herself. After a few seconds, she lifted her gaze and found Catra on top of the transport. She winked, waved, and went back to mingling while Catra shifted in her seat, new leather boots creaking. They were her favorite part of her new outfit. With what Adora had said about her thigh-high leggings fresh in her mind, she'd enjoyed tracking Adora's reactions as she tried on pair after pair of leggy footwear. Some with open toes for her claws, some with heels for some extra sex appeal, all of them reaching over her knees. She'd deny it if she were ever confronted, but it had

been Adora's reaction that decided her final choice. Now she wore leather boots in shades of black and grey that reached halfway up her thighs, and were held up via straps that connected to her belt. She was still catching Adora in sidelong looks at her legs, and Catra was more pleased than she should have been that her other friends were throwing glances of their own. Glimmer in particular still sometimes glared at Catra's legs as if they'd personally slighted her.

Scorpia's attention, on the other hand, was entirely consumed by Perfuma. The two princesses were inseparable and may as well have adopted Moonshine and Daisy as their own, considering the way they doted on the brothers. But for all their softness and lovey-dovey nonsense, Catra was still a little rattled by the magic she'd witnessed Perfuma wield.

She'd found herself with a free afternoon one day in Salineas, hitched a ride with Entrapta, and had been looking for Scorpia when she found her sparring with Perfuma in an abandoned quarry. When Catra saw the two of them at it, she had finally understood why Perfuma had always refused to use her full power in battle. In the echoing emptiness of the stark quarry, she'd watched them dash around each other from afar, crimson lightning arcing around them. Scorpia, who'd disabled entire fleets of bots with a single touch of her claw to the ground, was grunting and panting with effort as she fought to whither every shoot of vine and root that came for her. Perfuma, who looked nearly weightless, moved as if she were dancing as she pranced about Scorpia, pulling her arms and body around in graceful arches and spins. It was beautiful and terrifying in equal measure, and Catra had quickly become entranced by their battle.

Swaying, twirling, leaping and landing, Perfuma was arrestingly beautiful as the living things around Scorpia mirrored her motions. The larger woman heaved and grunted as she answered with much heavier movements. She brought her claws around in devastating blows to the earth and pillars of green that Perfuma created, the huge muscles in her shoulders sliding and bunching with effort. Catra's eyes had still been trained on Scorpia when

she registered Perfuma's running leap in her periphery. Perfuma curled in on herself as she seemed to float through the air, hair trailing behind her. Then she landed in a crouch and with a strained grunt, lifted her entire frame with her raised palms toward Scorpia. Massive shoots of green burst from the ground and shot at the larger woman, too fast to react to. Catra was shouting and sliding down into the quarry by the time Scorpia was pinned tightly against the opposing cliff, but she needn't have worried. Perfuma squealed at the same time and hurried forward, waving her hands desperately to free Scorpia of her leafy bindings. As Catra had skidded to an awkward halt on level ground, the green tendrils holding Scorpia loosened their grip and lowered her gently to the ground.

The two women had convinced Catra to stay a while and train with them, after which Perfuma had gone on to other princess duties and she'd had a chance to catch up with Scorpia. The new princess of the Crimson Kingdom was in no hurry to retake her throne, it turned out. The Fright Zone was still radio-silent anyway, with no news coming in or out. The alliance had no contacts who could tell them what was happening there, so as a united front, they had decided to put out fires before launching new projects, so the Fright Zone had yet to be addressed.

The dramatic motion of Swift Wind's wing moving through the air caught Catra's eye when the obnoxious beast wrapped it around Wrong Hordak, who was apparently getting emotional. He leaned into Swift Wind and produced a tissue to blow his weird little nose into, patting the horse's neck affectionately. He looked around himself, up at a nearby hill and waved. Catra followed his line of sight to see Hordak standing on the slope, observing from a bit of a distance in his old black cloak, looking as grim and dour as he ever had. He raised a hand in response and nodded to Wrong Hordak, who smiled in return and went back to hugging Swift Wind.

She glanced back at Hordak's solitary figure once more before scanning the meadow for any sign of Entrapta, but she was nowhere to be seen. She squinted back up at Hordak, who simply

stood on the hill, stone-faced. In a few simple motions, she'd leapt from the transport and skirted the crowd on her way toward him, Melog right behind her.

When she approached his side and drew to a halt, she rested a hand on her hip and waited for him to speak first.

He eventually did. "Catra."

"Did Wrong Hordak make you come?" she asked. '*That's what they said* ,' she added silently to Melog, who narrowed their eyes at her and flicked their tail in annoyance.

"Several of my brothers requested my presence," he corrected mildly, still looking at the others below them rather than at her.

She studied his face openly and considered asking him about Entrapta outright. But at the moment, he seemed completely closed off, cold and aloof, and she didn't expect him to volunteer any information willingly. "So have you been, like, bonding with them?"

He nodded stiffly. "I have had several conversations with several brothers, yes."

"Uh huh." She sighed, thinking. "And how has that been going?"

He finally looked her way, frowning down at her. "Why the sudden interest in my personal affairs?"

"I'm fucking bored," she said to Hordak, *'just go with it,'* she added to Melog.

He sighed but didn't press the point. Then he seemed to wilt a little, and when he spoke again he seemed a million miles away. "I suppose some part of me hoped I might find a sense of belonging in their midst."

"But that didn't happen?"

He didn’t answer immediately, still watching people milling about the transport. “I think I missed my chance.”

“What do you mean?” she asked, pretending she wasn’t starting to be scared by the pattern among her peers.

“Maybe if I’d lived a different life… maybe if I hadn’t been made a general…” his voice was quiet and slow. “They belong to one another. It’s palpable.”

Catra nodded slowly. “But you’re not part of that?”

He shook his head. “I belonged to Prime, and then I was my own. I do not feel at home in a collective.”

His voice sounded hollow and achingly sad. “But they’re still your brothers,” she said uncertainly.

“Of course they are my brothers,” he answered, then stalled, seemingly uncertain of how to continue.

“But?”

“But… there is… I am separated. There is a permanent chasm between us that cannot be undone.”

Catra nodded slowly. “And does that bother you?” Hordak gave her an incredulous look that was a clear suggestion to fuck off. Melog stepped forward and nosed his hand, making him jump badly and withdraw his hand as if it had been burnt. Catra sniggered. “Yeah, emotional honesty is kind of their thing.” Hordak gave her an appalled look. “It’s a pain in the ass, I know, but what are you going to do?”

“Yes,” he growled, but with none of his usual venom, “it does bother me, I suppose.”

Catra didn’t let him off. “You’re being more depressing than usual.” She narrowed her eyes at him. “Are you alright? You seem… I don’t know.”

He frowned down at her and for a moment he was the forbidding Lord of the Fright Zone. But the moment soon passed, and once again she was again looking up at the tired, defeated man she'd come to know and tolerate. With eye contact especially, she could see what Entrapta had meant. He was barely there, it reminded her of how he'd been after she'd sent the scientist to Beast Island. No wonder she hadn't been hanging around him. If Adora had been such a miserable bummer, Catra might not like being around her either.

"Whatever. You don't have to talk about what you don't want to."

"Thank you for your clemency," Hordak said, a hint of his old bitchiness edging his tone.

Catra left him to it and started toward Adora. When she heard a disgruntled "what?" she looked around and saw Melog sitting and staring at Hordak intently, who was scowling back.

She chuckled to herself and left them to it, wading back into the crowd toward where Adora was watching Bow's dads saying goodbye to a handful of clustered Etherians, a few of whom clearly resembled Bow. She realized they were some of his siblings as she recognized a loose, family-looking group around the scene.

"Remember to take lots of breaks," Lance said as he watched four of his children split away and join the line of clones headed onto the transport. "And don't be afraid to take things slow with projects that are intense for you. No need to kill yourself over things that are over now," he laughed nervously and clutched his hands together in front of him just like Bow did.

George put a hand on Lances shoulder and called out, "Your father and I are happy to help whenever you needed, just let us know,"

"Yes dad," a woman with small antlers responded patiently.

“Keep in touch!” Lance shouted. Bow put his hand on his other shoulder as Lance teared up.

“This is nothing new, guys. They’ve been out of the house for years,” Bow reminded them.

Lance caught Bow up in what looked like a very tight hug. “It’s never easy to say goodbye to your babies!” he sobbed.

“Bow’s got a big family, huh?” Catra asked Adora.

George answered her. “We had the means, so Lance and I ended up adopting quite a few little ones after they were orphaned by the war.” Catra’s stomach clenched, but there was no malice in his tone.

She turned to Adora and changed the subject. “Are people really calling them space bats?” She asked once they were in a slightly quieter spot.

“Sure, why?”

Catra groaned in exasperation, throwing her head back. “That’s fucking stupid,” she whined.

“What do you mean it’s stupid?” Adora asked defensively.

They had to stop talking and shield their eyes for a moment when the transport lifted into the air and began to make its slow way toward Plumeria. When Glimmer clustered them together to take them back to the palace, Catra looked up to see if Hordak was coming, but he was gone. He’d probably left as soon as he could do so without hurting Wrong Hordak’s feelings, knowing him. Melog was also gone. They were likely off doing their own thing, but part of Catra hoped that they were still giving Hordak a hard time.

Glimmer brought them directly into the Dining room where lunch was already laid out, and Catra continued her discussion with Adora while everyone chose seats. “I was just being sarcastic

when I called Hordak a bat monster. It was mostly because he skulks around in the shadows like an overgrown bat all the time."

"Are you freaking blind?" Adora asked. "What about the Horde symbol with the bat wings? Their stumpy little noses? The flappy ears and the fangs? The way they like the dark and cuddling up and sleeping together? Come on, Catra. Of course they've got something to do with bats. Don't be dumb."

"I feel like Etheria is projecting local notions of cuteness on them," Catra protested.

"I feel like you're being a contrarian."

Catra scoffed and clutched imaginary pearls, affronted. "Contrarian? I'm just saying it's a reach."

"How is it a reach? Everything about them says humanoid bat beast." Their friends were all politely not looking at them while they sat down, bickering.

Catra shrugged in a way she knew infuriated Adora and said, "whatever. I can roll with it."

Adora made a frustrated sound and stewed while she took her first few bites. Then she paused, smiled wickedly, and cleared her mouth before speaking again. "You know what you're being?"

Catra knew exactly where Adora was going and put her fork down, glaring dangerously. "Don't you dare."

"You're being a…" Adora began teasing.

"I'm serious Adora," she growled.

"Being a sssss…"

Her voice was raising with her temper. "Adora!"

"You're being a sourpuss."

“I will set this fucking building on fire,” Catra shouted at Adora as the entire table broke into laughter. Adora was already laughing so hard her eyes were watering.

Glimmer and Bow appeared with three clones and sat down across from Catra and Adora. “What’s the joke?” Glimmer asked curiously.

Catra cut in before anyone else could. “Are these the three sciency clones I’ve been hearing so much about?” she asked Bow.

“Yes,” he answered brightly, looking over at the brothers. Before her, one Clone was growing roots in a slate blue similar to his skin, and his eyes were a soft blue to match. Another sported eyes in a soft yellow and his roots looked to be a bright shade of pink. The last’s hair was still growing stark white, and his eyes were startling. They’d gone dark blue, nearly black, but flecks of bright blue glowed throughout the staring orbs like stars, and the overall effect was kind of creepy.

“Anything we can call you?” Adora asked pleasantly.

“I have chosen the name ‘Truth’” the clone with the soft blue eyes and blue roots said. “In service of Horde Prime, I worked with his various ships and vessels, and will be working with Bright Moon on establishing a space-worthy martial presence. My brother here,” he placed a hand on the yellow-eyed clone’s shoulder, “has not found a name yet. He worked with teleportation technology.” Truth looked over to the clone with dark eyes, signaling his turn to speak.

He cleared his throat politely, reminding Catra of Hordak’s stiff, formal manner. “I installed the cybernetics in my brothers during their developmental stages.” Catra felt the atmosphere chill noticeably. “You may call me Mushroom.”

“Mushroom?” Adora asked in apparent confusion.

He nodded. “I admire the noble fungi.”

“Has he seen Erelandia?” Catra muttered to Bow.

“Weelll,” Bow said, glancing over at the clone in question. “We’ve decided to wait on that. Mushroom can be a little… intense.” Catra looked back at the dark-eyed clone, who was staring at her with a blank expression. She busied herself with her food so as to avoid his gaze.

The clones didn’t eat much, they finished even before Catra and Adora, then excused themselves to go plan how best to use the emptied section of the clone camp.

"I'll be there soon," Bow called after them. Truth waved cheerily in acknowledgement. Bow turned back around and looked at the table in front of him, brow furrowed.

"What?" Mermista asked, eyebrow raised.

He shook his head. "Just thinking about the clones." This time Glimmer looked sideways at him with a raised brow. She elbowed him lightly in the ribs and he sighed. "And Hordak," he admitted.

Catra rolled her eyes and could practically feel Mermista do the same while Micah and Castaspella came and sat in two of the seats the clones had just vacated. “Honestly I’m surprised you've chummed up to him so hard,” Mermista shot at Bow. “Weren’t you still like, mad at him for trying to kill your girlfriend?”

To everyone’s surprise, Bow scrunched his face up and rubbed the back of his head. “What?” Glimmer asked, cocking her head.

“That’s actually something I’ve had to think about a lot,” he began haltingly, looking around at the others. “I… I hated him.” Catra totally got it, but even so it was strange to hear Bow say he hated anything. It was a very strong word coming from him. “You’re right Mermista, I hated him.” Mermista didn’t look entirely comfortable either. “Especially when I saw him move to kill Glimmer twice when she was already down and hurting.”

“Bow,” Glimmer muttered, placing a gentle hand on the other’s shoulder. Catra heard Micah’s knuckles crack as he clenched his fists in his lap.

Bow started shaking his head, and it seemed like he was sorting out his words as he said them. “I actually hated a person with all my heart. I hated him so much it was exhausting.” He sighed and shrugged. “But now, after everything with the clones… I don’t know. Maybe I’m crazy, but I kind of feel like I’m the asshole for hating him in the first place.”

“Bow,” Catra interrupted, “you’re not the asshole. Hordak… uh, Hordak and I are absolutely the assholes in that situation. In this situation.” She felt Adora’s hand slip into hers and squeeze lightly.

“I get what you mean, though,” Glimmer said, her voice still unusually soft. “Sometimes I still kind of hate him when I think about the war.” She lowered her eyes and seemed to grow distant for a moment. “There’s this one scene I can’t get over, I think about it a lot. You were all there, too,” she said, looking around at them. “Well, not you guys,” she added to Micah and Castaspella, “but it was when we’d just finished evacuating everyone we could see from Salinas and people were crying and bleeding…” Mermista crossed her arms tight and her mouth twisted. “...and I made eye contact with him when he was standing way up on that dumb rock… and he *smiled.*” Glimmer looked around at them and chuckled bitterly. “That shithead smirked at me, and I... I just can't forget that face above the flames.”

Catra lowered her head in shame and felt Adora squeeze her hand. “And yet…” This time it was Castaspella who spoke softly, and Catra saw that she too had a hand resting on Micah’s shoulder. “I'm having trouble reconciling that man with the Hordak who seems genuinely horrified at how wrong he’s been his whole life.”

Mermista shook her head and sighed. “I would never have believed he had any conscience if it weren't for the truth spells. Not in a million years.” Bow even nodded that time.

Micah spoke up next. “Yeah... yeah, I still think about that a lot.” He looked a little embarrassed but continued. “I don’t doubt that he’s sorry, I trust the truth spells worked, but… it just seems so sudden, you know? Decades of seeing us as animals for slaughter, but Prime up and dies and suddenly he cares that he hurt people?” Catra sensed a sudden burst of chilly anger come off Adora and turned toward her in surprise. She was glaring at the table and her eyes were overbright, and Catra immediately knew what the problem was. “I guess I just don’t get it.”

“No,” Catra interrupted, trying to focus on modulating her tone to keep it light and approachable. “You don’t get it.” She looked around at the serious faces of her friends and squeezed Adora’s hand harder. “None of you here could ever get it, and you should be grateful that you don’t.”

Adora wiped a tear away angrily and tucked her chin further. “Adora,” Bow began, “are you upset?”

She made a frustrated sound before replying. “Yes,” she thought for a moment, swallowing and struggling for the right words to explain. “I’m upset because I believed it all too, okay? She wiped her face angrily again and pulled her hand from Catra’s grasp so that she could fold her arms tightly. Everyone in the vicinity besides Glimmer and Bow looked shocked and worried as Adora sniffled. I swallowed *all* the bullshit, hook line and sinker. I *never* questioned the morality of my actions,” Catra recognized Perfuma’s words and realized they’d upset Adora more than she’d noticed. “It took Bow and Glimmer talking at me for *hours* and then watching a village get destroyed right in front of me before I could believe we’d been wrong.”

The others in the room now looked uncomfortable and somewhat guilty. Micah was rubbing his arm with his eyes lowered. “Not everyone is in a position to see through the bullshit on their own,” Catra offered with a shrug, and the tension eased somewhat. “Just… just remember that you don’t get it, okay? And you’re lucky for that.” Several people nodded.

In the ensuing silence, Sea Hawk's voice carried over them as he tried to make conversation with Wrong Hordak. “So, what’s it like, being around your prodigal brother now that he can remember his time away?”

Most of the table looked at Wrong Hordak when he stayed silent for several moments. He seemed to be considering the question seriously and furrowed his brows before speaking. “It is many things.”

“I bet,” Mermista said with a half-smile. “He’s a real joy to be around.”

“It is mostly sad.”

“Sad?” Spinnerella asked him. “For you or for him?”

“It is sad for me,” he said seriously. “He is often sad as well, but that is because he is Hordak.”

“Uh huh,” drawled Mermista, already bored of yet another conversation that was devolving toward a discussion of Hordak’s feelings. Catra sympathized. “And you’re sad why?”

“I am sad for him. We all had to suffer to become pure, but Hordak was created with an impurity that could not be cleansed. It’s why he came here in the first place, and brought Prime to the planet... I think he would have liked to call it home, had he been as lucky as I. It makes me sad.”

“Eesh,” Mermista grunted. "Really getting nailed with the Hordak stuff here."

Netossa spoke next. “It’s certainly darkly ironic.”

“He sought to be enough for Prime to want, as did we all.” His ears lowered slowly. “And after all that struggle, I have everything he ever wanted, and he believes that anything he'll ever have is more than he could ever deserve or hope to earn. He spent his

life fighting to be more than his mistakes. And because he fought so hard, he made sure he never will be. It makes us all sad."

"Seriously bumming me out there, dude," Mermista said, looking more sincere than usual.

"Hmmm," Wrong Hordak looked at the table and seemed to consider her words. "Myself as well," he finally declared, smiling again. He reached to grab several apples in his large hands. "I think I shall go find Swift Wind and repair my mood." He stood and turned to the table, then smiled and bowed to them before walking energetically from the room, smile firmly in place.

"Great small talk, babe," Mermista said to Sea Hawk, who shrugged helplessly.

"Good thing we've got Entrapta," Glimmer said.

"Good thing Entrapta managed to get through to that miserable prude," Catra corrected.

"He *is* a prude!" Spinnerella giggled. "I don't know why that strikes me as so funny."

Netossa replied, "I mean, look at the culture he comes from. So many of them are so weirdly innocent outside of their 'divine rivers made from the blood of infidels' song and dance."

"Not all of them," Glimmer muttered, looking sideways at Bow, who suddenly looked uncomfortable.

"What does she mean?" Adora asked in a concerned tone.

Bow grasped his hands in front of him and pulled a face. "Prime was just really, really bad," he said. Catra felt her face fall and she dipped her head.

"I overheard your dads telling you about… what was it.. envoys?" Adora prompted. Catra snapped her head around to look at her and she averted her face.

"Yeah," Bow answered, twisting his hands around each other, "and… and more. Prime was… he was so bad. I know you know," he said, looking over at Spinnerella, who was rubbing the back of her neck and whose eyes were shining with unshed tears. "But like… he had personal favorites, too, you know?"

"And his collections," Glimmer said. Her face had gone flat and she suddenly looked very tired.

Bow pulled her closer to his side and kissed the top of her head. "My dads and their people are collecting stories from clones as we speak and it's already becoming available to the public, if you guys want to know more," Bow said to the room at large, "But for now, how about we change the subject?"

The group shared an enthusiastic murmur of assent and several went back to eating.

"I'm honestly surprised how well they're doing," Mermista said, her tone determinedly light.

Catra let out a breath she didn't know she'd been holding. "Holy shit, right?"

"I am so, so proud of them," Bow said, brightening back up.

"And they're soooo sweet," Spinnerella cooed. Netossa looked over at her fondly."

"And helpful," smiled Glimmer. "Are you guys glad we got the clones?" she asked, "Because I'm really glad we got the clones."

Everybody nodded in general agreement.

Catra snorted. "Some of them are really taking freedom on for all it's worth. Sort of inspiring, in a way," she said.

"I've already heard rumors of clones that fell in with the pirate community who could give Etherians a lesson or two in

hedonism," Sea Hawk said in his 'juicy gossip' voice. Mermista rolled her eyes.

"I could see it," Netossa said thoughtfully, "some of the clones certainly have it in them. They're capable, I'm sure."

"And," Mermista said, "haven't you guys noticed some of the clones are like, with *each other* ?" Her expression was unsure.

Catra spoke up on this point. "Hey, I saw where they come from, what their existences were like. Identical DNA or not, I'm not holding whatever they did to survive against them."

Bow nodded in agreement and the others made faces of concession.

"Hordak's certainly getting it in," Netossa said, smirking at her plate.

Catra rolled her eyes as discussion turned back to him *again* . "Fucking Gross," Mermista muttered at the same time Catra made a sound of disgust.

"And you *know* if Entrapta's fucking Hordak, then there's bound to be other Etherians shacking up with clones out there," Adora said.

Bow made a funny sound. "What?" Catra asked.

"I don't know how I feel about that," he said, making a worried face. "They're just *so vulnerable* , you know? I don't know how to feel about Etherians putting them in that sort of situation."

"People gonna people," Catra said simply, shrugging. "And the clones are full-grown adults, uninformed or not."

"And stop clutching your pearls, Bow," Glimmer chided. "Of all people, *you're* one to talk." Bow sputtered back in horrified indignation.

"True," Catra said, grinning with mischief, "you're certainly sympathetic toward Entrapta's attraction to a certain seven foot bat monster."

Bow let out an affronted grunt of protest as Glimmer laughed outwardly at him. But Mermista then drew their attention as she lurched away from Sea Hawk, who was stroking his moustache thoughtfully. "Ew, Sea Hawk! Sea Hawk, *what the fuck*?!"

"Oh come now Mermista dearest." She stared at him with shock and disgust. "Darling, light of my life, sweetest of my joy. You can't mean that you're completely untouched by their love story?"

"He murdered my people," she hissed dangerously.

"But you don't think the depths of his love for her aren't just the tiniest bit endearing?" he asked with a duplicative expression.

She threw up her hands up, speechless, and Sea Hawk didn't push it for once.

"I'm with her," Catra muttered into Adora's ear.

"That may be," she answered from the side of her mouth, smirking as she teased, "but you can't pretend you still hate him."

Without thinking about it, Catra opened her mouth to retort 'that's because he *knows,*' but no sound came out. It wouldn't. She shut her mouth and swallowed in frustration and shame. To make things worse, Bow and Glimmer seemed to immediately know why.

Catra blushed in further embarrassment and Adora pulled a face. "Crap. I'm sorry, Catra, I know it's complicated."

She shrugged and folded her arms tightly against herself, tapping a foot and looking down at the table. "It's fine, nobody's fault." When conversation continued to stall, awkwardly, she excused herself, scooting her chair out as quietly as she could. "I'm just gonna take a break and go find Melog. I'll find you again, soon,"

Catra said, looking at Adora. She seemed disappointed but understanding as Catra turned to go.

She'd only taken a few steps, however, when she registered what sounded like an argument in the hall beyond, growing slightly louder as she paused. Her first thought was Micah and Angella, but no, the voices were wrong. Conversation petered off behind her as other people heard what she did and she swiveled her ears, listening hard. All of them realized at about the same time that what they were hearing was a heated discussion between Entrapta and Hordak. She didn't know about the others, but Catra had never witnessed a truly angry Entrapta before, and hearing her raise her voice at Hordak was unnerving.

She looked back at a room full of people who were instantly uncomfortable, and she heard Entrapta say loudly, "...moderation for sustainability's sake!"

Bow started whistling, Mermista started drumming her fingers on the table, and Spinnerella started humming, all blocking out the argument and preventing Catra from eavesdropping. After just a few more seconds, the sounds from outside ceased and the people at the table followed suit. Tense silence hung in the air until the doors to the Dining Hall burst open with a loud bang.

Entrapta, cheeks flushed with frustration or anger, stood before them all, shocked to see a room full of people. She slammed her mask down and stood still, fists clenched, breathing hard. Catra exchanged confused glances with the others as they cringed collectively.

"You know what?" Entrapta finally said quite loudly. She flipped up her mask and threw her hands in the air. "Fuck it!"

"You okay Traps?" Catra tentatively ventured as the small woman started shaking her head and pacing.

"No!" She shouted and whirled about, a manic gleam in her eye. "Hordak's been, uuuuuurgh," she broke off for an angry growl and

shook her fists before her violently. “He… would you believe…”

“Entrapta?” Bow asked, concern all over his face.

Entrapta finally stopped pacing and glared at them, fuming. “I just ran across Hordak’s search history.”

Chapter End Notes

Sorry these first three chapters are slow, but I wanted to check back in with our other characters to see how Reconstruction is going for them.
If it's convenient and you happen to have a thought or opinion, I humbly request any feedback you’ve got. It is very much appreciated.

"Pain for pain is justice."

Chapter Summary

> The gang finally finds out what's been eating Hordak, and Hordak finally finds out what's been eating Entrapta.

Chapter Notes

> If it's convenient and you happen to have a thought or opinion, I humbly request any feedback you've got. It is very much appreciated.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Entrapta finally stopped pacing and glared at them, fuming. "I just ran across Hordak's search history."

"Woah!" Catra blurted, stepping back. "I do *not* want to hear about…"

"Hundreds of hours of interviews," Entrapta continued over her.

"No no no n… wait what?" Catra cocked her head in confusion.

"Those stories that the historians and ethnographers have been recording and putting up?" They all exchanged looks and nodded. "He's been listening to everything from Salineas!"

"Oooh, that cannot be good for a person," Glimmer said, cringing openly.

"*Hundreds of hours*!" Entrapta repeated at a shout.

"For fuck's sake, why?" Mermista asked, and she seemed genuinely alarmed.

"He says it's part of his responsibility to his victims!" Entrapta started off pacing again, gripping her pigtails distractedly. "It's sucking the life out of him and he absolutely refuses to cut back!"

“No wonder he’s been so miserable,” Catra muttered, raising an eyebrow at Adora, who grimaced. She tried to ignore the little sting of guilt over not having watched more than a few minutes here and there herself, but they were difficult to sit with.

“Uuuugh,” Mermist groaned loudly. “Alright folks, we’re the backup.” She rolled her eyes and heaved an annoyed sigh, “I actually need Hordak to *not* die of ennui before he finishes rebuilding my kingdom.” She stood up and brushed crumbs off her front wearily. “Where is he?”

“Probably back down in his lab,” Entrapta said, starting to calm. Bow, Glimmer, Sea Hawk and Adora rose to follow Mermista.

“Spinny and I need to head home to handle a couple of things. You can find us there if you need us.” Netossa called. Micah and Castaspella also made discrete exits

Entrapta made to follow the crowd, but Catra threaded her fingers through a section of her hair to catch her attention. To her surprise, Entrapta spun around looking angry, cheeks still pink as she demanded, “*what*?”

“Woah, okay- for one, I wanted to check on you because you seem pretty upset,” Catra said, putting her hands up in surrender.

Entrapta opened her mouth, but paused. Then she closed it, gulped, and Catra was further confused to see a shine of tears come to her eyes. “I was pretty mean to Hordak just now, and it’s definitely something I’m going to have to deal with later.” She screwed up her face briefly and muttered, “*stupid.*”

“And, second," Catra continued, using a softer tone, "I wanted to check in on the whole virus thing and-”

Entrapta spoke over her, angry again. “I told you not to worry about that,” she said in a loud, clipped voice. “I *told* you I’m handling it!”

Catra was genuinely shocked by how very unlike herself Entrapta was behaving, all while still being very much Entrapta. It was starting to unnerve her, and she grew more uncomfortable the longer she talked with her old friend. "I mean, sure, yeah, but don't you think it's a little hypocritical to be mad at Hordak for being shifty?"

For a moment, Entrapta looked like she might do violence. Instead, she slammed her mask down, spun on her heel, and stormed off toward the kitchens. "Fine. I'll tell you for the umpteenth fucking time, *I've got this*." She kicked the door open when she reached it and stomped out of sight, pigtails dragging.

Catra stood for what felt like minutes in shock, staring after Entrapta with her tail slightly bushed. Whatever Entrapta might say, Catra was getting very worried about her, scared that for once she might not, in fact, 'have it.' She eventually shook herself, however, and turned around to walk down to the cellars, taking her time and thinking hard.

When she stepped through the sliding doors to the lab, she saw that Hordak's back was turned and he was leaning heavily on a worktable. Her friends stood between them, frowning with many shaking heads and crossed arms.

"... and we never said that atoning for what you've done involves torturing yourself," Glimmer was saying.

"I am not torturing myself," Hordak growled, sounding like he was struggling with his temper as well. "I am *learning*." He whirled around, dramatic as ever, and glared at them, reddish eyes glowing a little brighter than usual. "I know you think that labor and resources in exchange for suffering will function as an approximation of justice, but I disagree. Pain for pain is justice," Catra saw Bow and Glimmer exchange an exasperated look, but Catra felt a thrill of discomfort and shrank back slightly. "So I will do the best I can do to feel the pain I have caused." He looked

into each of their faces in turn, ears up and assertive, fists clenched at his sides. “Because I am unwilling to suffer the same losses I caused for my victims, then acquainting myself however I can with their experiences is quite literally the absolute least I can do.” Catra felt her ears lower slowly.

“You can’t just steep yourself in misery like that. Even you deserve some respite every now and then,” Bow said patiently.

Hordak gave him a look that was positively disdainful. Then he crossed to the nearest screen and began tapping it, offering no explanation as he selected a file, found a point about midway through the recording, and started it playing. All the hair on Catra stood on end as the disembodied, peculiarly raspy voice of a little boy began to echo through the room.

“I went back for my mom,” the boy was saying. “I had to get her out before the soldiers got there.”

“Why wasn’t your mom running with the others?” the interviewer asked gently, in a voice that reminded Catra of Bow.

“She was deaf, so she didn’t hear the guns or the people screaming,” the little boy replied. Catra’s eyes opened wide and she felt tears well up. “That’s why we were together. My mom was doing chores and like I said, she couldn’t hear, and we were getting out, and then I heard a really loud noise, and then I don’t really remember, but it was really loud, and then it was all dark and there was lots of dust in my mouth.” The boy coughed lightly as if he could feel it there again. Catra’s ears were pinned back flat against her head.

“What happened then?” the interviewer asked, and their low voice also sounded thick.

“I was really scared of the soldiers, so I stayed really quiet after I saw my mom was dead.” Catra looked up at Hordak, who was glaring at the ground, a muscle in his jaw ticking. The terrible voice continued. “She was up, like, a little ways away in the

blocks, but I could see her face so I could tell. But... I'm glad she was there. I held her hand while I hid all night long. I knew it wasn't her anymore, but holding her hand made me feel better anyway."

Glimmer and Adora both held hands over their mouths, Bow looked tense, and she couldn't see Mermista's or Sea Hawk's faces.

"I stayed there because I had to hide from the soldiers, so I hid with my mom all night," the boy continued. "I tried to get out when it was light outside again but I couldn't, um, but I wasn't really that scared until I heard the fire. I heard it burn some other people who were stuck like me, and I started screaming because I was really scared again, and then my neighbors who had come back got me out before I got burned up. But the smoke hurt my throat and that's why my voice sounds like this."

Mermista turned around, looking angry and distraught with tears running down her face, and brushed past Catra as she fled from the room. A very upset looking Sea Hawk turned to follow her, but Catra caught his shoulder and shook her head, suggesting he give her space.

"What happened then?" the interviewer quietly asked.

"My neighbors helped me bury her and I went to stay with the people next door. They're very nice to me. And I bring mom flowers every week."

Hordak stopped the recording and folded his arms, standing tall and continuing to stare at the others, lip slightly curled. "I did that. I brought their home down on top of them. Do you think I deserve respite from the reality he cannot escape from? How well do you think I would absorb his story were I to walk away any time it got *too sad* ," he filled the last two words with venom, narrowing his eyes further until they were glowing slits. "I cannot truly take responsibility for something unless I know *exactly* what

it is, and I need the context by which to understand what I have done."

Ringing silence followed the end of his little speech and Catra wished more than anything she could just disappear. After long, dragging seconds, Glimmer cleared her throat to speak up. "That may be," she conceded. Adora and Bow gave her worried looks, but kept quiet. "And I won't argue that what you're doing is the responsible thing," Catra gulped, "but feeling all that is hard on a person, you can't deny it." Hordak raised an unimpressed brow and Glimmer continued. "Going through the material you're going through is an act of sacrifice, and you can't keep that up forever."

Hordak's lip curled again and Adora broke in. "Take it from She-Ra," she said, casting what looked like an apologetic glance at Catra, "if you want to keep giving, you're going to have to pace yourself."

Hordak didn't respond, simply stood and glowered.

"What about Entrapta?" Bow asked. Hordak's expression finally shifted slightly, uncertainty entering his face. "What you're going through affects her, and it seems to me like she could really use some emotionally stable friends right now."

Hordak heaved a sigh and wilted, taking them all aback. He gave the floor a morose look and said, in a shockingly meek tone, "I do not know what to do for Entrapta. I'm sure my mood has not been helping, but she won't tell me what's wrong. I am simply trying to do what I ought to."

"Hordak," Sea Hawk muttered, though he didn't seem to know what to say next.

"Look. How about this?" Glimmer said, taking a small step forward. "I can't give Entrapta orders, but by the power invested in me by the kingdom of Bright Moon and the Princess Alliance, I order you to actively maintain your emotional health. For everyone's sake."

“My emotional health?” Hordak repeated slowly, brow raised again.

“Yep, look it up,” Glimmer replied cheerfully. She put a hand on Bow’s and Adora’s shoulders. “Ready to go find Mermista?”

“To find the love of my life!” Sea Hawk declared, leading the way out of the lab. Catra hung back, ears low, eager to avoid facing Mermista’s grief.

“Catra.” She turned when Hordak said her name, loud but calm. He was leaning back against his worktable with his arms still folded, looking tired and worn as ever. “I like your new boots.”

She couldn’t help but snort. “Fuck off,” she muttered with a confused smile, and saw the corners of his mouth lift before she turned and left him to himself.

* * * * *

Hordak stood in silence for a very long while, thinking hard. He thought about what he’d just been ordered to do, about the hundreds of hours of unreviewed testimony that would no doubt multiply as he worked his way through it more slowly than ever, but more than anything else he thought about Entrapta.

He’d never seen her like this before, but he wasn’t entirely clueless as to what was going on. At one point in the Fright Zone, when he’d inquired about her stress levels, she’d made a passing comment about how he’d definitely know it when her stress levels got out of hand. When he’d questioned her, she’d grown uncharacteristically embarrassed and reluctantly explained something that she’d called ‘meltdowns.’ He’d been surprised and dismayed at the intense shame in her manner as she told him that sometimes, when she got too stressed or overwhelmed, she would grow more withdrawn and more focused, and if the spiral

wasn't checked she would eventually grow hostile. This, she said, was an indicator to watch out for, as it apparently suggested one of her meltdowns would likely soon follow. She described the process like some sort of involuntary transformation, as if she became some kind of cursed beast who preyed on those around her. At first it had struck him as ridiculous, but the way she'd warned him like she was saving him from her had disturbed him greatly. Saving *him.* From *her?*

She'd eventually given him a rundown of protocol should such an occasion arise, and he remembered most of it now. But everything about the situation still felt surreal and painful and was difficult to face. When he'd mentioned it that morning, she'd reacted with shocking anger, and he'd finally had to acknowledge the signs. She was too thin, too tired and so very stressed. No matter how she insisted that Beast Island had toughened her, he recalled what she'd said long before about being blind to such warning signs whilst in the middle of a crisis.

Hordak pinched the bridge of his nose, feeling a headache coming on. Then he walked to their bedroom to fetch his old cloak before making his way out of the cellars. He hoped his familiar walk down to the peers by night would be enough to clear his head a bit.

Indeed he did feel better as soon as he'd exited the palace and the sea air filled his lungs. He looked at the stars and took his time as he made his way downhill, over freshly re-cobbled streets and alleys, staying away from anywhere he could hear others or that was too well-lit. He still had his eyes on the sky when he stepped onto the wooden peer by the bay and walked slowly out over the water. He froze, however, when he lowered his gaze and saw none other than Princess Mermista sitting at the end of the dock with her back to him. He softened his footfalls as he took a few steps nearer, listening now to the soft sounds that carried toward him on the breeze.

Her head was in her arms and she was definitely crying. He hesitated, wondering if he should say anything to her. He had no

words to comfort her, but it felt cowardly to simply walk away. He sighed in resignation and took a few steps toward her, deciding that at least he could give her a chance to speak her mind, ignore him, or tell him to fuck off. In any case he wouldn't have to wonder about it all night.

He saw it when she heard him, shoulders stiffening. He closed the distance between them before speaking. "I am… very sorry for the pain you must bear because of me," he said from a few feet away. "I know that it's not enough…" he broke off when she jumped up and spun toward him, clenched fists out at her sides. As she stared at him with clenched teeth and tears running down her cheeks, he clutched his cloak about his throat against the cold night air and wondered if she was about to attack him.

"I hate you. And I'm never going to forgive you for what you did to us. I *hate* you! You don't deserve Entrapta, you don't deserve friendship, you don't deserve a millionth chance to change!" Her mouth twisted again and she covered her face with her hands, breaking back into a storm of crying.

"Indeed," he said awkwardly, trying and failing to think of anything he could offer or say.

Without warning, Mermista pulled her hands back into fists, wiped her face on the back of her arm, and stomped directly at him, chin down and eyes blazing. He took several steps back as she came at him, but to his utter shock and mild alarm, she wrapped him in an aggressive hug. Then she let go and stomped off without another word, leaving him to stand hopelessly confused in the coastal breeze, cloak flapping lightly. After she'd faded from view, he turned to face the sea and stood still, thinking. He stayed and looked out over the water for a very long time before he walked on.

It seemed that Hordak was not done with forced socialization for the night. He had made his usual loop and was on his way back to the palace when Adora found him, tracker pad in hand and looking sheepish.

"Hey, Hordak," she said, shutting the pad off and rubbing the back of her head. "Sorry to track you by your cuff and all," she said, not meeting his eyes. He looked down at the cuff he still wore in mild surprise. Not a single princess had ever tracked him like that to his knowledge, and had completely forgotten it was a feature. "But, can I talk to you? It's about Catra."

Hordak's stomach sank and he looked back up at her, guessing where she might be going with the conversation. He nodded reluctantly.

She didn't start talking right away, but worried her lip and shifted in discomfort. "I was thinking about what you said, about trying to feel pain you don't know first-hand?" He nodded again, but she only grew more agitated. "So, I know really bad things happened. Like, uh," she glanced up at him, "with Prime." He swallowed drily as she began to pace before him. "She keeps dropping hints that are terrifying, but she never wants to talk about it and it never seems like a good time to push." She still didn't meet his eyes but started gesturing as she spoke, brows furrowed. "And she says stuff like 'she doesn't want to burden me' but I feel like if I tell her that's nonsense it's like I'm not taking her seriously. But knowing what Prime was capable of and hearing rumors, and seeing how much damage she came back with…" she glanced up at him again as his own discomfort grew and he saw tears in her eyes. "The questions are killing me and my imagination is like, *always* in nightmare mode trying to anticipate what could be going on in her head. It's killing me. And any time it's mentioned she gets so upset and I don't want to hurt her like that," she sucked in a sharp breath and suppressed a tight sob, "and I feel like she would be angry if I tried to press the issue, but another part of me feels like I'm leaving her to suffer alone with these memories and I just... I want to know." She stopped in her tracks and turned to

him, finally staring into his eyes, tears brimming in her own. “I really really want to know.”

He swallowed and considered. He sympathized with both Catra and Adora, but while he wanted to help Adora understand, it wasn’t his story to tell. He decided to say what he could, but keep it limited to what he was sure of. “She fought as hard as she could when they were dragging her away. She fought the whole way,” he said, and Adora nodded. He thought for a moment before he continued. “I was not present for her reconditioning, but I attended her purification.” An odd little expression of consternation flashed over Adora’s face before she schooled it again. “I can only tell you that by the time I saw her again by the pool, she seemed... changed. She entered it as willingly as I did.”

Adora’s face crumpled and she hid it in her hands, suppressed sobs shaking her shoulders. It took a while, but she eventually regained her composure and pulled her hands from her face, wiping her eyes and sniffing.

“Adora?” he ventured. She looked up at him and nodded. “Might I suggest that you tell her the things you just told me, and leave the decision to her? I think she’d want to know how this is affecting you.” Adora looked down and seemed to consider. He thought of Entrapta and his hearts clenched. “Your insight has been quite… enlightening.”

She immediately knew what he was talking about. “Have you talked to Entrapta about what happened to you?” she asked gently. He pressed his lips together and shook his head. “I think maybe you should ask how she feels about it. That might be enlightening, too.” She gave him a watery smile and he bowed slightly. “Can I hug you?” she asked abruptly.

Hordak sighed, annoyed, but raised his hands up to his shoulders, giving her the room she’d take anyway. He held his stiff position while she hugged him briefly, and nodded to her again when she waved and walked away. He waited for her to put some distance between them before he followed toward the palace.

* * * * *

Catra found Melog waiting in their bedroom and caught up with them while she waited for Adora. They mentioned the woman named Razz again and expounded upon the endless kinds of curious behavior they were witnessing around Etheria. They seemed to have a particular affinity for old people in general, and she promised them she'd help them talk to Micah and Angella about spending more time with elderly refugees. Weird, weird cat.

When Adora finally came in, she seemed tired. "You find her?" Catra asked.

Adora shook her head no. "Sea Hawk's gone to look around the grounds but nobody's really worried. She's a big girl and can handle herself." Catra nodded in vague agreement. "How are you feeling?" She looked at Adora, who was staring intently while she shed her jacket and white top. Catra shrugged and watched her drop her pants. "Did the stuff Hordak said upset you?"

"Only because I agreed with him," she muttered.

Adora frowned. "How so?"

She sighed, but tried to speak with honesty. "I don't know what people went through because of me. The closest I'll ever get is for me to listen to their pain try to feel it in myself, and I'm too much of a coward to even do that."

"Hmmm." Catra watched Adora pull her breast band off over her head and groan in relief when air hit her tits, marked with red lines from her support garment.

"And though I am loathe to talk about him YET A-FUCKING-GAIN, I'm really starting to notice how differently he and I are treated,

and I don't think I'm totally okay with it." After the complaint, Catra's voice grew quiet again. "I get that he did more than me, but I'm just as responsible for what happened at Salineas. And, like, I'm comparatively off the hook. I mean they're still having him wear that cuff thing." For some reason Adora winced and looked away. Catra ran her fingers through her hair distractedly. "I don't know what the hell is wrong with me," she looked back at Adora and frowned. "You and your friends broke my brain."

At this, Adora smiled and approached her wearing nothing but her underwear. "Anything to do with Hordak seems to really bug you," she said through her grin. "Do you think that maybe, *just maybe,* you're so bothered because you care?" She looked up at Catra from under her lashes with a wicked gleam in her eye.

"Dude, fuck you," Catra said loudly, playfully punching Adora's shoulder and trying not to stare at her breasts as she slipped her hands under Catra's jacket. Adora lifted it off and away from her shoulders and Catra shivered at the chill, nipples pebbling up.

"You care about Hordak and you *hate* it, " Adora smirked, moving to unbuckle Catra's boots from her belt.

Catra growled in frustration as she began to run her palms over Adora while she undressed her, though still quite caught up in the frustrating matter at hand. "I just can't *not* give a shit about that miserable old bastard." She stayed Adora's fingers at the waistline of her leggings, wanting to move on with their conversation before they went further with their hands. "I guess I just see too much of myself in him."

Adora snorted. "That's called empathy."

Catra paused, taken aback. "Oh yeah," she murmured, almost to herself. However, she only had a moment to think before Adora moved in and claimed her mouth in a firm, urgent kiss. Catra moved her hands up to hold the sides of Adora's waist, and Adora stepped forward between Catra's spread thighs.

“Melog, you know what to do,” Adora said without looking away from Catra. Melog meowed in affirmation and teleported their way out of the room.

The light was low and the air was chill in their seaside bedroom, but their beds and bodies were burning. Adora cupped her hand behind Catra’s neck and started leaning her backward, bracing her other hand on the low seat beneath Catra as she bent forward. When she sought access to Catra’s throat so that she could press gentle kisses to the flushing skin there, Catra sucked in a deep breath. “Why so intense?” she asked, feeling a little dizzy.

Adora paused for a moment, then whispered her reply against the side of Catra’s neck. “Guess you just bring it out of me.” She pressed another couple of kisses down Catra’s neck. “Regardless of how we move forward,” she cajoled, dipping her tongue into the hollow above her collarbone. Catra felt a flutter in her gut and slid her hands around to Adora’s abdomen, “we’re pretty good at making each other feel better.”

Immediately the little boy’s tortured voice replayed in her head. “…holding her hand made me feel better…” Catra jerked away from Adora, nearly toppling backward off her short stool.

“What?” Adora asked, snatching her hands away and straightening immediately. “What did I do?”

Catra was already shaking her head. “You didn’t do anything,” she assured her hurriedly. “It was me.”

Catra kept her eyes on the ground, fighting back tears and trying to think of anything other than the boy.

Adora slowly lowered herself to kneel before her, putting her hands gently atop Catra’s knees. The footstool was so low that even sitting on her heels, Adora was about level with her. “What happened? Prime?”

Catra shook her head. “That kid… I just… I just remembered that kid.”

Adora stayed silent. When Catra chanced a glance up at her, she saw that her brow was furrowed and she was staring at one of her hands. Catra felt an unbidden tear slip down her cheek and turned her head away.

"Is there anything I can do?" Adora eventually asked in a quiet, gentle voice.

Catra snorted out of sheer bitterness and squeezed her eyes shut. "You've already done everything. So much more than I deserve."

"Catra," she said, raising a hand to touch her cheek and turn her face back toward her. "Don't say that."

Catra took a deep breath and regained control of her tears, steadying her voice. It was much more her habit to avoid the things that threatened her, but suddenly she had to know. She *had* to. "How…" she tried to begin, but the rest of the words caught in her throat with a small choking sound.

"Take your time," Adora murmured.

She squeezed her eyes shut against renewed tears. "How can… how…" she cleared her throat and tried again. "How can you still love me?" Her voice cracked, and she finally looked back into Adora's eyes, searching for the truth. "How can you love me after what I've done?"

"Catra," Adora breathed, then leaned forward onto her knees and wrapped Catra in a tight hug. She clung to her in return, rubbing her face into Adora's shoulder. Adora pressed a tingling kiss to the top of her head and began to stroke her back in slow, soothing strokes. "I love you so much."

"How?" Catra repeated, voice still muffled against the other's shoulder. "I've caused so much harm. So much pain."

Adora shook her head and held Catra tighter. "I don't care." Catra made a small whine of confusion but Adora shook her head again. "I don't." She pulled back and held Catra's shoulders while waiting

for eye contact. When she finally looked up, Adora continued. “I know you. You have a good heart, and you’re so strong, and I love you so much. Other people love you too. You’re worthy of love.” Catra took a deep breath, trying to calm herself down again. She had a hard time believing Adora’s words, but they were soothing all the same. Her eyes were on the ground again but Adora kept talking. “I love you, and I want you. I’ll always love you.”

Catra rubbed her cheekbone against Adora’s shoulders a bit more, her heartrate slowing as she did so. When she looked back up at Adora, who still held her tightly in her arms, she smiled down at her and leaned in to gently kiss her eyelids. “I love you too,” she murmured when she opened his eyes again.

“I know you’ve got a lot on your mind,” she whispered, brushing the backs of her fingers along Catra’s cheek, “but please… please stay with me. In my arms. In our bed.” They kept looking into each other’s eyes as Adora murmured, “I’ve got you. You are safe and you are loved.”

Catra knew she didn’t deserve it. She knew in her very bones that she could never deserve such tender, generous grace.

When she rested her head back against Adora’s shoulder and nodded, she smiled down at her again, kissing her forehead. Then she rose slowly, pulling Catra up with her. Once they were both standing, she swooped, caught Catra up behind the knees and shoulders, and carried her to their little bed.

She guided them both down and turned them so that they were on their sides, facing each other. Catra scooted up closer and Adora snuggled up close, arms folded against her naked chest. A low purr started up in Catra’s throat and Adora hummed into her hair, still stroking her back in slow, soothing motions. After a while, Catra shifted her arms against Adora’s breasts so that she could spread her palms over the smooth skin there. A familiar, tantalizing thrill of anticipation flickered in her core.

Adora hummed into her hair again and Catra felt her smile. She allowed herself a small grin of her own and moved a hand down to stroke the smooth, warm skin of Adora's abdomen, then around to her waist. She kept her hand on Adora's waist for a few moments, unsure if either of them was ready for more. Eventually, she slid palm hand down to Adora's hip and squeezed it gently before scooting her hips up closer than ever to Adora's.

"You know exactly what you're doing," Adora muttered into Catra's hair.

"Maybe," Catra teased quietly, squirming against Adora.

When Adora let out a small chuckle, Catra looked up at the other's smirk, lower lip between her teeth. As soon as she was settled, Adora hooked a finger beneath her chin, tilted it up so that they were face to face, then pressed her mouth against Catra's for a long, gentle kiss.

"I love you," she whispered when Adora pulled back to take a breath.

"I love you too, Catra. More and more every day."

They wrapped their arms around each other and tangled their legs in a close embrace while they kissed. First, the kissing was gentle and sweet and coaxing. Soon, however, Catra felt Adora's tentative lick against one of her lips and opened her mouth for her lover's eager entry. They massaged their tongues together languidly, making small noises into their open-mouthed kiss as they ran their hands over each other's heating skin.

When Adora pushed her tongue deeper into Catra's mouth, a low moan escaped her. Adora growled in response and squeezed Catra's hips, growing more excited. Adora drew back and pressed their foreheads together. "Say my name," she whispered.

"Adora," Catra breathed, tilting her face so she could brush her lips against Adora's.

Adora took a deep breath and moved her hands around to Catra's ass, gripping hard. Catra gave a little gasp and groan. "Say it again," Adora muttered in a strained voice.

"Adora," Catra whined.

Adora dove back into a ravenous kiss, plundering Catra's mouth, with heady abandon. She pulled Catra's hips hard against her own and ground against her, rolling her pelvis with strong, fluid motions.

Catra let out an open-throated moan and raised her leg to hook around Adora's thigh, eliciting more fervor from her mouth and another hum of approval. Zinging thrills flickered through Catra's stomach when Adora slid her hand up and down her leg, hoisting it further up over her hip. As their energy and eagerness mounted, Catra felt throbbing blood flow burning in her loins, sending miniature shocks of pleasure through her stomach in time with her heartbeat and Adora's tongue in her mouth.

When Adora ran her hand up Catra's inner thigh, toward her core, she shivered and gasped lightly. "I want to touch you," she whispered against Catra's mouth, pulling back just enough to make eye contact.

Catra nodded desperately, already chasing the pleasure Adora was tracking her toward. Catra reached her mouth again with her lips and found Adora's hand on her inner thigh. She twined her fingers with Adora's and slowly dragged her palm further up her inner thigh, leaving an exquisite trail of fire over the delicate skin there.

"So soft," Adora breathed, kissing her way over Catra's cheek and onto her ear. She dragged the tip of her tongue out the outer edge, eliciting flicks and twitches form the fuzzy points. When she drew the very tip of one between her lips and nibbled lightly, a stifled moan escaped Catra and she shivered in Adora's arms. "So beautiful," she muttered, finally moving the hand at the apex of Catra's legs, palming her sex gripping lightly.

She gasped and jerked, clinging to Adora's shoulders. She felt herself slipping out of the thinking present, buffeted by sweetest, turbulent sensation as her lover trailed the tips of her fingers along her dripping slit, toying with the fluid gathering there. Catra felt her breathing grow heavier and less controlled, sharing each other's gasps and desperation. The thrilling process left the heady atmosphere of unthinking need in the air all around them, electrifying their breaths and touches.

When Adora slid a finger between Catra's swelling lips and drew it up to circle her clit lightly, she threw her head back and groaned. "Yesss," Adora murmured behind Catra's ear, grinding her hips against her own hand so that Catra could feel the movement in the fingers sliding through her wet folds.

"Inside," Catra pled, tucking her face against Adora's chest and shoulder, lost in the delicious energy between them. "Please."

Adora slipped the very end of her middle finger to press against Catra's entrance, pausing to push on the tight opening there. Catra let out frustrated little wines as Adora teased her, circling the tip of her finger around and around, pushing against the tightness in the ring of flesh there. Finally, she dipped the finger in further, past one knuckle, then two. When her finger was thoroughly buried in Catra's slick heat, she curled it forward and stroked back out, watching Catra arch her back against the bed below her with primal hunger all over her face.

Adora leaned in to lightly nip against the corner of Catra's jawline, whispering words of love and praise against the sensitive skin at the top of her neck. "More?" she eventually asked beside Catra's ear, who nodded wordlessly, helplessly addicted to Adora's heated touch. Adora drew her finger out of Catra and paused for a moment, then slid two fingers back in, stretching the tender flesh around her entrance with a supremely satisfying, filling sensation.

Catra's moan was consumed when Adora moved up to cover her mouth in another hungry kiss. She kept drinking in every noise that escaped her lover as she began to pump her fingers, in and

out, pressing her fingertips against the bundle of nerves on Catra's front wall.

As Adora began to grind her hips in time with her thrusting fingers, Catra snaked both arms around her torso to clutch her close, open mouth pressed against his collarbone and eyes shut tight in rapture. When Catra moved one of her hands around to Adora's front and slid it lower down her belly, a tight little noise of need escaped her and hit Catra like a whole new high. When she dipped her own fingers between her hot, wet lips, Adora's breath caught in her throat and she grunted against her teeth as if she were in pain. Catra hooked her chin this time, lifting her face for eye contact when she withdrew her thoroughly drenched fingers, raised them to Adora's mouth, and slid them in between her lips and onto her tongue. She accepted Catra's fingers willingly, and she felt her own eyelids flutter with overwhelming lust as Adora's tongue licked her own taste from Catra's fingers.

When she began to lose control and sink into the oncoming wave of pleasure Adora was kindling between her legs, Catra withdrew her fingers from Adora's mouth and went back to clutching her shoulders. Adora pushed on a shoulder with her free hand and rolled forward so that she was on top of Catra, still pumping her fingers and hips with mounting force.

"Let me watch," Adora cooed over Catra, and she opened her eyes to Adora's swimming visage, her own expression twisted against the accumulation of pleasure within her. Several more moments passed as they moved together in time, growing more in tune with their bodies and motions while Catra crested her summit.

With a strangled sort of keen, Catra tipped the edge and plummeted into bliss, shivering and bucking her hips while Adora kept fucking her with strong, practiced fingers. For a few perfect seconds, Catra existed in bright white pleasure, simultaneously solitary and everywhere as relentless waves of pleasure washed through her.

When Catra came to, Adora was pressing gentle kissed all over her face and neck, smiling faintly and panting, beautifully flushed and tousled with a slight sheen of sweat. After Adora pressed a final kiss to her lips, she pulled away and gazed down at Catra in adoration. She grinned in return and growled, "My turn."

With that, Catra pushed up against Adora and rolled them over, clambering up the bed so that when she rolled back, Adora lay with her front toward the ceiling, shoulders resting against Catra's chest as her warm hands trailed down her front. Before Adora had quite got her bearings, Catra managed to hook both her legs around Adora's thighs, pulling them apart and locking them there. If she'd wanted to, Catra could easily have put Adora in a full nelson, but instead she began petting and stroking, squeezing and purring as Adora tested her grip. She had Adora pinned, however, and hitched her legs up around Adora's upper arms to secure her further before sliding a hand down her shoulder, onto her chest. Adora whined and arched against Catra's palm as she kneading her breasts, enjoying the new angle and twiddling Adora's nipple between her fingers.

Catra kept reveling in Adora's breasts until her lover's hips were rolling again before moving on, watching from her fabulous viewpoint as Adora's nipples grew harder and pinker the more she played. When Adora was properly panting, breathing her name between desperate little moans, Catra lowered a hand to slowly run down the center of Adora's belly. "So soft," she repeated lightly as she felt the layer of impossible luxury give beneath her fingers and slide over the hard bumps and ridges of muscle beneath.

"You too," Adora muttered, eyes closed and armed raised around Catra's neck and shoulders.

She finally reached Adora's crux and felt drunker than ever with Adora's answering cry. She knew her own slick was currently painting Adora's lower back, but the friction felt so good that Catra couldn't keep her hips from grinding against Adora's naked

body as Catra began to stroke her dripping lips with feather-light touches.

Adora's pleasure built quickly, both of them caught up in the intoxicating richness of each other's body, the female scent on the air, the beautiful, breathy cries combining in sweet harmony within the evening quiet.

Catra's own heartbeat pounded in her ears as she listened to Adora's mounting cries, her body writhing sinuous and beautiful in her arms and between her straining legs. She had excellent access and leverage in this position, and she took advantage of the fact, driving Adora onward mercilessly and getting swept along in her passionate wake.

Catra couldn't stay away from the place where Adora's neck met her shoulder, kissing and licking and nipping the skin there obsessively. Catra reached her other hand down to Adora's core and Adora began to release a little cry with every thrust of her fingers. "Adora," Catra moaned beside her face, teeth braced against the exquisite span of muscle between the top of Adora's arm and the base of her neck.

The softness of her skin, the sweetness of her voice, the beauty of Adora's pleasure- it was all too much for Catra, who finally lost control and gave herself over to basic instinct. She allowed herself to sink her fangs into the top of Adora's shoulder, not even registering her lover's cry of surprise and alarm, completely caught up in the slaking of long-dormant instinct.

Adora screamed when Catra's teeth broke skin, but the scream morphed into a strangled cry of release and extasy as Adora's entire body arched and spasmed with the intensity of her orgasm. Catra even cried out in joy and delight as she literally rode Adora's climax from beneath, voice muffled by the flesh between her teeth.

After a while, their breathing started to calm and Catra realized what she had done. Immediately, she unlatched her jaw and

pulled away, staring in horror at the bleeding bitemark on Adora's neck. "Fuck," she whispered, placing her hands over her mouth. "*Fuck*."

"What?" Adora asked, though she was already touching the stream of red on her neck.

"I'm so sorry, I didn't mean to bite that hard," Catar muttered from behind both fists, raised to press against her mouth as she resisted mounting distress.

Adora brought her fingers away and looked at the red there, then bit both lips and looked up at Catra from beneath lowered lashes. "Honestly?" she asked, and her voice was low and somewhat raspy from their loud fucking. "I think I'm into it."

* * * * *.

The moment Hordak entered the lab, he knew something was very wrong. Several chairs were knocked over, tables and desks were askew, and it looked like a fair few pieces of machinery had been thrown against walls with significant force. He heard a weak whistle from the corner and turned to see a distressed Imp curled up on Emily, who did not approach him. He crossed to them cautiously.

"What happened?" he asked. Imp opened his mouth and he flinched at the sounds of agonized combination of screaming and sobbing, punctuated by crashes and bangs. Imp shut his mouth again and uttered a low chirp. "Did Entrapta do this?" he asked in confusion. Imp nodded and pointed toward the bedroom door.

He patted Emily a few times before he walked away, growing more concerned by the second. He opened to door gently and looked around, but Entrapta was nowhere to be seen. He did not call for her, but checked for her in nooks and crannies in case she was hiding from him for some reason. Finally, he walked through the archway that lead to the bathroom facilities, again carved directly into rock. The lanterns inside had not been lit, but it was the only place she could be.

He saw her as soon as he entered the dark room. She had discarded her overalls and armguards, but her hair was up and she still wore her white bodysuit. Entrapta huddled in the corner of the shower area while water fell from the holes drilled in the stone ceiling, soaked through and weeping softly. He hurried to turn up a lamp and she started, glancing up at him through bloodshot, red-rimmed eyes. She looked utterly wretched as she met his gaze before putting her head back between her knees and crying harder. He approached her slowly, removing his cloak and registering that she was running her nails up and down her shins, scratching them bloody. Once, when he'd asked about the scarring on her legs, she'd tried to explain it, saying that it helped her calm down when she couldn't get ahold of herself.

He draped the cloak over her back and shoulders even though the water fell continuously, and gently took her wrists in his hands. When she pulled them away he let her, and settled into sitting against the wall as water rolled down his face, waiting for her tears to slow.

The crying continued for what felt like a very long time before he heard her start gulping and holding her breath periodically, trying to stem the sobs. A while after that, she tried to speak a few times, but it took another several minutes for her to finally croak a few words to him, lifting her eyes again. "I fucked up, Hordak," she said in a tortured murmur.

"We'll handle it," he responded just as quietly.

She shook her head slowly. “I fucked up really bad, and I can’t figure out how to fix it.” Her voice broke again and a thrill of anxiety shot through his chest as he watched her and waited. “I’m so sorry. I’m so, so sorry,”

“Sorry for what?”

She sobbed several more times, her throat sounded raw and painful. “I’m sick, Hordak. I’m sick and I don't know how I'm going to get better."

Chapter End Notes

> Entrapta's struggle this chapter is based on personal input and experiences with loved ones. If I somehow did you dirty with my effort here, I apologize for any hurt feelings and request that you explain so I can learn.
>
> Stay safe and take care of yourselves, and remember that you don't have to forgive anybody for anything.

“...felt almost like respect,”

Chapter Summary

> Hordak keeps an eye on Entrapta while the princesses regroup. Catra runs into another wrong that needs to be put right.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“I’m sick, Hordak. I’m sick and I don’t know how I’m going to get better.”

As water continued to fall over both of them, the words hit him like the sentencing to some dreadful punishment, filling him with gut-wrenching, panicky dread. Even as he commanded himself not to jump to any conclusions, he felt his ears lower and his pulses rise. “What do you mean?” She buried her head back in her arms and shook it miserably, signaling that she wasn’t up to talking more. After a while, he changed tac. “May I relocate us to a more comfortable place?” he asked, staring through his under-eyelids as water ran down over his face. She nodded this time and he approached her slowly.

Hordak shifted to his knees next to her, touching her shoulder lightly and briefly. When he hovered both hands over her upper arms, she reluctantly reached out so he could pick her up off the ground. He lifted her against him as gently as he could as she curled in on herself as he carried her, both of them soaked through and subdued. He stood her up and turned her around so that he could squeeze heavy moisture from her hair. It remained totally limp as he did so, unresponsive to his ministrations.

She’d started shivering by the time he pulled the straps of her bodysuit over her shoulders and down off her body. It was then that he saw the fresh marks on her back and froze, staring. The scar from Catra’s stun baton looked like the wound had been

painful but wasn't especially severe. However, fresh scratches crisscrossed the area, accented by scabs and minor scarring.

"Entrapta," he murmured in dismay, tracing his dulled claws over the damaged skin. She shook her head and stayed silent.

He wrapped her in her softest towels, leaving his wet cloak crumpled on the floor so he could scoop her up and carry her to their bed. Hordak could feel that she was still fighting back tears as she gulped and tensed spasmodically. When he'd set her down, she curled into a ball on her side and fell back into strained sobbing. Meanwhile, he peeled his own clothes off and dried himself, uncomfortably exposed just one door away from the lab, but unwilling to leave her side. Once he was wearing a fresh dress, he crouched down next to her and leaned in close. "Take your time, I'll be here," he whispered, and kissed her head. Then he settled into bustling about the room, tidying up the mess Entrapta had left. He wished he knew how to help her, wished he could do something about the muffled sounds of hopeless frustration and despair that were being forced through her pillow.

But she'd told him. He knew. There was nothing for it other than getting it all out, which meant he had to watch her bleed.

When he was finished, Hordak lay down lightly next to Entrapta, facing her on his side. She rolled over and scooted up close, still crying silently, her face red and blotchy. He kissed her forehead and murmured, "I love you," into her drying fringe.

After a long time, she started sniffing again, burying her face in his chest as she did so. "I fucked up," she repeated quietly.

"Tell me," he whispered gently.

"I made us go get the tech from the Northern Reach."

One of his paranoid anxieties stepped into the forefront of his mind, very real and menacing. "Is it the virus?" He refrained from saying 'murder virus' but was no less horrified when she nodded slightly.

"It got me this time. I think it's making me sick. It's getting harder to use my hair and I'm *so* tired, all the time," she said. He nodded, thinking hard while she continued. "That dumb artifact was found in Dryl in the first place and I'm the one that insisted on studying it. I'm the one that kept it even after I knew it was dangerous. I'm the one that made us go retrieve it, even though it did *exactly* what Catra warned us it might." She sniffed hard and coughed, voice thick and strangled as she spoke against his chest. "And I thought for sure I could fix it, and I kept doubling down, but I couldn't figure it out. I can't figure it out!" She paused and gathered herself. "The more I told you I could do it, the harder I tried… but I just can't get it. I can't... I can't…" Her voice broke and she fell back to silence.

"Does it hurt?" he asked, and couldn't help a small sigh of relief when she shook her head 'no' again.

"But it's getting a little worse each day," she said, and his hearts constricted. "I'm so sorry, Hordak. I'm so sorry," she sobbed.

"It's okay," he soothed her, shushing her and stroking her head softly. "It's okay. We can work together to beat this now. It's okay."

When she'd cried herself to sleep and he'd tucked her in under all her covers, he left quietly to soothe Imp and Emily and clean up the lab. "Imp, Emily," he called. Emily stomped forward from the corner slowly, Imp perched on top, and Hordak crouched so that he was nearer their level. "I'm going to go sit with Entrapta, but I think you two might want to wait a little while before you check on her." Imp nodded solemnly and Emily beeped. "Everything is okay, you didn't do anything wrong, Entrapta's just overexerted herself and needs rest, alright?" Hordak insisted, mentally checking off his list of Imp's usual anxieties. "She'll be happy to spend time with you once she's gotten plenty of sleep." Imp

nodded again and Emily beeped before she turned and made her way from the lab.

The wreckage from her breakdown was hardly critical, especially by Hordak's standards. He found the work was quick and easy as he mulled over Entrapta's situation. After hearing Entrapta's communicator ping sporadically the whole time he was there, he retrieved it from where it had been thrown at a wall and noticed that she had about a dozen unread messages from Mermista alone. He was wondering if he might be able to lessen Entrapta's workload when Mermista appeared on the cuff he wore.

"Hordak, do you know where Entrapta is? I can't get ahold of her and I'm starting to get worried," she said in a rush.

"She is sleeping at the moment," Hordak said, reluctant to compromise Entrapta's privacy with more details.

Mermista immediately followed up with, "Is she okay?"

He frowned. "She is… feeling unwell."

She swore loudly. "It's my fault," she claimed, looking distressed. "I know she's been stressed, but I was upset, and we argued, and I pushed her too hard, and-"

He interrupted her. "Whatever fault is yours; it is but a factor in her condition. She has been feeling unwell for some time."

Mermista groaned into her palms. "Fuck, I know she's been going through something. We've all been worried." She dragged her hands down her face and looked back at Hordak, eyes bloodshot and tired. "What can I do? Is there anything she needs?"

Hordak was gratified to see concern shown over Entrapta, but he didn't have the information she needed. "I'll ask Entrapta what she wants, but I'm going to let her sleep first."

Mermista nodded and sighed heavily. "Keep me in the loop," she said before the feed cut.

Now that the screen was open, he saw that Entrapta had quite a few unread messages from others as well. It looked like she hadn't opened any new notices from the day before, and he could see messages from Bow, Perfuma, Catra and Scorpia. He turned the communicator off and placed it on a worktable, then set a scrap bot to sort and retrieve whatever little pieces had broken off the things Entrapta had thrown.

He was looking around the lab to see if there was anything else to attend to before he checked on Entrapta again when the communicator on his cuff went off again. When he opened the call, Catra's face met him on the screen. "Hey Hordak," she said, "do you know where Entrapta is?"

"She is sleeping," he answered.

Catra frowned and looked at him with worried eyes. "How's she doing?"

Hordak clenched his jaw and sighed. "She told me that the virus is affecting both Adora and herself. She told me she's sick and getting sicker." Another thrill of terror sent an ice-cold sensation through his body.

Catra sighed wearily and rubbed at her face and hair with her hands. "Fuck, I know lying is like, some kind of trigger for you or whatever," she looked back up at Hordak and he kept his frown firmly in place, "but she's one of my best friends and you know how this loyalty shit works." He huffed in begrudging acknowledgement as she seemed to consider his words before looking back at him from the communicator on his cuff. "Look. I get why you might not trust me, and that's fine, but I need to make sure she's okay."

Hordak relented and deflated. "She has overworked herself," he admitted. "I wasn't paying enough attention, and I didn't notice how difficult it was becoming for her to-"

Catra interrupted him. “Shut up, Hordak. Just worry about what you can handle, not what you missed." She rolled her eyes. "You and Entrapta both, fuck,” she muttered before a quick sigh. “Alright, well, I’m not trying to wake her up or anything-”

“Good.”

She raised an eyebrow but continued as if he hadn’t interrupted. “-so I’ll be around later,” she finished, a little louder.

They both nodded to each other before she ended the call. He waited a few full seconds in the rare silence before he moved, trying to gather himself.

Before he reentered the bedroom, he stilled and shut his eyes, trying to take a moment for focus. He wanted to be whatever Entrapta needed him to be, but he felt spent and thin from the day’s arguments over so many… *feelings*. He knew, however, that he needed to stay sensitive for Entrapta’s sake, and leaned his forehead against the door wearily. Hordak took a long, deep breath before shaking his head, squaring his shoulders, and quietly returned to their bedroom.

Entrapta lay on her side, facing him with red, puffy eyes. He let out the breath he’d been holding in a long sigh. “Is there anything I can do for you?” he whispered, sounding more emotional than he’d meant to. She shook her head and he rose to retrieve something soft and warm for her to wear before returning to her side. Once she’d donned her oversized shirt and snuggled back into the blankets, he swept his claws over her forehead with a gentle caress, brushing her fringe back. She grabbed his hand as he did so and pulled it against her face, turning into her pillow and hiding behind it wordlessly. “Do you want to maintain some space, or-” Hordak began, but Entrapta was already shaking her head again. Instead, she reached for him, face still turned toward the floor, and dragged herself onto him as if she were climbing between so much machinery. He wrapped his arms around her small form and shifted on the ground so he could lean against the bed.

Entrapta wrapped her short legs around his middle and tucked her head beneath his chin, fisting her hands in the fabric on his chest. Her hair was still damp, and after a while, he felt fresh teardrops soak into his dress beneath her cheeks as well. He buried his pointed fingers in the roots of her hair and stroked her back gently, breathing deeply and regularly as he did so.

For a brief moment he stilled in nervousness as her hand ran up his chest and neck, but he relaxed as her gentle fingertips traveled on up to his ear. Prime had desecrated her habits with imitation, but he'd never quite been able to replicate Entrapta's particular brand of tenderness. The way she ghosted her palm against his cheek on the way to his ear was uniquely reassuring, and he felt the corner of his mouth lift.

As she gently toyed with the tip of his ear between her fingers, he reminded himself that they were together, they were safe, and they had everything they needed. He took some time to focus on calming his own anxieties, but when Entrapta cleared her throat to speak, she immediately had his full attention. "When my head gets like this," she started, "sometimes it's like… like I'm being held hostage by a malfunctioning computer."

Hordak grimaced. "That sounds utterly terrifying."

She sighed heavily. "It can certainly get weird sometimes." She fell back into silence, though she opened her mouth a few times as if she wanted to say something.

"What?" he prompted gently, hoping he wasn't pushing her.

The fingers on his ear slowed but didn't stop entirely. "Just… trying not to get lost in my thoughts." He nodded. "But… all I can think abo-" her voice broke, and she was unable to finish the sentence for a moment. She hid her face against his chest while she composed herself then tried again. "All I can think about is *how fucking angry* at myself I am."

Hordak was taken aback. "Why are you angry at yourself?"

“Everything about this situation is so messed up, and it’s all my fault,” she repeated in a tortured whisper.

“We’ll handle it, it’s okay,” he said, trying to reassure her.

“It’s so stupid. And I’m so, *so* mad.” His confusion rose again as she dissolved into frustrated noises and angry crying.

Hordak scowled at the floor, thinking hard. She wasn’t giving him much by way of explanation, but it seemed to be all she could do to give voice to anything she was feeling. “I don’t understand,” he confessed, and she started gulping and sniffing again. “Why didn’t you tell me?”

“Because I was humiliated!” She sounded as angry as he’d ever heard her.

“Why? How?”

She made a frustrated little growl. “I’m fully aware that I’ve been acting strangely, but *I can’t make myself stop*.” He screwed up his face and buried it deeper into the hair at the top of her head. “I couldn’t handle my shit... guess I just couldn’t handle my shit…” she muttered distractedly. “Then I go and throw a full-blown tantrum, complete with throwing things and screaming like I’m a *fucking* toddler.” Hordak nearly flinched outwardly at the vitriol in her words, and had to fight the urge to interrupt her to contradict her claims. He knew, however, that these disjointed thoughts weren’t coming from a place he could approach with logic alone. “Science is like, my *only* thing. I can’t fail my friends at science, not after all this time.” She shuddered through a brittle sigh. “It’s so embarrassing,” she repeated miserably. “I let it get too bad and then I freaked out on the people around me. I’ve been acting like a… like a crazy person.” The last two words oozed bitterness. “I’m so sorry,” she hissed before a sob. “I’m *so* sorry.”

"Hush now, Princess,” he murmured against her head. “You have nothing to apologize for, nor is there anything to be embarrassed by.”

She shook her head even as she hid her face against his chest again. “I don’t even have the vocabulary to talk about these things. I feel as handicapped as I’ve ever been, and it’s so frustrating! It’s normally not a bad thing at all,” she argued, seemingly to herself. “Normally it’s just different. Just different. But sometimes… like now, I get stupid, and I don’t do the things I-”

This time Hordak did cut her off, his mind flashing to Catra momentarily. “Enough of what we might have done better,” he suggested in the quietest voice he could manage without whispering. “You just need to rest. You’ve done nothing wrong, it’s okay.”

“I left a mess in the lab and I did it all in front of Imp and Emily,” she muttered against his front.

“It has been handled. There was only minor damage. Imp and Emily are concerned for you, but otherwise they are perfectly fine.”

“I freaked out on my friends,” she continued.

He hesitated for a moment before he continued. “Several of your friends have reached out, actually.” She whimpered in dread. “They are not angry. Confused, yes, but their emotional reactions stem from concern for your welfare. You have not done permanent damage to your social ties.”

She looked up at him through watery eyes and frowned. “They aren’t mad at me?”

He shook his head slowly and stroked the back of a claw down the side of her blotchy cheek. “No one is angry with you, princess.”

“And… are you mad at me?” She narrowed her eyes and flinched slightly, as if preparing for an experiment to flash in her face. “After I kept saying nothing was wrong even though I was lying?”

He shook his head again and went back to stroking her hair gently. “I wish you had told me sooner, but I feel no anger toward you.”

“I did the science all wrong and messed everything up.” He resisted the urge to snort at the thought. “And… you haven’t taken being lied to very well in the past.”

He sighed and held her a little tighter. In fact Hordak was angry, but the feeling was thoroughly mixed with fear and confusion, and he didn’t yet know exactly who or what he was angry at. “What concerns me is addressing the issue at hand. The rest is of little import.” She seemed to accept his statement and tucked her face back down against him, falling into silence. Before she fell asleep again, he asked, “what would you have me tell your friends? Would you like to speak with them, or would you like more time to rest?”

She sighed, long and slow. “I don’t know, Hordak.” He buried his stumpy nose in her hair and ran his fingers through its roots. It hadn’t done more than shift and coil as it lay damp and heavy around her since he’d returned from the lab. “Right now I just want to sleep for a while, I think.”

He nodded and felt her shift in his arms, then watched her extricate herself and crawl back into bed. She curled up on her side again and he continued to sit on the floor, their faces close together so she could go back to rubbing his ear. It wasn’t long before her hand slowly fell to rest on his shoulder, and she began snoring softly. Again, he waited for a while to make sure she was resting soundly before leaving her side.

* * * * *

Catra scratched absently at the back of her neck while she listened to Mermista, looking down at her communicator where the princess's scowling face appeared on-screen. Mermista was worried about further upsetting Entrapta with her presence, but she wanted a progress report. She continued venting to Catra as she made her way down hallways and staircases, Sea Hawk making suggestions from behind her shoulder. "I don't believe I picked a fight with her while- I'm still talking, Sea Hawk- while she's being like this. Of all the stupid..."

"You weren't in a super rational place either," Catra reasoned. "We all say dumb shit when we get upset enough."

"Darling, there's nothing wrong with your mighty presence, but perhaps-"

"*I know*, Sea Hawk," she interrupted impatiently, then she groaned and leaned away from the screen. "What has even been going on with her? Has she said anything yet?" her tone was as flat and dragging as ever, but her expression reflected genuine concern. "What the hell could be happening that she won't tell us about? It's starting to freak me out."

"I have a feeling that whatever it is just peaked somehow. Hordak says she's getting some sleep right now."

"Maybe I should come down too… well, no… or… just let me know, okay? Please."

"Will do," Catra said before clicking off her communicator as she approached the sliding doors to the lab.

When she walked through them she found Hordak bent over a work table, as usual. He was absorbed in conversation, however, with Emily, who was facing him and beeping animatedly. "But if it were an issue with her immune system, it should be easier to map with bloodwork." He looked up at the sound of her entrance and scowled.

“Having a nice chat with Emily?” Catra asked, raising an eyebrow and smirking at him.

He grunted and focused on his work. “She is a helpful sounding board.” Emily beeped and whistled.

“How are things on your end?”

“Entrapta woke for a time but is asleep again, I am attending to my duties as usual.” His tone was clipped and efficient, but there was unmistakable strain showing at the corners of his eyes.

Catra pursed her lips and considered her next approach. “I’d imagine this is kind of tough for you, considering the whole thing with your health.” He didn’t react but his expression was starting to make her uncomfortable. It looked like he was barely managing a neutral mask over raging turmoil, staring at the wall to their side. “That fucking sucks.”

He lowered his head. “Indeed.”

She hesitated for a moment before tentatively trying one of Scorpia’s lines, “you okay, champ?” He waited for a long moment, staring into nothing, but then shook his head slightly. On impulse, she patted his shoulder a few times. “We’ve got a lot of people on our side for this,” she said softly. “Everyone is going to do everything they can for Adora and Entrapta. I’m going to do everything I can. We’re going to beat this.”

The corners of his mouth lifted slightly, and she stifled a sigh of relief. “Thank you, Catra.” He went back to using some kind of mini-welder thing and they shared another span of silence as Catra looked around at the various pieces of machinery and equipment around the lab. After a while, Hordak paused his work again and looked up at her. “And how is Adora? Is she sick as well?”

Catra shook her head. “Nah. It seems to be affecting her in a different way. So far old scars have been acting up and she’s being kind of a bitch, but it’s manageable.”

“At least you’re not unfamiliar with such behavioral patterns.”

Catra snorted hard, taking herself by surprise, and grinned at him incredulously. “Hordak, did you just make a joke?” she asked.

He huffed and frowned. “I did not intend to. I was merely noting your tactical advantage.”

Catra laughed out loud and he scowled before he went back to his working and sulking. She rolled her eyes and started walking around the lab. When she’d wandered to the other side of the space, she stalled behind a large pillar of stone and observed Hordak. After a while he stopped what he was doing, lay down his tools, and rested his head in his hands. He stood like that for a while, slumped forward and still as a statue. There was nothing she could do to make it easier for him, there was one thing she wanted to say, however, before she tried sneaking into the bedroom to check on Entrapta herself. “Hordak?” she asked, walking toward him. He startled and straightened as if he’d forgotten she was there. “There’s something else.”

“Yes,” he said, taking a deep breath.

“I never thanked you for stepping in that day we came here, on the boat I mean.”

He frowned for a moment, looking away as if he was trying to remember. Then his face smoothed and he shook his head. “It was in everyone’s interest to keep the situation from escalating further,” he dismissed simply.

She crossed her arms and shrugged.” At the time, it didn’t seem like de-escalation was your priority,” she said with a small smirk at the floor. “At the time, it kind of seemed like you were standing up for me.”

Hordak looked away again and thought for a moment. “I know how difficult it can be to control… to manage situations ...” he trailed off.

Catra nodded. That was precisely the reason she wanted to thank him. She was glad to have, if not a friend in Hordak, at least an understanding peer. “Well, thanks anyway. It’s nice that you get how hard it can be, you know? How much it takes out of you.” He nodded at her gently.

A clanging sound preceded a small piece of metal bouncing off the table they were next to. They were still staring at the spot in confusion when something hit Catra’s shoulder before clattering across the ground.

“Fuck me,” she muttered, looking up into the ductwork and squinting.

“Imp,” Hordak growled, narrowing his eyes and matching Catra’s wary searching. “Imp?” he called a bit louder. “Come here, please.” All he received in reply was a defiant, echoing screech.

Another piece of something hit Catra’s back from a new angle and she gritted her teeth, deciding she should finish her sentiment sooner rather than later. “Anyway, I guess I just wanted to say-” a thick spring flew past the side of her face and she closed her eyes, willing patience.

Hordak tried summoning the little shit again, but Imp wouldn’t come. They merely heard Imp chattering and a few scampering sounds as Catra tried to continue. “I just wanted to say…” a metal nut bounced off the side of her head. She took a deep breath and tried to ignore it. “I wanted to say that I…” A bolt bounced off this time. She ignored a twitch in her eye and calmly took a step backward, hopefully out of Imp’s line of sight. “To say that…” This time whatever Imp threw bounced off the back of her head, “that I can’t have a conversation with pieces of scrap being thrown at me !” she finally roared, losing her temper. A delighted chittering echoed above them and they both looked around wildly, trying to locate where little skittering noises were coming from.

“Imp!” Hordak shouted, losing his own patience. “Desist this instant or…” A larger piece of metal hit Hordak square in the back

of the head and he snarled against another defiant screech.

The next thing she knew, Hordak and Imp were in a full-blown battle, throwing pieces of scrap at each other and exchanging threats and taunts. Somehow, Imp still had access to little stashes of projectiles along with the dexterity to keep them flying at Catra while still avoiding Hordak's missiles. She leapt from machinery to machinery, up into the pipes. But they were slick against her claws and she was wary of puncturing them, and she avoided the pipes small enough to grip lest they give way under her weight. She pounced from perch to perch, chasing Imp around the ductwork and piping haphazardly. She managed to cut him off as he moved to another stash of machinery bits, but he was waiting with a tiny wheel that he whipped at her face. She dodged it, but the pipe beneath her shifted at her violent movement.

The doors to the lab opened just in time for Adora, Glimmer, Bow, and Mermista to see Catra fall from the rafters, dropping her pipe and twisting in mid-air to grab Hordak around the neck as she landed on top of him, using him to cushion her fall while he made a loud gagging sound. They landed in a crumpled heap and several pipes fell down on top of them.

"I know where you sleep!" Hordak bellowed, shaking his fist at Imp as he chittered maniacally. "He's beginning to take after Entrapta," Catra heard him mutter dismally as he hauled himself up off the floor. Catra was already up and straightening her clothes.

"What about me?" Entrapta asked as she emerged from the bedroom, looking around curiously for the source of commotion, wearing bedclothes with her hair down and trailing behind her.

Catra shook her hair out and dusted herself off. Glimmer spoke with a smirk and a raised brow at her. "What happened here?"

"Imp started a fight," Catra answered, looking over as Entrapta approached. "You know, it'd be great if I could come in here

without being harassed by a TINY TERRORIST FROM ABOVE," she called out loudly. Distant chittering echoed back.

"I suggest bribery," Entrapta said in a voice that suggested she was sleepy, but in a much better temper. "He really likes fruit and sugar."

"Thanks, Catra griped. "I'll remember that."

"Entrapta," Mermista started, "I'm so sorry I-"

"I'm sorry too," Entrapta said, looking down and twisting her hands. Hordak scowled. "It wasn't your fault, I was having a little bit of a breakdown."

"Both of us contributed. The whole thing was stupid," Mermista was still frowning but seemed more at ease. "We just wanted to come and make sure you're alright." Entrapta looked up, offered a small smile and nodded.

"How are you feeling?" Bow asked.

Entrapta looked very weary while she thought for a moment, then sagged and stared down at the floor miserably. "Sort of fragile, I guess."

Glimmer grunted in displeasure. "That's awful."

Hordak continued to frown but seemed to approve of the interaction. Bow walked forward and hugged Entrapta, an embrace which she returned. "Why don't you and Hordak take a few days for some R&R? Hordak's under royal orders to take care of his emotional health, so it's convenient timing."

Entrapta nodded but didn't answer. Just then the sliding doors opened again and Scorpia walked in with a steaming tea pot held between her claws. "Oh," she said, stopping short. "Hi everyone... um, are we having a party?"

Catra noticed Entrapta edge backward a few inches. “No,” she said, in fact, we didn’t even mean to wake her up. We should probably be going, now.”

Mermista walked forward, caught Entrapta up in a quick hug, and turned to lead the others back out of the lab. Catra made to follow Adora but stopped when she felt a lock of Entrapta’s hair curl around her hand briefly. Looking down at the smaller woman, Catra saw her look up and smile hopefully. “Want to have a Super Pal Trio reunion? Just a little one?”

Catra smiled at her. “Yeah, I think I’d like that.” Entrapta retreated to the bedroom as the others turned to leave. Scorpia hovered on the side, unsure of whether she should go or deliver the tea, and seemed relieved when Catra jerked her head at her in a gesture to follow Entrapta. She gave a significant nod to Adora, who smiled and waved, then looked to Hordak, who might have almost smiled.

Back in the private rooms, Entrapta groaned and flopped flat on the bed, face in her pillow and hair totally limp. “How are you doing, Traps?” Catra asked as she selected a crate to sit on.

“I’ve been better,” she said into her pillow.

Scorpia bustled about the room, collecting tiny cups in which to serve her tea. “Gosh it’s been a while, hasn’t it guys?” Scorpia asked as she returned with an arranged tray. “Just like the old days, huh?” Entrapta rolled back into a sitting position and Scorpia passed the tray off before sitting on the ground between them. “Do you ever miss it? The Fright Zone?” Scorpia asked, looking between them.

“Fuck no,” Catra answered quickly, and a small chunk of rock hit her forehead. “ARE YOU FUCKING KIDDING ME?”

“Imp!” Entrapta cried, holding out her arms. He blew his customary raspberry at Catra as he flew into them, then settled down on her lap with a self-satisfied grin.

“What about you, Traps?” Scorpia asked.

The other looked thoughtful for a few moments. “Sometimes I do." She gave them a slow, sheepish smile. "Not for any noble reason, though.”

“Obviously,” Catra remarked.

Entrapta shrugged. “I definitely had more creative license working for you guys. And I really like building bots and weapons. And I liked spending so much time with Hordak.” Scorpia nodded and smiled. “And I guess I kind of miss the rank thing.” Catra raised an eyebrow, smirking now as well. “From the vents, it was easy to tell that everyone was just afraid of Hordak, but in person-to-person interactions, the way people treated me felt almost like respect. I might have gotten just a little bit attached to the feeling.” Catra’s and Scorpia’s faces fell. Even Imp scowled and looked around up at Entrapta’s face. As the tense silence stretched, Entrapta became aware of the change in atmosphere. “What?” she asked, “What did I say?”

About forty-five minutes later, Entrapta was back to dosing and Catra was following Scorpia back out of the lab. Hordak was where they’d left him, busy as ever, and barely gave them a glance as they left. Before she was through the doors, however, Catra noticed a small pile of fruit on a tray that had been left by some nervous staff member next to the sliding door. On sudden inspiration, she waved at Scorpia to stay and turned to the fruit instead, plucking a handful of grapes and returning to the bedroom door.

Hordak gave her and Scorpia a scowl and a lifted brow, but they ignored him, opening the door slowly and silently to peek inside. Imp was curled up with Entrapta for a nap, but as she looked around the corner he opened his malicious little eyes, yellow and

glowing. Catra showed him the handful of grapes and beckoned him forward. He hesitated, narrowing his eyes in suspicion, but eventually made his slow way toward her on all fours, sniffing cautiously. She gave him a couple of grapes before coaxing him out of the bedroom completely. Then, crouching as Hordak watched curiously from across the room, she gave Imp the rest of the grapes. He crouched on the ground and watched Scorpia, Catra, and Hordak in turn.

“I know you don’t like me, and you don’t have to,” Catra offered as a caveat while Imp stuffed his bulging cheeks, “but I want to do something for Entrapta." He frowned up at them as he finished wolfing down the grapes, but lingered there, listening. “You know that thing she said about the way she was treated in the Fright Zone?” Catra asked.

Imp nodded and opened his mouth. “...felt almost like respect,” he replayed.

“Exactly,” she affirmed, looking over at Scorpia, who was frowning again. “I know some people who should really hear that. Do you think you could help make that happen?” He nodded without hesitation, and she grinned. “Perfect. We'll take the next opportunity we get.”

* * * * *

Several days passed quietly in Salineas, most everyone lost in their own affairs for the time being. The first night after Entrapta had finally fessed up, right after she'd struck her truce with Imp, Catra and Hordak had discussed their next steps. Very quickly, Catra had realized her power in the situation was minimal, but that wouldn’t keep her from putting everything she had toward curing Adora and Entrapta. She'd even tagged along when

Glimmer had taken Adora, Melog, Hordak, and Bow up to the Northern Reach so that they could meet with the scientists at the drilling station, even though she was utterly useless in a discussion on health science. Apparently, Entrapta had been spending quite a lot of time up there studying the virus with them, though she never let on that her interest was anything unusual. The news that they'd already been working on their problem, however, was a brief flash of encouragement in a visit that was otherwise disappointing.

In an increasingly frustrating process of elimination, they'd slowly been forced to accept there was nothing they could do to help solve the problem any faster than those who were already working on the problem. As Bow did his best to translate sciency lingo, they'd systematically broached every idea, thought, and question they could imagine about the virus to the team. One by one, they were answered with lengthy and complicated explanations of when, how and why they'd already exhausted every proposed avenue with Entrapta.

The experts who were already on task represented far more experience in organic disease and computer viruses than even Hordak could match, and they had yet to contribute anything new to the effort. The most useful action had come from Glimmer and Bow, who'd brought in a handful of especially science-minded clones to add expertise of their own to the think tank, but even they were at a loss when it came to understanding the virus.

Bow and Hordak had both believed them easily when Adora and Catra explained that the virus affected She-Ra differently than Entrapta, mainly manifesting as anger issues rather than fatigue. Privately, Adora had explained that She-Ra's healing energy was being turned destructive by her anger, which made it seem like more of a personal problem than a medical one anyway. Even so, Catra had been a breath away from just telling everyone the whole situation to have it done with, but the overwhelming anxiety that had permeated the air kept them from giving up the secret until they absolutely had to.

Catra and Adora had struggled valiantly, but their attention spans didn't hold for long and Glimmer had been asked to take them home early. After a hail of scolding that would have impressed Angella, Glimmer had flashed off and left them to their own devices. And, for the most part, that's how things stayed. Catra watched the roads, Adora cleared shit up or blew away old wreckage, and because most of the world's open bleeds had been addressed immediately after Prime's defeat, they were somehow able to avoid telling everyone that She-Ra had lost her healing powers.

Because of all this, however, the subject had become something of a problem in hers and Adora’s relationship. Now, several days back into business as usual, any time the virus came up in conversation they avoided each other’s eyes and changed the subject as soon as they could, and Adora was completely unwilling to talk about it separately. All the same, Catra couldn’t deny that worry was gnawing at her, getting a little worse each day that passed without progress toward finding a solution. They both knew they’d have to address it of course, but so far it seemed to Catra that neither was willing to open that can of worms yet. She knew full well it probably wasn’t healthy, but then, she and Adora had never been great with communication or coping skills.

She was on her way back from checking in on Entrapta one evening when Catra ran into a small crowd in the Great Hall. Adora was there, talking with Mermista, Sea Hawk, Glimmer, Bow, Micah and Castaspella. They were all wearing very serious expressions and Castaspella seemed somewhat upset. "What's up?" she asked when they noticed her approach.

"We were talking about Entrapta," Micah said. "Glimmer mentioned she was feeling unwell.” Mermista frowned harder and Sea Hawk touched her arm.

“Not that sweet girl who hacked Prime’s tech?” Catstaspella said, glancing at Micah's neck reflexively.

Catra jumped in before anyone else could speak up. “Yeah, she’s been dealing with a bit of a bug,” she said casually, “but we’re having a tough time figuring out what it is.” Castaspella looked genuinely upset and Catra was relieved to know she could be upfront. “Come to think of it, sorcerers might just have some ideas she could benefit from. I don’t suppose you’ve got any people who might be able to help her in any way?” The others all exchanged looks of mingled doubt, hope and interest.

The Sorceress immediately brightened. “Of course! I’ll send them round right away.”

“Speaking of the basement nerds,” Mermista drawled. Catra snorted and Bow gave them both disapproving looks. “Anybody know how they’ve been? I’ve been giving them their space but is there anyone that’s like, in the know or whatever?”

Glimmer shook her head with a fresh frown, but Catra sighed and spoke up. “I’ve been checking on Entrapta at least twice a day since her… uh, her thing.” She winced at her own words. “She was asleep nearly every time. I think she just really needs rest right now.”

“How’s Hordak?” Glimmer asked.

She rolled her eyes and sighed again. “He’s never far away, and every time I’ve popped in, he’s been researching something or other.” She shrugged. “He’s pretty fucked up about it, but he’s also gotten a lot better about being a gigantic asshole and honestly, he seems more stable than I would have expected.”

“Actually,” Bow broke in, “about the only silver lining of the situation thus far is that it’s thoroughly distracted Hordak from his thing about Salineas’ war stories. He says he’s cut the time he spends on that stuff down to a minimum.” Mermista folded her arms and gave him a questioning look. “What?” he asked defensively, frowning now between her and Glimmer. “I want the whole team to be okay. You guys aren’t the only ones checking in on each other.”

Sea Hawk faced Catra, and she could tell he was whipping himself up some drama. “How is he fairing as he witnesses faltering health in his beloved?”

“Why are you people asking me all this?” she grouched at the rest of them. “I don’t know, it’s not like he talks to me about his personal life.” The others didn’t stop looking at her. “*He doesn’t even like me*,” she protested.

“Doesn’t he?” Sea Hawk asked, seeming genuinely surprised.

She made an exasperated face and sighed. “He likes my shoes.”

“That tracks,” Glimmer agreed.

Catra snarky things to say, but her attention had been caught by a paper bag held loosely in Mermista's hand. A handwritten note scrawled across the front read: ‘It’s called a turtleneck. Couldn’t find anything big enough so I had to have one made, and it’s not because I like you. I’m just tired of looking at your puckered up face every time the wind blows. Keep your neck warm, sea breezes can be chilly.’

A growl from Mermista let Catra know she’d been caught, and she looked up at the glaring princess sheepishly. “Do not push me, horde scum,” she muttered from behind tight lips. “I will drown you so fast…”

“My lips are sealed,” Catra assured her as Adora turned around.

“Huh?” Adora asked, but Mermista was already gone.

* * * * *

Entrapta slept for the better part of three days after Hordak had found her in the shower. Once he'd learned what he could in the Northern Reach, he'd stuck mainly to the cellars for the duration, never far from where he could hear Entrapta snore. All the while, he had investigated everything he could to try and wrap his head around what the virus could be doing to her. Unfortunately, to his utter dismay and disgust, he was still clueless as to the exact nature of the situation, or how to go about combating it.

Wrong Hordak had, of course, appeared with Swift Wind in tow the moment he'd learned Entrapta was experiencing problems with her health. Naturally he'd been devastated, leaning on Swift Wind heavily while he begged for their assurance that she would be okay, over and over again. Entrapta and Hordak had struggled to comfort him, even with Swift Wind's earnest support. A part of Hordak, however, was grateful that at least someone else reflected the kind of terror that he felt when he considered Entrapta's protracted illness.

All the while, he had maintained a mantra of self-assurance that Entrapta merely needed more sleep, and she'd feel better soon. She was improving rapidly, but when they spoke, he was often disquieted by topics of a separate nature. In talking to him about the leadup to her episode in the shower, she explained a lifelong love/hate relationship with her own mind. Her intense shame around her struggles, while nothing new, was deeply troubling to him. He had, or had had, the outlet of aggression and public expression during most of his darkest times, regardless of whether he deserved it or not. But the way she spoke about her lows, the stories she told him, painted a picture of internalized suffering that he was both familiar with and appalled by. She had done nothing wrong, was a source of nothing but light and life and love, and she hurt so quietly that even he'd been quite unaware of how different life could be for her. The whole affair struck him as utterly unacceptable, but he did not know what to do about it other than to assure Entrapta that she was not broken or wrong as best he could. It was a frustrating and strange position to find himself in.

Hordak was deep in his musings during a break from his reading when he was roused by the sliding lab doors opening. He expected a servant with some message or report, but instead saw Mermista toss a paper bag onto the nearby table. He watched in confusion as she turned around to go, pausing to look at him briefly. "Don't leave that out," she said, gesturing to the bag. Then the doors were closing behind her and she was gone.

He retrieved the curious parcel and read the note on the front while carrying it back to the bedroom. Entrapta stirred when he opened the door and smiled at him from the bed, sleepily. "What have you got?" she asked after a yawn.

"It's from Princess Mermista," he answered, still puzzled. He sat on the end of the bed and removed what seemed to be a large, black knit garment from it.

Entrapta read the bag quickly and looked up to where Hordak was feeling the plush squish of the material between his fingers. "Oooh, it looks like you got a new sweater!"

"A sweater?" he asked, raising a brow at her.

She giggled and nodded. "They're comfy and warm. Let me see it on!" she insisted.

"Entrapta," he protested weakly.

"Oh, you know you want to."

Hordak bit back a smile and began to undress. It took a few moments of holding it up at different angles to see how the garment was supposed to be worn, as it seemed whoever made it had also preserved access to a clone's ports. He pulled it over his head and the tubelike collar stretched uncomfortably up over his face. After he'd slid it down to his neck he shook his hair out and his ears flapped, making Entrapta clap with gee. Once she helped him fold the collar down, however, he paused, then sank his fingers into the squishy knit around his neck.

“Are you liking it?” Entrapta asked, eyes wide and curious.

“It is… surprisingly pleasant to wear.” He stood and let the garment fall to his calves, looking down and twisting to see how it hung.

“Well you look fantastic in it. It was a good call on Mermista’s part,” Entrapta raised an eyebrow and leaned back, admiring the gift.

“Why…”

“It’s not rocket science. Anyone could have guessed you’d rock a sweater dress.”

Hordak blushed. “No, I mean… why did she do this?”

Entrapta beamed. “I told you they’d warm up to you.”

He furrowed his brow and shook his head in confusion. “They’re all mad,” he muttered to himself. Entrapta shrugged and snuggled back into bed, watching him observe his reflection in the mirror.

Chapter End Notes

If it's convenient and you happen to have a thought or opinion, I humbly request any feedback you’ve got. It is very much appreciated.

"I vote we make Hordak go first."

Chapter Summary

Hordak and Catra go participate in a Salineas side project.

To Hordak's great relief, Entrapta was feeling more herself after five days or so of rest. Her mind was again ravenously active, and she was nearly up to her old energy. Not quite all the way, however- she was still spending many more hours asleep per day than she'd ever done before.

In addition to the increased fatigue, she was finally letting him see the extent of the virus' effect in her hair. While he was glad that she wasn't hiding it anymore, he thought she might still be playing her symptoms down and it worried him endlessly.

Hordak helped Entrapta brush her hair every morning and evening now because she couldn't command the dexterity needed for it to brush itself. Every night, he braided it so it wouldn't tangle in her sleep, and every morning he helped her keep her sectioning crisp when she tied it up in her pigtails. She still used her magic strands actively around the lab, however, and if Entrapta was distressed by the changes, she did not show it.

She insisted that her remaining symptoms had to do with the virus, rather than her more painful, more recent ordeal. The only clue to the episode that remained was her choice of projects in which to lose herself. Instead of spacecraft or intergalactic security, she'd chosen much smaller, more manageable tasks.

It was just such a task that they were about that day. Entrapta had been struck with an idea in the middle of the night and immediately sent out a round of messages. Now, as Hordak gathered the supplies Entrapta was mentioning as she worked, a comparatively large team from the alliance was meeting up to help enact her plan.

So far, however, it was just he and Entrapta in the lab, along with a little group of Mystacor healers that had been sent to collect what information they could on Entrapta's health troubles. They struggled to keep up with her as she bustled, following her this way and that as she flitted from place to place, many of them holding strange devices and casting glittering runes.

"Like I said," Entrapta shouted to Hordak over the small crowd of healers, "I've based my plans for sensory navigation on Plumerian catfish, so it shouldn't need visibility to get around down there. Once I work out the bugs it should be able to aid toward cleanup without getting in the way and making life harder on the people that live there. We're expanding reconstruction to border regions anyway, so this is good timing." She coiled up her hair and sat cross-legged at a massive screen, staring up and typing wildly as sorcerers followed and clustered around. "Mermista's going to start us in one of the nastiest runoff areas on the outskirts of Salineas' coastal borders!" she continued cheerfully. "She says it's pretty disgusting and *heavily* trafficked, so it should provide a fascinating challenge! Obviously it was cleaned up when She-Ra released the magic, but if it's since re-polluted this badly then clearly a long term solution is still required."

With a large poof of glitter, Queen Glimmer appeared with Frosta, Micah, Catra, Melog, Perfuma, Daisy, Mermista, Sea Hawk, and a couple of palace guards in tow. "Friends!" Entrapta cried brightly, "You're here!"

"Entrapta!" Perfuma cried with a giant smile, starting toward the little scientist. "How are you feeling?"

Before Entrapta could reply, Imp swooped out of nowhere and plucked a flower from her hair as she walked, startling her into a squeal. "What did I say about stealing from strangers?" Hordak called warningly. He was promptly answered by a defiant screech.

"Oh, it's okay," Perfuma chuckled good-naturedly, looking a little bit shaken. "They can have all the flowers they want," she poked at the flowers in her hair lightly, found the empty spot, and

conjured one to replace it. Then she filled her palms with blossoms and lifted them above her head. “What’s their name?” she asked Hordak.

“His name is Imp.”

“Is he, like, your son?” Princess Frosta asked, craning her neck to see over Perfuma’s shoulder.

Hordak had to do a double take at the second Etherian to suggest such a thing. “Absolutely not,” he said, affronted as ever. “He is Imp.”

Frosta shrugged and Perfuma waited with her palms in the air. After a while Imp flapped his way down to the table nearest Perfuma and crouched there, sniffing cautiously as he sized her up. She bent slightly and slowly brought her flowery offering near him so he could reach it.

With one last suspicious look, he leaned forward and began selecting the blooms he cared to. Entrapta crouched low to watch Imp on his level and squished her fists against her cheeks, eyes big and shiny with adoration. When Imp had filled an arm with what he wanted, he reached into his overalls’ front pocket with his free hand, fished around for a second, then held his little fist out over Perfuma’s open hands. When he dropped an especially shiny nut and spring onto the flowers that still rested there before scampering back into flight, Entrapta squeaked with glee. “Tradesies!” she whispered ecstatically.

“That was so precious,” Daisy added from the sidelines, eyes brimming.

“That was even cute for me,” Mermista said, approaching Perfuma to smile down at the treasured junk in her hands.

The grinning blonde wove little vines through the pieces, then shaped them into a bracelet to wear over the pink wrappings on her wrist. “Entrapta?” she looked up at her hopefully. “Does that smile mean you’re feeling a little better?”

"*Much* better, thank you," Entrapta said, grinning as she accepted Perfuma's brief hug. A healer took the opportunity to wave a wand vaguely over her head with an expression of intense concentration. Entrapta pulled herself free and looked around, scratching at her scalp with a screwdriver held in a lock of hair. "What was I looking for, again? Oh! Right!" She climbed up a large generator and lifted herself into the rafters. "Netting, netting, giant wad of netting…"

With Entrapta gone, there was nothing between Hordak and the healer with the wand, who suddenly found himself uncomfortably near the ex-warlord. The man squeaked and stepped back. Hordak ignored him, and Princess Mermista stepped forward into the vacated space. "Can clones even have kids?" she asked with a raised eyebrow.

Hordak snorted and gave her a bitter half smile. "As if Prime would allow his genetics to mix with those of *lesser* species. He even designed our DNA to be difficult to clone or otherwise adapt."

"Oh yeah, that makes sense," Mermista grunted, looking back at the others. "Nice dress, by the way."

He nodded and considered thanking her as he turned his head back toward the shadowy ceiling. Before he'd returned his gaze to Entrapta, however, he saw her plummeting through the air from the corner of his eye. He yelped and lunged, but far too late. She hit the ground on her feet with bent knees, but crumpled with the force of her landing, a large skene of netting falling from the ceiling soon after, though Frosta caught it with ice before it reached them. "Entrapta!" he snarled, sounding far more viscous in his alarm than he'd meant to.

Entrapta groaned and arched her back to rub her backside. "I'm fine," she grunted, eyes squeezed shut. "I just lost my grip is all." He picked her up and set her on her feet, growling distractedly and looking her over as she scowled and continued rubbing where her ass had hit the ground.

Once he'd stepped away to retrieve the thawing netting, he heard the healer approach Entrapta and whisper, "Princess, we wanted you to know that if you should ever feel unsafe, *for any reason,*" Hordak felt the man's gaze prickle on the back of his neck, "you need only reach out, and you would be well cared for."

There was an awkward pause while Entrapta processed the man's words and meaning. "Oh!" she finally exclaimed. "Thank you! Oh wow that's so super nice of you to say, really. But my boyfriend willed himself back from torture and brainwashing so he could kill god for me. I feel very loved and cared for."

Hordak felt a deep blush burn his face and creep through his ears as the healer sputtered.

"*No*, Sea Hawk," he heard Mermista growl in a warning tone. "Still a *hard no*."

Micah mercifully broke in to address the group Glimmer had brought. "Honestly, of all people, Entrapta's probably the only one I'd bet on in a one-on-one with Hordak. I'll never get over the way she handled Beast Island." Hordak felt his gut twist and he swallowed.

"The only one? Fucking seriously guys?" Catra groaned."

"Oops, and you of course, Catra," he corrected.

"Ooh! Speaking of Beast Island!" Entrapta perked up and turned to Bow, her fall from the ceiling already forgotten. "I actually got a lot of ideas for this particular project from the same critter I got my mask from." She beamed and knocked on her insectoid welding mask playfully. "That and Hordak's scrap-bots."

"Ooooh, you made that from something a monster had?" Frosta asked in mild interest.

Entrapta laughed. "Oh no! No, this little technological monstrosity was eating the transport I was sent on when I regained consciousness, and my mask broke when he attacked." Hordak

felt a cold feeling bloom in his chest and start spreading. “That was probably the closest I came to kicking the bucket the whole while I was there. He caught me by surprise, and I wasn’t so used to fighting yet." He stilled his movements to concentrate on his calm. "But I managed to wiggle my hair into his weak spots while we tussled and I managed to pull him apart. Then I adapted his face and started my work on Beast Island.” She knocked affectionately on the welding mask again, still grinning, and the cold in Hordak’s chest abated somewhat.

"Wait… your mask is the face of a vanquished foe?" Frosta muttered, her eyes going big and shiny.

Entrapta gave a cocky smirk and shrugged. “He broke my mask, I took his face. Fair’s fair.” Frosta let out an audible gasp of shocked adoration while Bow and Perfuma exchanged a dubious glance, but Entrapta took no notice.

"That's the most badass thing, like… *ever*," the young woman whispered with reverence. Her eyes slid out of focus and she took on a dreamy expression as Entrapta lifted herself back toward the shadowy ceiling.

“Get that shit-eating grin off your fucking face,” Catra muttered at him irritably from the corner of her mouth. He hadn’t realized he’d been smiling. He cast a glance at Micah and quickly readopted a neutral expression.

"I'm still the one who’s cool enough to be your sidekick though, right?" Glimmer asked with what seemed like genuine worry.

“*She wears the face of her enemy!*” Frosta exclaimed, both hands held out before her in a gesture of awe. She turned to Catra. "I'm beginning to see some of the appeal with the Etherian Horde,” she said with a devilish grin, “You guys are awesome!"

“And I think I’m beginning to see why Entrapta was never scared of Hordak,” Sea Hawk said, looking around above them to see where she was lurking.

“If you ask me, she’s definitely the more terrifying of the two,” Catra said. Hordak bit back another impulse to grin.

Entrapta appeared between them as she lowered herself up-side-down, suspended by a pigtail with her mask in place. “Terrifying?” she cried, startling the people in her vicinity. “Who, me? Absurd!” She laughed, flipped right-side-up and dropped to the floor, stumbling a little. “Hordak is much more prone to violence than I am, and he checks more of the boxes for traditionally frightening physical characteristics than I do.” She flipped her mask up and smiled around at them. “I’ve been told that my hair and propensity for intense focus are both creepy, but that’s about it.”

“Well, I like your creepy hair,” Catra said appreciatively, running a strand through her fingers.

“And I like your creepy focus,” Bow added. Entrapta beamed.

Then her face suddenly went slack and her eyes grew distant for a moment. “Focus…” she muttered dreamily with a blank stare. Then she stirred and blinked. “Focus! I was telling Bow about our options for digestion mechanisms!” She rounded on the young tech enthusiast and continued her conversation with him. “Oh, I’m so excited about these new bots! Ideally they’ll exist simultaneously independent of and in harmony with the flora and fauna we hope to encourage,” Entrapta continued, smiling and looking around herself. “I’ve never copied the work of the First Ones so directly, trying to make a kind of approximation of a bottom-feeding critter. But you have to start somewhere, right?” She laughed again. “The idea is that they’ll troll the refuse-filled water, eating up trash and sorting it out in their big weird bodies while they hang out on the muddy bottom,” she ran out of air and dragged in a huge breath, “and hypothetically, well, hopefully spit up bundles of reusable materials to people who’ve ostensibly forged positive relationships with them! How cute is that!?”

“Oh, that actually is really cute,” Bow smiled, walking closer.

“I’m bringing some different bot prototypes with us so I can play around with adapting their designs to the drainage area,” she enthused, eyes sparkling. “Want to see?”

Bow nodded and followed her to a different part of the dank space. The sound of a throat being cleared pointedly at Hordak’s side announced that Micah had approached him without his notice. He gave an awkward little bow and waited to be spoken to, observing the short man warily. He didn’t look friendly, but he didn’t seem hostile either. Eventually he offered a tight smile and began to speak in a casual voice. “You don’t have to hide it, you know.”

Hordak looked over and saw that the man’s anger had been replaced with a kind of resigned sorrow, which was much, much worse than unfriendliness. “Hide…” he began in confusion.

“Being happy. Glimmer used to do that to her mom and I all the time.” Micah’s dark eyes crinkled at the bittersweet memory. “Only, *she* did it to let us know she was still mad at us.” Hordak nodded, waiting for the man’s point. “*You’re* hiding it because you know you don’t deserve it,” he looked back up at Hordak, “but you’re not actually achieving anything by it.” Micah looked away again and seemed to be chewing on his words. Hordak shifted his weight and frowned, growing more uncomfortable by the second. “You know my daughter forgives you? My daughter, the queen, actually… *forgives* you.” He returned his gaze to Hordak’s face and squinted, giving him a mystified expression. “She’s the most extraordinary person I’ve ever known, and she deserves my full support.”

“Your highness,” Hordak began, but Micah interrupted him gruffly.

“Shut up, I’m making a point and then we’re done with this conversation.” Hordak nodded and waited. “And the point is,” he took a deep breath. “I hate you, Hordak. But for my daughter’s sake, I want you to have what you took from me,” he fixed Hordak with a blazing look. “Do you understand? *I want you to have what you took from me*.”

Hordak gulped and nodded.

Micah took a deep breath and his manner eased. “So go ahead and love the things you love, since you’re apparently capable of that.” He offered another tight smile. “It just might end up making you less of an asshole.” Hordak nodded in uncertainty. After another long pause, Micah spoke again, voice light. “People change, Hordak. I hate the man that did those terrible things to me and my family, but the man you’re becoming?” He looked up at Hordak and this time his smile was genuine and easy. “I might even kind of like him.” Hordak tried not to pull a face at the king in his incredulity. “And before you ask, yes. I am a little crazy.” He winked and then grinned, widening his eyes momentarily. “And I wonder whose fault that would be?” He clapped Hordak roughly on the shoulder before walking away and leaving him to his stunned staring.

As he readjusted his focus, he heard Entrapta’s voice carry above other conversations around him. “Obviously more than anything, I’m excited about space things, but…” she faltered, “I’m not quite up to big projects quite yet,” she admitted, frowning and lowering her face.

“Oh man, I get it,” Mermista said from her corner. “I mean, I’ve spent literal days at a time in a bathtub eating ice cream. Shit happens.” She said, shrugging. Entrapta looked slightly encouraged, however, and Hordak felt himself smile again.

Glimmer spoke up from next to Mermista. “The space stuff isn’t going anywhere. It’ll all be there when you’re ready to face it with a fresh mind.” Entrapta shot her a wide smile and Hordak had to suppress one of his own.

* * * * *

The entire group shuttled in Darla to a small coastal settlement on a distant fringe of Salineas' territory, a settlement which Hordak recalled destroying while Catra ran the conquest of the seas from the Fright Zone. It had been impoverished then and looked much, much worse now. People dressed in worn and tattered clothing clustered in small groups in doorways and on corners, their shoulders hunched under invisible burdens. Others in flamboyant, colorful outfits swaggered down the middle of roads, flashing their swords and ill-gotten gains. Trash blew hither and thither with the wind while skinny strays picked through what scraps they could find. The bombed-out buildings had only been repaired to the point that they offered the meagerest of shelters, many housing clusters of tents and shanties within the remaining walls of the ruin.

Melog grew large and though his mane stayed blue and smooth, his eyes were large and his posture wary. Hordak overheard Catra worrying to Glimmer over the hateful glares they were drawing from every single person they passed, and he couldn't help a thrill of nervousness himself. A rock bounced off of Micah and he grumbled. When Princess Mermista took up the lead, however, flanked by the two palace guards and holding her head up high, the surrounding residents' behavior simmered a bit.

They smelled the drainage lagoon long before they saw it. It was large, filled with trash and muck, brown, opaque and foul. Rickety looking docks dotted its perimeter, along which raggedy children scampered, looking for valuable salvage. Glimmer let out a long, low whistle and Mermista swore softly. "Alright, team," Glimmer said bracingly. A large blue tentacle rose from the water and narrowly missed a light-footed child before slipping back into the water. "Let's get to work."

Catra's job was to keep the roads secure, which was more of a pain in the ass than she'd expected. Displeased locals kept trying to dart close enough to throw things at Hordak and were just as happy to fight her upon confrontation. Meanwhile, Mermista and Frosta managed sections of water while Micah and Glimmer handled large pieces of scrap and mutated lagoon creatures. Entrapta and Hordak talked robots next to Perfuma and Daisy as they talked estuary ecosystems, and the four of them regularly broke to talk environmental sustainability all together. Sea Hawk managed to move around more than any of them while achieving absolutely nothing at all, though he seemed to thoroughly enjoy himself while doing so.

Several hours after their arrival, Glimmer retrieved Adora once she was finished with work elsewhere and tasked her with heavy lifting. Another couple of hours after that, Catra had the pleasure of witnessing an interaction between Sea Hawk and a particularly helpful seagull. The pirate drew the attention of everyone around him as he made a lengthy series of awful screeching sounds, apparently conversing with the bird on its level. Then it flapped away, calm as anything, and he clapped his hands together before loudly declaring, "Friends! A seagull told me about more horde wreckage fouling the waters upstream!"

"You can speak Seagull?" Entrapta asked with dawning delight.

"My beloved Mermista taught me," he answered proudly.

"Fascinating," Hordak and Entrapta said in tandem.

As the hours of work passed, more and more people gathered around the spectacle, trying to get a view or else add their input. Eventually, Catra resorted to setting up a kind of loose perimeter with empty crates and broken barrels, which made it easier for her and Melog to patrol. The flaw in the plan was revealed to be Melog's blossoming affinity for elderly people. Catra had just dodged a flying chunk of brick when a commotion across the water behind her drew her attention. She looked around in time to see a white-haired old man with a wooden leg that was noticeably

too short for him, stumping his way toward She-Ra, Glimmer and Micah as if they weren't in the middle of demonstrating the Universe's most powerful magic.

"What the hell, Melog?" she shouted before jogging into a run. They meowed back insolently, as if *she* were the asshole.

By the time she made it to the group, Adora, Micah and Glimmer looked thoroughly amused as they listened to the citizen who was already in full swing. "...it's going to take a while to handle all the things living in *that* lagoon, I'll tell you what, even when I was a boy it was a nasty spot. And those critters have only gotten bigger and *weirder* since the big blast."

Glimmer motioned to Catra that she wasn't needed and She-Ra blew a kiss. She left them to it, reasoning that the old man was harmless enough, if obnoxious. While she wandered back around the swampy shore, she passed close to where Hordak and Entrapta were talking over a bunch of robot parts.

"...even though it's going to be mostly wetlands," Entrapta was saying. "It's going to be the tougher function to secure, so I want to do deep water first."

"Is that dock sufficiently sound to launch bots from?" He asked curiously, looking around and spotting Catra.

"I don't know," Entrapta said, "Catra?" she called a little louder. "Have you been out on any of them? Do you know how sturdy they are?" Daisy and Perfuma wandered over.

Catra looked out over the lagoon and approached the moldering remains of what had once been a fishing dock, looking out over the inconsistent row of planks that seemed to hover over the still-disgusting water. "Uuuummm… " Catra began hesitantly, raising her voice and turning back to face Entrapta. "If you're going to test it, maybe somebody heavier should do it? I vote we make Hordak go first. I've seen pieces of building fall on this guy, and it just slowed him down for a while. Mostly pissed him off."

Hordak heaved a huge sigh before he walked her way, as if he were the most inconvenienced person on the planet. "Happy to oblige," he muttered at Catra as he passed her. He slowed slightly when his feet left solid ground, but he made a good show of striding forward without visible nervousness. Everyone around the lagoon stopped what they were doing when they saw him out over the water.

"Keep going," Catra goaded in a shout. "Entrapta said deep water, right?"

She saw Hordak's head tilt back and could practically feel his exasperated groan. He took another few steps, however, and a loud crack sounded beneath him. "Damnit Catra," she heard him mutter, just before the boards beneath his feet gave way and he fell straight through.

"Hordak!" she yelped instinctively, cautiously picking her way along the rickety boards on all fours even as she fought to stifle the laughter pushing through her set teeth. All around her she could hear that most everyone around the shore were roaring with laughter, and she barely stayed mobile through crippling giggles at how very dignified he'd been as he dropped straight enough to barely splash. Catra approached the center of the ripples on the water and finally allowed herself to burst into paroxysms of laughter, tearing up and clinging to the rotting wood for support. As the laughter around her passed, however, her smile slid away, and she leaned forward over the water, waiting for him to come back up.

When the laughter faded, the old man's reedy shouting became audible. "You'd best get your boy out of there quick! Right quick! The things in that lake'll eat him up, fast as anything!"

Catra knew he didn't need as much air as they did, but as seconds ticked by and the surface of the lagoon stilled, she started getting nervous. The old man kept squawking as he stumped his way around the shore and Glimmer appeared next to Perfuma and

Daisy with Adora and Micah in tow, wearing an expression of earnest concern. “Shit!” the Queen swore.

A small burst of bubbles blooped to the surface as they stared and Catra registered a thrill of trepidation. However, the bubbles were soon followed by the slow appearance of two halves of a giant lightning eel, bobbing and turning pathetically in the filthy water.

“Why didn’t you guys just have me build an ice platform?” Frosta asked as she skated up to their side, creating ice that encased the weak wood of the dock. “Where is he? Why hasn’t he come up?” She sounded like she was starting to get nervous.

“That definitely would have been the smarter thing to do,” Entrapta agreed brightly, appearing on Catra’s other side. “Lessons learned!”

“Entrapta, is everything okay?” Mermista called from behind her.

“Oh, we’ve got time,” she assured them cheerfully, “but somebody’s going to have to go get him. Mushroom promised he’d help me develop new super light armor, but right now Hordak can’t displace sufficient volume with his arms and legs to get the weight of himself and his armor up through the water.” She sighed and rolled her eyes. “*I* wanted to install a buoyancy device, but he said he draws the line at floaties.” Everyone stared at her blankly. “What?”

A massive fish with too many long, sharp teeth floated to the surface between the two halves of eel, along with most of its insides. On the opposite shore, a large animal that looked like an unpleasant combination between a frog and a lemur exited the water with a splash and hopped away.

“I’ll get him,” Mermista droned. Catra could tell that she wanted to sound annoyed, but she could also hear the amusement in her voice. She poked her trident in the water and pushed the remains of the lagoon creatures toward the shore. “Guards, give the meat to the strays. Don’t let people eat it though, if they’re that hungry

I want you to take them for a meal at the tavern. Start a tab on me if you need." With that, the princess leapt from the peer in a perfect dive and disappeared into the foul water. Entrapta left to start dragging over robots while Glimmer and Perfuma hovered anxiously. A steady stream of bubbles confused Catra for several long moments before Mermista slowly bobbed to the surface herself, clutching her stomach and letting the bubbles float from her mouth and nose. For one horrifying second, she thought Hordak had accidentally lashed out at her, but then gurgling laughter rose as she broke the surface. Mermista was barely coherent, laughing harder than Catra had ever seen. She kept trying to right herself long enough to explain, only to dissolve into silent laughter again and slip beneath the surface.

"Any day now," Catra eventually called.

"Right, right, I'm sorry." She took several deep breaths and blinked hard. "I just got down there where the water's clearer, and he was just standing there with his arms folded, watching me and pouting like a fucking little kid. It was the most ridiculous thing I've ever seen," she dipped underwater to get another round of giggles out of her system.

"Alright," Glimmer said, elbowing Adora to quiet her snickering, "moving on,"

"Okay, okay," Mermista conceded before diving again.

"Are his ports okay in the water?" Adora asked Entrapta.

"Oh sure, Prime built them real durable. It takes a lot of force at a sharp point to puncture the membrane over their ports. Just gotta wash a clone regularly and you should be fine."

When Mermista re-appeared she was laughing as hard as ever, dragging Hordak backward through the water by his armor's collar. He had his arms folded tight and looked like he'd swallowed a lemon. She dragged him until they could both reach the mud, then released him to crawl forward, still laughing hysterically. He

stood, scowling fiercely, and stomped up the shore, avoiding Catra's gaze.

Glimmer was giggling now, too. "I feel like Hordak could use a break," she said, biting her lips against continued giggles as she looked around.

Mermista was finally calm enough to breath deep and step forward. "Why don't the two guards take the Horde scum to get something to eat and drink? They've been working hard all day."

"I could actually really go for some food," Catra muttered, feeling her stomach growl in response. "I'll bring you something back," she called over to Adora, who looked like she'd just opened her mouth to ask the same.

"I'm installing the buoyancy thing," Entrapta said to Hordak as she fussed over his armor, opening a panel and twisting a dial.

"I said no," he said in a stern and final tone. Catra saw him hunching his shoulders and fighting a shiver.

"You know you can't stop me," she replied in an airy, singsong voice. "And what if I made it cute? Added little teeth and bat wings?"

"Entrapta!"

"Come on, big guy," Catra said, punching his arm lightly as she passed him toward the guards. Let's go warm up a little."

I shall come with you!" Sea Hawk cried, throwing his hands in the air and grinning. "For I can show you how to enjoy these fine coastal communities as one of the locals!"

"That will not be necessary," Hordak assured him as Entrapta returned to her robots.

"Nonsense!" the pirate boomed cheerily. "I must show you the hospitality of the high seas! Away with me, my friends," he cried,

leaping onto the road and striking a pose.

"I don't think we're getting out of this one," Catra muttered out of the side of her mouth at Hordak, who grunted in reply and glowered.

"...you break for lunch, you find a mob with pitchforks."

Chapter Summary

> Catra and Hordak get into a bar fight before getting chased by an angry mob. She-Ra can't heal Hordak.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Sea Hawk led the way down the street, loudly boasting their tour of the squalor while Hordak and Catra obeyed his lead and the Salineas guards followed after. They'd been there all day, so the reactions they received from locals as they went were passive, if hostile. Even so, she felt her tail bush slightly in her nervousness and pulled her hood up over her ears. "Is this a really bad idea?" She muttered to Hordak without turning her head.

"Getting into an enclosed space and imposing upon the locals?" He replied drily.

"Yeah." She looked over at his furrowed brow and severe frown.

"It is a terrible idea, but I am absolutely freezing."

She snorted loudly and he turned his scowl on her, raising a quizzical brow. "Well, we are with guards," she reasoned. "So let's just keep our heads down and hope for the best." He grunted dismissively and faced forward again, shivering lightly as he maintained pace. She felt her ear swivel under her hood as she kept observing their surroundings. "Is your armor… is it humming?"

He grunted again before answering, "Entrapta's current design includes various condition-control mechanisms for extreme conditions."

“Oh shit, so that warm breeze is coming from you? Crazy.”

“As always, her work is thorough and comprehensive.”

“Romantic.” He ignored her. “So, the suit features everything but the floaties?” she goaded. Hordak narrowed his eyes and glared ahead.

They had to walk for a while, but the group of five visitors ended up in a local tavern, dimly lit and unwelcoming. Seeing as Catra was leaving with both guards, Melog had stayed behind to help maintain the work site’s perimeter, and she was already missing their reassuring presence. She sat with her back to the corner along with Hordak, both of them watching the surrounding patrons warily across from the guards while Sea Hawk ordered a round of strawberry wine and bar snacks.

The longer they sat in the focus of the room’s collective attention, the more Catra wished that they hadn’t come in the first place. It seemed like an incredibly reckless and naive thing to do, now that they were effectively surrounded. “Are you starting to dry out yet?” she asked Hordak, trying to ease some tension.

“I am,” he answered in his driest tone. The guards they were sitting with shifted in their seats, looking away awkwardly to hide their sudden smirks.

“At least your pride was the only thing injured,” she said, flashing him a half smile.

He laughed out loud and she was relieved to hear it was a genuine sound. “Pride?”

“Sure,” she said, pausing at his reaction but doubling down anyway. “A little humiliation is probably good for you. Keeps you humble.” One of the guards laughed, then slapped a hand over his mouth and glanced at Hordak warily.

Hordak smiled, however, even if the expression was a little bitter. “Pride…” he muttered, folding his hands on the table and looking

down at them. “After I lost Prime’s favor and he cast me out, I tried to teach myself cloning so that I might live long enough to see him again. I waged his war to earn his approval, devoted my existence to returning to him, and the entire planet knows it. There's not much by way of *pride* for me anymore.”

Catra tried to ignore the chill that swept over her skin from her scalp downward. “That,” she admitted, “is a good point.”

He huffed again, but his expression was gentle. Strangely gentle, in fact- as if whatever he was thinking of was a tender, treasured memory. But then his face soured again, and he shut his eyes tight.

Several feet of floorspace separated where they sat from the large, dirty window that was currently the only source of light in the gloomy space. If she had tried to look through the grime on its panes, she wouldn’t have seen much. However, her head snapped around and she stared hard at the filmy glass when a familiar, if fuzzy silhouette passed by. There was nothing particularly unique about the shape of it, but something in the combination of coloring, size and gait made Catra absolutely certain that Octavia had just strode past the front of the Tavern. For a moment, the impulse to run out front to be sure had her leaning forward, ass an inch from her seat, but then the guard that had laughed blurted out at Hordak, “Is it true that Horde Prime sent you here because you’re mutated or something?”

Hordak lifted his head and considered the now very nervous man. “He didn’t send me here, that was an accident,” he said and paused for a moment. “But otherwise, yes, you are correct. Beauty was very important to Prime. He did not suffer imperfections, nor incomplete devotion.”

He got another faraway look in his eyes as they slipped out of focus, but soon Sea Hawk was there with hands full of crystal mugs brimming with pink liquid. “What’s this about perfection?”

Hordak’s ears tilted back and he muttered, “Nothing.”

Sea Hawk pretended as if he hadn't heard his reply. "Perfection, other than the perfection that is my darling Mermista, is overrated. Perfection and uniformity kill the soul!" he nearly shouted, stomping one of his feet directly onto their table. Hordak's ears stayed back as he snatched his mug out of the way of Sea Hawk's antics. "Why, look at Salineas, it's the most beautiful place in the world! And its beauty is rooted, not in homogeneity, but in variety! Haha!" He took a long swig from his own mug and smacked his lips appreciatively. "The more colors in our palette, the more fantastic the scene. The more tones in our songs, the more luscious the sound." His voice lilted dramatically and he waggled his eyebrows as he made grand gestures, spilling his drink over his hand. "To limit oneself is easy, but to find harmony in the chaos is to overcome and thrive beyond! Messy things up a bit, and learn to live!" He raised his mug in a grand toast. One of the guards lifted their own drink to follow suit, but then blushed and demurred when nobody else did.

Catra snorted, "Is that what the Fright Zone was about?" she asked Hordak. "Was it an exercise in messy-ing things up, even though you preached order?"

Hordak curled his lip and stared down at his wine. "No. I was simply ineffective in establishing said order."

Catra laughed and took a sip from her drink. "At least I had that much right," she smiled.

"Indeed." He paused before opening his mouth again, but then faltered. He furrowed his brow and his manner turned thoughtful. "Compromised, ineffective, and worthless," he continued faintly. An odd, empty pang in her gut accompanied her memory of him calling her the exact same thing. "An ugly defect banished to yet another world where beauty determines worth?" He looked up again, directly at Catra, and he seemed very, very tired. "The idea was to create an alternative, where beauty is nothing and utility is everything." Catra heaved a sigh and she noticed the guards shifting uncomfortably on their side of the table. "In the Fright

Zone, the most repellant person on the planet had worth so long as they served their purpose."

The table fell into a tense silence and even Sea Hawk seemed at a loss for what to say next, settling instead into frequent small sips to hide his face behind his mug. They were saved from further awkwardness, however, when two large people appeared behind each of Sea Hawk's two shoulders. One of them was a blue feline Etherian with numerous ear piercings, the other was a large, bearded man with dark tan skin and brown hair. Both were glaring down at the table with humorless sneers.

When Sea Hawk realized where the other members of his party were looking, he gulped and slowly tilted his head back to look up at the two newcomers, which finally spurred the feline to speech. "What an interesting assembly of characters to find here in our humble little town," she said quietly, a muscle ticking in her jaw.

"I'm not surprised, but I'm disappointed all the same," the other started, "to see the depths to which you've sunk, Sea Hawk, really. You literally could not keep more despicable company." His eyes were hard with hatred.

"You look familiar, though," Catra countered hesitantly, squinting at the two. "Weren't you working for us before Prime came?"

"Yeah," the woman hissed, starting forward. The man leaned slightly into her way to stay her movement and she heeded, looking livid. "Yeah, we worked for the Horde. We had to."

"We had family and friends along the coast you conquered," the man said, looking over at Hordak, whose face was neutral, ears back to a more assertive position. "I made my living dishonestly, but I made it on the open sea." He took a deep breath and his cold smile finally turned into a twisted expression of bitterness. "To make the money we needed to survive in your hellscape, I had to answer to your trained dogs."

“Collaboration for survival isn't the same as waging the war itself.” The feline person said, looking back up at Catra. “Not to mention having the nerve to show your faces around here after war’s end.”

“We were just going,” Hordak said in a low, measured voice. He slid from his chair and pulled the familiar move of very slowly drawing himself up to his full height.

To Catra’s rising consternation, the two strangers weren’t impressed at all. Instead, the man barked out an angry laugh. “Lord Hordak! You don’t command the same presence you did the last time you were here, serving as the princess’ lapdog, and all.”

A thrill of confused agitation ran up Catra’s back at the blunt reminder of their defeat, and she sensed Hordak’s temper stir as well. They may have been beaten by the right side, but it didn’t mean they’d renounced all of their views around the princess system. Then, she noticed the tavern had gone silent. “Come on,” Catra said through clenched teeth, rising to hurry the others back out of the tavern before she lost her own temper. Sea Hawk cleared his throat and made to follow.

When Catra was free of the table, she turned around to see several people standing and frowning between her and the door. More people were rising from their seats around them, and Catra broke into a sweat while she cursed herself for her stupidity. Grim faces and clenched fists appeared all around them and Catra felt every hair on her body stand on end. “If we don’t get some back up here,” she hissed lowly, “people are going to end up dead, two of which will be us.”

“Whom,’” Hordak corrected.

“Shut up,” she snapped.

“You two,” the blue lady said, pointing at the guards. “We have no quarrel with you, but if you stand between us we’ll count you as on their side.”

The guards looked at each other for a moment before one of them glanced back at Hordak and Catra. "I care about my job, but I am *not* dying for those two." They bit their lip and threw her an agonized look that confirmed better than words that she and Hordak were very much on their own.

Without warning, the bearded pirate threw an elegant right hook directly into Hordak's face, sucker-punching him square across the jaw. "Hey!" Catra shouted automatically, even though Hordak had barely reacted. Like a triggered spring, her arm jabbed forward and she hit the offending pirate right on the nose. His eyes immediately started streaming, the feline roared in outrage, and Catra knew their window for diplomacy was closed.

Sea Hawk was a slower draw than the pirate but Hordak met his bearded opponent's sword with the bracer of his armor in a flash of sparks. Before Sea Hawk could jump in, some ally of the pirates jumped in and engaged him in a close-quarters duel, and the feline pulled a dagger on Catra. People around them made way as the ex-collaborator started slashing the air toward her experimentally, looking as if she were warming up rather than attacking. Behind her, it looked like Hordak had already bent his opponent's sword in two and was throwing off several other tavern-goers. Before she could get a good view, the feline finally lunged.

Catra used the same old trick she always used on Adora, jumped up, and drove her heel down onto the woman's back. She landed neatly on a table, the woman staggered into another, and several other tavern patrons began advancing. Before they reached her, however, she began to leap from table to table toward the door. A hand caught her ankle before out of midair before she'd reached her goal, however, and brought her down hard.

She kicked the hand off and rolled away, managing to right herself before anybody else got ahold of her. The blue feline reappeared, panting with rage and clutching her dagger. She made her next jab and Catra had just managed to catch her wrist when an elbow came out of nowhere and slammed into her cheekbone. The

disorienting blow knocked her backward and she rolled off the table she fell into. Luckily, she landed on her feet and managed to catch the dagger lady's arm in another hold with her next attack, still dazed and blinking.

An effeminate cry of warning from Sea Hawk and a snarling roar from Hordak caught all of their attention, and in her peripheral vision, Catra saw Hordak yank a knife out of his thigh and turn toward the man who'd put it there. His eyes were glowing bright as he growled a terse, "Rude."

Her own knife-wielding opponent wrenched free of her hold before she saw Hordak do anything else, and Catra was back to blocking blows while edging toward the door. Things were not looking good, and those witnesses who had merely been passive bystanders were beginning to grow more bold and interested in the bloodsport unfolding before them. She finally got a hold on the cat lady's arm and gained the leverage she needed to twist it upward violently, breaking her grip on the dagger. She thrilled with the small victory and stamped down on the knife before anybody could grab it off the floor.

Before Catra or anybody else could move further, however, a soaring body slammed into the blue feline in front of her, and the two people were knocked flying through the large window between the door and herself, shattering it with a terrific crash. For a couple of beats, the only sound while the room stared at the window was the tinkling of falling shards. Then they rallied and the fight was back on.

"Nice!" Catra shouted, punching the last person between her and the open air out of the way. Sea Hawk and his glowing sword appeared beside her and they leapt through the window together. Sea Hawk tore off up the street but Catra hesitated long enough to turn back toward Hordak, who was nearly to the broken window himself. But he was more surrounded than she'd been, with weapons aimed at him from all around in a loose ring and hands and arms dragging on every movement. One angry Etherian was latched tightly on his back, holding on for dear life.

Hordak paused for a moment as if overcome by a swarm of flies, looking more annoyed than anything. Then he grabbed the man on his back and pulled him forward, breaking his hold round his neck and freeing his shoulders. With a protracted grunt, he heaved the man's body in a wide arc, knocking several other people backward and throwing him into the rest who were nearby, clearing his retreat toward the street.

He met her eyes as he clambered over the windowsill and seemed surprised to see her there. "Don't wait, you fool," he puffed. "Run!"

Catra didn't need telling twice and tore off up the road, back toward Adora, Melog, and Safety. She could sense the entire crowd coming after them up the street as she and Hordak sprinted. The only thing she heard as they ran was their loud panting and the pounding of their feet on the packed dirt road. She began to shout as she ran, hoping that Sea Hawk's warning or Melog's keen hearing might afford them precious extra seconds. "The roads are no longer secure!" she bellowed hoarsely as she sprinted. "Angry mob! We got an angry mob!" She heard Hordak's breathing and uneven footfalls start to fall behind hers, but she knew better than to slow down. Her eyes began to water in panic as she kept screaming, pushing herself faster in hopes of reaching help in time to come back for him.

From out of nowhere, Melog pounced into the middle of the road, glowing red and growling. Close behind them were Sea Hawk and She-Ra, flanked by Mermista and Frosta, both wielding impressive shows of water and ice as they met. Relief flooded her as she made it to their midst, gasping for air but ready to brawl. She skidded to a halt at Melog's side and turned in time to see the crowd slow and eventually stop, not far behind a limping Hordak. His teeth and fists were clenched as he went, and she could see a wide stripe of slightly luminescent reddish blood that blocked out the skin between a nasty gash on his thigh and the top of his stocking.

"You okay old man?

He huffed at her and lifted a corner of his mouth. “I’m hardly bleeding to death,” he scoffed as he passed her, limping much less noticeably now that he could afford to move slower.

A flash of light announced Adora’s return and Catra turned to see her girlfriend approaching her with raised eyebrows. “It wasn’t us!” she immediately said defensively, “I swear, they were the ones who picked the fight! *We were being good*,” she insisted.

Adora wrapped her arm around her shoulders and squeezed, relaxing into a wide grin. “I know, I know, I just think it’s funny how minutes after you break for lunch, you find an angry mob.”

“I take offense at that,” Catra said in feigned outrage. “I didn’t find shit! I told you, they found me.”

“Speaking of which,” Adora said, guiding Catra around so that they were facing the slowly dispersing crowd. “Which ones laid a finger on you?”

Catra laughed and leaned her weight on Adora playfully. “Yeah right, Adora, you can lecture them when we come back tomorrow.”

Adora withdrew her arm so that she could crack her knuckles, glaring back at the crowd. “I mean it,” she said, and only then did Catra see actual rage in the other’s manner, “I don’t think they’d be so eager to surround you again if I taught them a quick lesson.”

Catra opened her mouth in surprise, trying to think of how to reply. First, she wondered if Adora was talking more love and peace and her words were merely coming out wrong, but... no, she really was angry. Then Catra looked down at herself, wondering if she appeared hurt or otherwise unwell.

When Adora made eye contact, she registered Catra’s confusion. “What?” She asked, somewhat defensively. “If it were me they were after, you’d be mad too.”

“I mean, yeah,” Catra conceded. “And I totally get why you’re pissed… I just… normally you’re not so big on the retaliation part, you know?” Adora blinked at her and seemed unsure of how to reply. “I’m not judging you or anything,” Catra tried to assure her as she continued. “It’s just a little weird to see you this angry." To her surprise, Adora scowled and crossed her arms. "Hey, I'm not trying to tell you off, here, I-"

Adora interrupted her. “So I’ve been a little angry lately, but this is *totally* justified. Don't bullshit me on this one.”

Catra felt her ears lower slightly at the cold edge on Adora’s tone before the fuming blonde continued. “Adora, I… I didn’t mean you shouldn’t be-“

“-You know what?” Adora interrupted. “Not just this, here. All of it is justified.” She took a step away and her breathing grew heavier as she clenched her teeth, gearing up for more. “It’s not like I appeared out of nowhere with the predetermined destiny of destroying the universe in an ancient suicide-mission against a despotic god, and ended up on a planet that’s been ravaged by civil war for three decades.” Catra’s ears were pinned all the way back and Adora’s voice began to rise a bit. “Not to mention I’m still the main hero and protector of said war-torn planet, which is now the new kid on the block in a universe that has just been dumped out of an intergalactic imperial system that was thousands of years old and apparently holding several worlds together!” Adora heaved in another breath to continue her rant, but paused when she realized everyone around them was staring, including several straggling members from the angry mob.

“Adora, it’s okay,” Catra began quietly, unsure of how to continue.

Adora blushed hard and seemed to demur somewhat. “It’s just a fucked up situation. I’m mad for everybody,” she said to Catra. She started rubbing her arm and Catra calmed slightly. “Whatever. Apparently I’m just unnaturally enraged because of a magically mutated murder-virus, so don’t mind me.”

Catra opened her mouth to argue, but Adora's face changed to a concerned, puzzled expression at something behind her. She turned to see Entrapta, walking toward them up high on her hair, squinting around over their heads. "Hey Entrapta," Catra said, bookmarking her conversation with Adora for later.

"Hey guys," the lavender hair princess said, furrowing her brow and looking back down at them. "Where's Hordak?"

* * * * *

Catra pointed up at the road and opened her mouth to say 'there,' but had to catch herself. "Well, he *was* walking up the road to you," she said, pointing vaguely at the empty road where Hordak had just been.

"No," Entrapta said slowly, "I just came down that road." The three women looked at each other and realized at the same exact time that Hordak had gone missing. The next instant, they were walking back up the street, spread out and peeking down alleys and around corners, calling Hordak's name as loudly as they dared without drawing unwanted attention.

"Hordak?" Entrapta called, climbing up a tilting lamppost for a better view of the street.

"Hordak?" Adora repeated, pulling aside a tattered curtain over a doorway to peer into the bombed-out building.

Catra sniffed the air, trying to see if she could pick up the scent of his blood, or anything else to follow. "Where the fuck did you go?" she muttered, moving from potential hiding spot to potential hiding spot.

"What about Hordak?" Catra looked up to see Micah and Glimmer standing in the road, watching them curiously.

“Have you seen him?” Entrapta asked, starting to sound a little worried.

“He’s missing?” the King replied with a raised brow.

“Hordak!” Entrapta shouted, moving away from the group to continue up the road. “Horda- Hordak!”

Her change in tone brought all their faces snapping up in time to see Entrapta running toward a group of four people up ahead. A clone with flaming red roots and grey eyes was supporting Hordak, who’s arm appeared to be held in a tight grip around the other’s shoulders. On either side were the bearded man and blue feline from the tavern.

“I’m fine,” Catra heard him growl as Entrapta reached the group, but Catra’s claws were out and ready when she approached.

“What the hell do you two want?” She asked the pirates suspiciously.

They merely gave her sullen looks, Hordak grunted, but the red-rooted clone spoke up. “Please forgive my neighbors their bitterness. The war was hard on us all.” He patted the hand on Hordak’s side. “I don’t think they quite understand the nature of our shared situation. Please allow me to help.” When the clone smiled and turned his head toward the others, Catra noticed that a large, nasty looking scar that stretched in a ruler-straight line from his chin up to his ear, pulling the flesh there in odd places where scar-tissue healed tight. He had clearly taken a large blade directly to the lower face. The jagged valley of healed flesh was both distracting and impressive.

The clone with his arm around Hordak’s waist refused to let him walk alone as the group returned to the lagoon, where Entrapta retrieved the medicine bag from the transport and the rest of their party slowly gathered around. While his brother helped Hordak into a sitting position on the ground, Catra watched the two pirates warily as they crossed their arms, eyeing alliance members

with open disdain. “Why the change of heart?” she finally asked them.

The man with the beard curled his lip before answering. “We are *not* okay with either of you,” he said slowly. “But we *are* okay with Scar.” He jerked his head toward the clone with red roots who was watching Entrapta dig through her medicine kit with avid interest.

“Woah, *Scar*?” Frosta exclaimed as she neared the little group. “That’s an amazing name!”

The clone named Scar pressed a hand to his chest and turned an emotional expression on the girl princess, as if she’d just deeded him a fortune. “*Thank you*,” he said emphatically. “My dentist gave it to me.” He then turned to Catra. “As I said, my neighbors here are merely uninformed.” He turned to look at them and they scowled like scolded children. “You two,” he began to reprimand, “did not read the minutes from the Alliance’s postwar Pan-Etherian meeting.”

At the same time that the blue feline said, “No shit we didn't,” Hordak yelped, “That record is public?”

Scar ignored them both. “Hordak of the Etherian Horde,” he looked back up at his seafaring friends, “volunteered for execution in exchange for the promise of pardon for collaborators such as yourselves.” The other two didn’t seem to know how to react, and Scar smiled gently at them. “He is not unaware of the evil he has done to you.”

“Well... shit," the man with the beard began, sounding very annoyed, “Now I feel like an asshole for trying to stab him.”

“*Somebody* managed to stab me,” Hordak complained through clenched teeth.

“Why weren’t you on the road?” Entrapta asked Hordak as if the others weren’t there. She was glaring at him suspiciously, eyes narrowed.

"I merely stepped aside to collect myself," he evaded.

"We've been over this before," Entrapta muttered back, scowling. "You don't have to hide it when you're hurting." Her face was stormier than her tone let on.

"I was not hid- Ouch!" Entrapta jabbed an alarmingly large needle into the meat above the gash on Hordak's leg without change in expression. He scowled sideways at her while she slowly injected him with something clear, moving the needle to different spots around the blossoming wound.

"Hey, how come She-Ra isn't healing him?" Frosta asked curiously.

Entrapta, Adora, and Catra all froze, unwilling to look even at each other. Several seconds ticked by as the people around them began to exchange looks. "Guys?" Glimmer asked. "Why isn't She-Ra healing Hordak?"

"I… I can't," Adora finally said. Catra had to fight the urge to slap a palm to her forehead. *Of course* this would finally have to come out in a crowded public setting.

"What do you mean, you can't?" Glimmer asked, cocking her head in confusion.

"I…" Catra cringed for Adora as she struggled. "I lost my healing ability." A shocked murmur swept the crowd and she saw several worried faces exchanging looks.

"Like it's not working for you right now?" Mermista asked, looking concerned.

"Like something happened to She-Ra, and now she can't do any constructive magic," Catra offered.

"What happened?!" Frosta exclaimed.

Adora sighed and sat down next to Hordak, slumping. "It started with that dumb virus. We think it mutated or something and

became more communicable between integrated tech. Because She-Ra is literally a part of me now, stopping it isn't as easy as separating me from the sword."

Glimmer swore and Micah sighed heavily. "Are you okay?" he asked.

"Yeah, for the most part. I'm kind of like, feeling rage for no reason now? I don't know." Adora shrugged and gave the ground miserable look. "It sucks but it's not the worst. I can still be the same heavy hitter I've always been."

The group lapsed into relative silence for several minutes, each lost in their own thoughts as mutters and whispers punctuated the air. Unsurprised and unaffected, Entrapta finished cleaning out the cut on Hordak's leg and brought out a little laser pen with one strand of hair. Then she held the two sides of Hordak's cut together with one hand, started stapling with the other, and followed up with the unpleasantly sizzling red laser. "Hold still," she commanded impatiently when he jumped and growled.

"Well," Glimmer finally said, "this is… this is unfortunate. Really, extremely unfortunate." Catra felt Adora flinch. "But we can handle this. She-Ra isn't gone, she's just working through some stuff. In the meantime, Etheria can handle itself." She gave the crowd a bracing look. "There's a lot of competent people ready to pick up the slack."

"I'm so sorry," Adora muttered.

"Shut up," Catra said.

Perfuma, infinitely more tactful, leaned forward and braced both of her hands on Adora's shoulders. "Don't be sorry. Adora comes first, and we've got this. It's probably best that we don't rely on She-Ra too much, anyway."

Catra gave her an appreciative look and nudged Adora's shoulder. "See? We don't need you. We barely even like you."

To her relief, Adora snorted and smiled. “That’s not what you said last night,” she muttered to Catra. The others pretended not to hear.

Chapter End Notes

> If it's convenient and you happen to have a thought or opinion, I humbly request any feedback you’ve got. It is very much appreciated.

"It's been a weird evening. Let's drink."

Chapter Summary

Catra gets trapped in a very awkward situation, after which Hordak and Entrapta sort a few things out.

Chapter Notes

Turns into smut like, a third of the way through?

The rest of the day went more or less smoothly. She cleaned the abrasion on her cheek and took something for the headache she could feel coming, but otherwise moved on with her day comfortably enough. Entrapta was busy planning her designs, the lagoon had been cleared of trash and debris, and they retired for the day after promising lingering locals that Perfuma and Daisy would be back tomorrow to finish up. Thankfully, the episode at the tavern seemed to have taken some of the steam out of the town's hostility and maintaining the perimeter was easy and she was able to have fun with Adora after their nerves had quieted somewhat. Hordak managed to spend the time standing still, leaning his weight on one leg while talking to Entrapta and working on whatever she placed on the table before him. He had, of course, refused to quit early, and he was so imperious and final about it that nobody pushed him.

Once they were all finally on the transport home, Bow and Glimmer motioned her over to where they stood talking to Perfuma. Melog was sitting nearby and observing, as ever. "We wanted to ask a favor," Perfuma said as she drew near.

She sighed. "Of course you do." Melog gave her a reproachful mrrp.

We just wanted you to check and make sure that Hordak's not hiding a more serious injury than he's letting on," Bow said.

Catra shut her eyes and pinched the bridge of her nose. Hordak was a grown ass man who didn't need, and *certainly* wouldn't appreciate their coddling. “Why?” she asked without looking at them.

“Teambuilding or whatever,” Glimmer replied.

Catra continued to pinch her nose while she contemplated whether or not it was worth telling them to fuck off. She ended up deciding against it when Melog shot her an extended meow, flicking their tail impatiently. “Fine,” she relented, looking at Melog rather than the others. “Fucking fine.”

Catra let Adora know she’d catch up with her and Melog later, and when the transport landed she began to tail Entrapta and Hordak as they made their way down to the cellars, moving slowly for Hordak’s limp. His hearing would have been a problem, but Entrapta’s constant chatter about her new bots was sufficient cover.

She was dangerously exposed for a moment when she leapt through the sliding lab doors behind them, but she was fast and silent as she dodged behind a giant piece of machinery. If Hordak was suspicious, he did not voice it. She waited until she could hear them walking away from her before she peeked, taking opportunities for cautious climbing when Entrapta grew especially loud in her excitement.

They slowly began removing Hordak’s armor and Catra heard him wince as every port was disengaged. She shuddered when she remembered watching Prime puncture his neck port with one of his weird sharp hair-tubey things, and how very upsetting the scene had been… the way Prime dropped him when he was done and moved on with his conversation like he’d finished a snack. Easy as anything.

“I think most of the pulling on your new dress will right itself in the wash. I don’t see any major cuts or rips, which is nice. It should be easy to clean up, nearly good as new.” Entrapta finished

talking right as Catra leapt up onto the piping in an especially shadowy corner of the ceiling. Then she settled into a crouch as he leaned on a worktable and Entrapta set to cleaning the cut on his thigh again. “Any other stab wounds, gashes or cuts?” She asked breezily.

“A few cuts, if that,” Hordak replied, sighing heavily. Imp appeared from their bedroom and fluttered onto Hordak’s shoulder, watching Entrapta curiously.

“Broken bones or damaged muscle? Anything at all?”

“Minor bruising. Nothing serious.”

Catra rolled her eyes at the insistent care the princesses continued to push on Hordak and her. He was fucking fine, and now she was stuck until they either decided to leave the lab or she had a sufficient diversion for escape. Best she could hope for was that Entrapta might blow something up sooner rather than later.

Entrapta kept talking as Catra kept spying, turning to cleaning said scrapes and bruises. “Mermista really nailed your dress. You make it look *very* good.” Catra scrunched her face and Hordak snorted, looking away like a shy kid. “What?” Entrapta asked through an indulgent smile.

“Your compliments are very kind,” he muttered, as if to himself.

“Do you believe me, or do you just think I’m just being nice?” Entrapta sounded uncharacteristically unsure as she stopped what she was doing and glanced at his expression.

“No, no I believe you,” Hordak hurried to assure her. “I’m merely glad… uh… I’m glad my physical presence still holds interest for you.” Catra immediately began looking for a different way out of the room.

Entrapta heaved a long, heavy sigh before she said. “You’re beautiful, Hordak. I thought I’d made it clear that I think your

body is beautiful.” Was it too late to just jump into the open and sprint for the exit?

“And I believed as much but…”

“But?” Entrapta prompted.

“I assumed that had more to do with… scientific curiosity. You find pure data to be a beautiful concept, as well.”

“Oookay,” Entrapta said, and Catra could hear her changing tac. “Your body is beautiful in a way that… shit. Okay. When I look at you without clothes on… well, nevermind on that one too. Hmmm.”

'Fuck fuck fuck fuck' Catra mouthed to herself. She couldn't see any holes cut in the rock for the piping and ducting that were big enough for her to fit through. Catra would have to either cover her ears and stick it out, or she'd have to reveal herself and immediately run away from everyone and everything they knew.

“Entrapta, it’s fine. You’ve already given me more-”

Entrapta interrupted him, still making her point. “You’re not just a scientific specimen, Hordak. With you... like, *you* you, it’s never been about the science. It’s always just been you.”

Maybe if Catra could figure out a big enough distraction… knocked over machinery or somehow caused an explosion or something. Maybe she'd be able to get to the doors in time to at least pretend she'd only just arrived. If only, *if only* she was carrying explosives. Why the fuck didn’t she carry explosives?

Silence stretched for what felt like a long time, until Hordak finally broke it. “Imp,” he began in a soft, gentle voice, “Entrapta and I would like some privacy for this conversation, please.”

Catra’s entire body thrilled with dread. When the fuck did Imp show up? Regardless, she heard his little wings flapping as he took flight. For a moment it seemed like he was headed for the

sliding doors and Catra thought she might be saved, but then he made a wide turn in the air before soaring up into the ductwork. He didn't see her at first, and she held as still as a statue, hands pressed over her mouth so that he wouldn't hear her breath. But then Imp began sniffing the air suspiciously, and Catra knew she was fucked.

"Your body is attractive and desirable. Do you understand that?" Entrapta asked in a gentle but insistent voice. "Why is that so hard for you to accept?" Catra wrinkled her nose and would have pressed her hands over her ears if she wasn't frozen before Imp's searching gaze. Instead, she started imagining Swift Wind's obnoxious singing in her head and tried to concentrate on that. Anything to distract. Imp narrowed his glowing yellow eyes and scanned, sniffing all the while. Before long, he finally locked eyes with Catra.

She began shaking her head and making a desperate pleading motion with her hands, but her stomach sank with his slow, wicked grin. She waited for him to sound the alarm, but to her great surprise, Imp raised a finger to his mouth in a gesture to hush her. He then motioned for her to follow him.

Catra only hesitated a moment, but she knew Imp was her best option at this point. As she began to follow, she moved slowly, careful only to shift her weight during active conversation.

"Hordak, why do you think I prefer to fuck with a light source?" Entrapta asked.

"So you can see what you're doing?"

"I… okay you got me there. But it's also so that I can see *you.*" Imp lead Catra toward a far corner where a giant pipe was sticking out of a large opening in the bare rock. Hope and relief flooded her at the sight of a potential exit, but progress was still slow going.

"But… why?" Hordak continued like the dumbass he was.

“Hordak,” Entrapta's tone was patient, but exasperated. “*Because I love you*.” Entrapta seemed to pause to collect her thoughts. “How about this- you like looking at *my* body, right?”

“*Of course* I do.” Catra only had a few more yards to go, but the span would necessitate at least two jumps.

“Well, I like looking at you too,” Entrapta slowly reasoned for him.

“But that doesn’t make sense.”

“How does it not make sense?" Entrapta's voice rose slightly in frustration and Catra took the opportunity to make her first leap. She froze when she landed with a soft fwump, squeezing her eyes shut in dread, but the conversation below and behind her continued. "You like *me*... I like *you*... you like spending time kissing me, don’t you?”

“Yes, but that is completely different,” Hordak replied, and Catra could tell his frustration was also rising.

“What? How?!”

“You have lips." Catra barely caught herself in time to stifle her snort, pressing a fist over her mouth and screwing up her face. “Did you hear something?” Hordak asked, and Catra’s heart skipped a beat.

“Don’t change the subject,” Entrapta ordered sternly. “I think I see the miscommunication here.” She took another steadying breath and Catra cursed the drop in their tones. “Hordak, I don’t like kissing your lips-”

“Or lack thereof.”

Entrapta sighed patiently. “Or lack thereof- just because I like kissing lips. I like kissing your lips because they’re *your* lips.”

“Or lack thereof. Wait… what?”

“Yep,” Entrapta answered cheerfully. “Every beautiful inch, remember? And I feel like it’s kind of the same with you. I mean, I wouldn’t be surprised if lady mammal lumps and bumps generally appealed to you-”

“Not generally, no.” Catra rolled her eyes.

“See? It’s because they’re *my* lumps and bumps, right? It’s the same exact thing as how I feel about you.” Another long stretch of silence kept Catra motionless, and she saw Imp watching her from the corner of her eye. “I feel like this is short-circuiting your brain a little bit. Do you need a break?”

Hordak heaved a lengthy sigh. “No, I’m listening.”

“Hordak, I don’t love you *despite* your body. I love your body too. And *yes* that means I think it’s physically attractive," she insisted emphatically. "Not beautiful in the same way as, for instance, Catra’s body is beautiful,” Catra couldn’t help but snap her head around in alarm at the sound of her name, “but *just* as beautiful in its own right. Even *more* beautiful, to me, in fact.” Imp crossed his arms and Catra motioned desperately for him to be patient before Entrapta finally continued. “It’s just… it’s hard for me to put into words. I’m going to think about it though, alright?” Hordak must have nodded, because Entrapta didn’t press the point. "Good. Now I want you off that leg for a bit."

Hordak started to argue and Catra took the opportunity to make her final leap. There wasn't much landing space and she was sure she must have made some noise, but Imp had judged the size correctly and she was crawling through the opening before she heard anything more.

The channel which the ductwork had been assembled in was wet from the seepage filtering through the rock, collecting in a slow trickle that moved down the center of the dark tunnel. Imp scampered ahead of her, out of sight, moving easily through the pitch-black space with the aid of his glowing eyes. Catra, on the other hand, wasn't even able to go on her hands and knees

properly without knocking her head or scraping her back on the rough stone ceiling. She followed Imp's pale glow as she crawled forward on her elbows, slipping through areas where slimy algae growth coated the walls, thoroughly soaking her front and getting moss and cave scum all over herself. She passed many places in the rock where ductwork or piping branched down smaller passages through which she could not fit, but it took a long time before Imp lead her to an exit she could use.

Once she'd toppled out of a grate onto a stone floor somewhere near the kitchens, Imp fluttered down to the floor beside her, mocking her with a high-pitched giggle. She didn't let it get to her. "Thanks, little shit," she huffed, lurching to her feet and looking down at the state of herself. Her clothes were soggy and she was covered in green and black sludge. She looked back up at Imp when he kicked her foot and screeched, spreading his arms expectantly. "Right," she continued, narrowing her eyes. "What do I owe you for that?"

He opened up his mouth and replayed Entrapta's voice saying, "...felt almost like respect."

Catra thought about the situation as she slowly lowered herself to a kneel, frowning in seriousness. "You're absolutely right. People are already here and *she* seems busy for the evening." She ignored a small shudder, "Plus our workday is over." He crossed his arms and nodded his head at her. "Alright Imp, I think I know where we might find them. Let's go fuck shit up." His wicked little cackle sounded again as he took to the air, flapping leisurely around her as she stalked back up through the palace.

Just as she expected, they found Adora, Melog, Glimmer, Bow, Perfuma, Scorpia, Mermista, Sea Hawk, and Frosta all clustered around one end of the enormous coral table in Mermista's dining hall. Imp's deafening screech announced their arrival and as the group turned to stare at her, one by one noticing her state of disarray, she spotted a large tray with cups and bottles. Imp circled above them once before he flapped down to land on

Scorpia's shoulder, leaning over to sniff the flowers in Perfuma's hair before giving Catra another malevolent grin.

Melog rose to meet her, peering curiously at her clothing. "And you, I'm mad at you," Catra said to them as they sniffed at her. '*Did I tell you he was fucking fine? Because I told you he was fine*,' she added silently.

"Catra?" Adora asked in faint bewilderment.

"Scorpia and I need to talk to you all about Entrapta," Catra said as she rounded the table into their midst.

"Oohh," Scorpia said, realization dawning. "Oh yeah, we actually do."

"What happened to you?" Adora asked as Catra came to stand between her and Glimmer.

"I got stuck spying and had to hear Entrapta explain to Hordak why she thinks he's prettier than me," she heaved a sigh and ignored the stunned looks around her. "But that's beside the point," she explained, leaning forward to grab a full cup. Before looking back up, she took another long, deep breath, trying to collect herself. Then she raised the glass as she looked around the room. "It's been a weird evening, let's drink."

* * * * *

Entrapta finished applying the waterproof membrane over the wound on Hordak's thigh as he leaned heavily on the worktable behind him. "Good. Now I want you off that leg for a bit." Entrapta backed away from where he leaned against a table, holding out her hands before her in case he needed steadying.

"It's still early," he protested, "I am not tired or pained, and if there is more to be done with the bots I would-"

Entrapta interrupted to talk over him. "I'm going to get ready for bed, too," she said softly, offering him a gentle smile.

"...oh," he said lamely, before taking one of her hands and standing. Without his armor on, the pain that pulsed from the wound on his thigh with every step was severe. He accepted Entrapta's help and did his best to stay dignified as he limped back through their bedroom toward the bathing quarters.

He spoke over the rush of water in the shower area as she handed him his toothbrush, already scrubbing the inside of her mouth vigorously. "You know, on any other clone this wound would be halfway healed by now."

She held a finger up while she brushed her teeth. For Hordak, who had perpetually sensitive teeth, her relish for the activity was astonishing. She'd explained, however, that she hated the feeling of "mossy" teeth more than the brushing. He hadn't questioned her further about the moss.

After another half minute or so of brushing, Entrapta finally spit and rinsed her mouth out before speaking. "A- that's an exaggeration. B- you still heal faster than the average Etherian, which counted and will continue to count as a distinct advantage," she reminded him cheerfully, drawing another grumble from him.

Bathing that night was not a graceful process, him leaning and wincing, her wrestling with semi-cooperative hair, both trying to guard their breath beneath the constant and somewhat aggressive flow of water. Once finished, he looked over to where

she was still fighting her hair, but she waved him off helping her. Reluctantly, he retreated to a dry towel and fresh nightgown, casting frustrated glances back at her every time she caught a little too much water between breaths and sputtered. Entrapta was finished and out of the shower soon, however, tucking a towel around herself before wrapping her hair up to carry over to Hordak on their bed.

The task of helping her hair to brush itself was slowly growing more laborious, but it was a ritual he found soothing. He loved it when her hair was down. Even though it acted on its own less than it used to, he reveled in watching it shift and sway around her as she moved, the way it drooped forward when she dipped her head or how her shoulders peeked through the soft curtain. It was a genuine pleasure to run his fingers through her heavy silken locks, breathing in the scent of her soap while they worked together to towel-dry it in sections.

He probably enjoyed her haircare routine more than he should have, considering it was now a source of bother for her. But while he watched her carefully crawl over his injured leg so he could braid her hair, he reasoned it was just as well. His hands, far larger than hers, were better suited to the job anyway, and he was happy to help however he could. With her back to him, he sectioned her hair slowly and gently, coiling the pieces into stacks and luxuriating in the way the light shone off her many shades of lavender as he twisted her hair between his dark blue claws.

The towel she still had wrapped around herself was growing less functional as they moved, revealing the scarring on her back then sagging lower still. The taut pulling of webby scar tissue was at once intimately familiar to him, and far too profane for her glowing skin. He let his gaze drop lower still, to where the edge of her towel dipped just below the dimples on her lower back.

Hordak resituated her unbraided hair and she scooted further away to supply tension. This time when the smell of her soap wafted off her damp strands, he was struck with the very clear impulse to make her smell of himself instead. He froze

momentarily with her hair in his hands, appalled that he would slip down such a vulgar line of thought when he should have been concerned with her feelings. As he continued and neared the end of her braid, however, the line of thought was difficult to resist.

He watched the muscles in her back move while she wiggled further away from him, thinking about how soft, how wonderfully *warm* she was, and how nice it felt when they slept skin to skin. Then, when she turned and handed him a little cuff to clip on the end of her braid, he stole a glance at where she held the ends of her towel loosely against her chest. She made the briefest eye contact with him when he trailed his fingers over hers while taking the cuff, and a small smile curved her mouth as she turned back around.

Entrapta heaved a deep sigh, closed her eyes, and rolled her shoulders slowly before turning to face him again. He watched the lines of her neck as she stretched and sighed, stealing glances down at her mostly exposed breasts. When she opened her eyes again to look at him, her eyelids were heavy with weariness. A spark of interest flared in them, however, when they flicked downward from his face.

Hordak blushed as he realized the beginning of an erection was visible beneath the thin black fabric between his legs, and Entrapta had caught sight of the fact. “Please, pay no mind whatsoever, it is entirely unintentional,” he said hurriedly, fumbling with the blankets around him and piling them in his lap. It was obvious and impulsive, and he soon found himself folding his hands on the pile of bedding in front of him, avoiding her eyes and failing to keep his ears from lowering.

She turned on the bed so that she was sitting fully in profile. She still held the edges of her towel to her chest, legs pulled up at an angle and tiny feet wiggling in the sheets. She rested her face against her knees and looked at him in silence as quiet stretched between them for several long moments. She didn’t hold eye contact for long, but she kept her gaze gentle as it wavered

between his shoulders. “I guess we should probably talk about a few things, huh?”

He wasn’t sure what she was trying to get at but nodded softly in encouragement. “Anything.”

She took a deep breath and stared at the covers in his lap with a furrowed brow, then down at her chest where she was still clutching her towel. After a few moments she shut her eyes and scrunched her nose. “Hang on. I can’t think straight.” He watched her hop off the bed and cross the room, braid dangling behind her nearly at floor level. She ditched the towel in favor of panties and an oversized shirt, then she donned her work gloves before returning. “That’s better,” she sighed, crawling up to sit cross-legged between his lower legs so that they were directly facing one another. Silence continued, however. Moments slipped past and again, it felt jarring to Hordak that Entrapta was somehow lost for words.

“Entrapta,” he began, desperate to clear the flow of conversation between them. “If I have said or done anything to give you pause…” he trailed off, hovering painfully.

She smiled bitterly and shook her head at his clenched hands. “I should have known you’d assume you did wrong.” She sighed heavily and finally raised her eyes back to his. “But it’s my fault.”

He cocked his head, confused. “Pardon?”

She bit her lower lip and looked away again, appearing more tired and dejected than angry or sad. “I figured it would have been a bad idea to have sex with you while I was…” She was still looking away and her eyes grew overbright. “You know, while I was, like, really feeling the stress. I mean, you know what they say about sticking your dick in crazy,” she forced a chuckle and chanced a glance at his mystified face. “No, no I suppose you wouldn’t be familiar with that particular turn of phrase.” She sighed and looked away again. “Anyway, I figured you probably weren’t into manic, mean me.”

“I don’t understand,” he said weakly as tears began to roll slowly down her cheeks.

She sniffed and continued in a thick, hoarse voice. “And then I went and had a meltdown, and I figured you’d *definitely* have plenty to work through after seeing *that*.”

Hordak could tell she was working herself up and broke in. “No matter how agitated you were, it was a worthwhile price to pay for proximity to you,” he tried to assure her, but her face crumpled and she curled up into a ball again, gripping her knees with her thickly gloved hands.

“I showed you way too much crazy,” she said, fully sobbing now.

He moved to reach for her but stopped himself, remembering that she would come to him when she was ready for the contact. He kept leaning toward her, however, with a hand extended on the blankets as he continued, “I’ve been careful to give you space because…" this time it was Hordak who found himself at a loss for words, though in his case it was out of cowardice.

She picked her head up and peered at him with bloodshot eyes. “Why?”

He took a breath and closed his eyes. “Because I have a relationship with intimacy… which… I know can be wearing.”

Her face softened into a look of beleaguered concern. “Nothing about you is wearing to me,” she said, inching closer. “I just wish I’d paid better attention back when we started having sex. I’m so sorry I never realized how badly you’ve been hurt.”

He smiled and shook his head. “Don’t be. I wouldn’t trade a moment of it for anything.”

“Still?” she leaned her cheek on her knee again, glancing at his eyes intermittently.

“Always.”

“Even though you had to clean up after my crazy?” She tried a wan smile.

“*You are not crazy,*” he said, furrowing his brow and leaning further toward her. “And nothing about what you went through made me want you any less.” She sniffed and peeked up at him from behind her knees again. “You are forever the brightest star in my universe.” She slowly reached forward and grabbed hold of his extended hand by the fingers, holding them loosely, but her eyes still looked tired and sad. “Do you believe me?”

“Turning the tables on me?” she asked, smiling at him.

He sighed. “I didn’t mean to, but I suppose similar trouble with suspending disbelief may be situationally applicable.”

“I want you,” she said weakly, squeezing his fingers again.

“I want you too,” he murmured. He watched her calm herself slowly, trying to think of anything that might cheer her up without reminding her of her stress levels. “In fact,” he began hesitantly. “When it comes... uh... comes to wanting you..." He cleared his throat, "I’m afraid I really can’t help myself.” Her smile became a little more genuine and she scooted closer still, so he went on. “I love that your hair often smells like mechanical oil, and I also love the smell of your soap, but while I was braiding your hair," He sighed and tried to steel himself against an oncoming blush, "I just wanted to make you smell like me instead.”

She raised her eyebrows before smiling warmly, perking up somewhat as she faced him. She gave him a wet chuckle before she said, “That’s actually pretty hot.”

He snorted. “Is it?”

She nodded and moved closer still, giving him a slow, impish grin. “Does that mean you want to fool around?”

He took a deep breath and smirked back at her. “Very much so.”

She unfolded her legs and hopped off the bed to set up her sound dome. He watched her with a smile as she bounced around the room, braid swinging madly and clanging off of whatever she passed, excitement in her eyes once more.

Once she surrounded them with a dome of glittering, pink, sound-absorbing energy, she clambered up onto the bed. "I love you so much," she said, smiling and keeping her eyes low. He kept his hurt leg out straight she crawled into his lap and managed to suppress the wince when her leg brushed over the wound on his thigh, but she felt the staples there. "Fuck," she whispered and froze. Then she heaved a disappointed sigh and slumped. "I forgot about your leg."

He nearly laughed. "As if that would stop me,"

She raised an eyebrow at him. "Hordak, fucking would definitely make it worse."

"I'll be easy on it," he said somewhat mindlessly as brought his face to her neck and breathed deep. "But I am not about to squander the attentions of the most remarkable Princess in all Etherian history."

"Hordak," she reprimanded with a smile in her voice.

"The most brilliant mind and generous heart I have ever known," he continued through a grin, moving to kiss her temple.

"Stop," she giggled.

"Entrapta," he murmured into the soft spot behind her ear. He felt from her movements against him that she was slowly removing her gloves. "Let your hair loose?"

She paused for a moment. "I feel a little bad… you just finished braiding it."

"I can re-braid it when you fix my leg," he cajoled, breathing deeply and kissing the spot where her shoulder and neck met.

She shrugged before she lifted her bare hands up to the sides of his head and stroked her thumbs over his cheeks. “You make your own decisions,” she sighed, though she was smiling as she lifted her lips to his.

Their kiss was unhurried and gentle. She wrapped her arms around his neck and deepened the kiss while he cradled the back of her head with one hand and combing out her braid with the other. As her fingers trailed to his collarbones, he knew a question was coming. “Hordak?” she asked, pausing their kiss to lean back slightly.

“Yes?”

“Feel free to say no, like seriously.” She fixed him with a pointed glare. “Please say no if you’re not ready…” she paused.

“But you were wondering…” he prompted, lifting a brow.

“I was wondering if I could take your nightgown off this time. You know, ready access to all of you?” She glanced at him again from beneath her lavender lashes.

He hesitated, biting his lower lip, but then nodded. She beamed in response and kissed him again, pressing her palms to his chest and grinning against his mouth. “You’re going first, though,” he muttered, sliding his hands up under her shirt, lifting it as he caressed up her sides around to the back of her shoulders.

“Naturally,” she agreed, moving to help him pull the thing off her head and hair.

With her hands otherwise occupied, he quickly slipped an arm back around her waist and pulled her more firmly up against him, happily ignoring the bloom of pain in his leg. She smiled and lifted a few fingers to one of his ears, stroking lightly and drawing an unintentional chirp from the back of his throat that made her giggle. A sweet smile lit up her face as she wrapped her short legs around his middle and squeezed playfully.

He finished releasing her hair and leaned back to watch as she shook it out around herself. Everything about her sparkled and glowed with the light of her sound dome, but even without the flattering setting, she was easily the most magnificent thing he'd ever seen. "My magical Princess," he whispered, mostly to himself. "How could I ever not want you?"

She scrunched her nose but kept smiling, and he felt a few tendrils of hair snake up one of his arms and pull it back around her. While he still had the room, he hooked a claw into the front of her underwear and pulled it forward lightly, breathing deep and growling at the growing scent of her arousal. Entrapta gave an impatient little growl of her own and hastened to wiggle out of the garment in an awkward series of maneuvers, grumbling about inefficient clothing as she did so.

When she got back to straddling him, he leaned his forehead on her shoulder, taking deep, slow breaths, mouth already watering. "I don't suppose you'd be interested in updating your record," he ventured, licking his lips.

"I never thought I'd say this, but think I'm a little tired for that tonight." She sighed. "I want to do another round of testing again soon," she said, smiling and waggling her eyebrows at him.

When she shivered in his arms before he'd done anything to trigger it, he remembered that it was always a bit cold in the cellars, so he moved them down on the bed where he could pull the blankets up over her. He settled on his side next to her, bad leg resting on top of the other, holding her close to him and leaning over her slightly.

He felt a small, warm hand appear on his hip and press a thumb to the flesh just inside the line of bone. He bit both lips and she nuzzled her face into his neck before the hand on his hip began to gather up the fabric of his nightclothes. He took a deep breath and stole himself before he sat up, keeping his leg at a straight angle, and pulled the nightgown off over his head.

With his eyes shut, Hordak flopped back onto the bed and took a few breaths. He wasn't baring anything she hadn't seen before, he was merely baring all of it at the same time, which he knew shouldn't have made a difference. Yet for some reason, he was unable to meet her eyes for several seconds. When he finally did, however, the hunger in her expression was flagrant.

Then, to his dismay, she seemed to remember herself, schooling her expression somewhat, and the change struck him like a personal loss.

Hordak thought of the things she'd just said, about repelling him by showing too much of herself. His gut clenched slightly and leaned back over her, lifting her hair away to the side so that it didn't get caught beneath them. "I want you so badly, all the time. I *crave* you, my Princess," he whispered to her, their faces inches apart. She kissed him at the same time as gently lifting her knee up against his rapidly hardening erection. He groaned and she took the opportunity to slip her tongue into his mouth and dart it across his fangs. When he slid his own tongue into her mouth, she responded heatedly, wrapping her arms back around his neck and sighing.

A purr rumbled to life in his chest and thrummed lightly between them, and he felt another smile grace her lips as she pressed them against his. As their kiss built, he cradled her shoulders in one arm and ran his free hand over her body, relieved to feel she'd gained a bit of weight since the end of the war.

Embracing there in the comfortable warmth, there were only two instances when he flinched away from her with thoughts of Prime. Both times they recovered much more fluidly than they had before, and by the time he was kissing his way down over her collarbones toward her breasts, Prime was again completely forgotten.

He purred through an open mouth, breathing deeply and tasting her with his lips and tongue as he made his leisurely way down her chest. The wound in his thigh burned as he readjusted

himself, but he barely noticed, caught up instead by the warm little fingers he felt thread their way through his hair. He pressed lingering kisses along the delicate valley of skin between her breasts, reveling in the unfathomably soft heat that surrounded his face and ears as he did, while he made his slow way down her chest, awkwardly scooting his stiffening leg. Though it took some maneuvering, the haze of lust between them was still crackling with energy when he finally lifted a breast toward his face to kiss the burning skin there, she gave him a contented little noise that sent a powerful thrill through his lower abdomen. He nuzzled, kissed, and caressed her and she wiggled her hips more insistently beneath him, sending shocks of tingling heat from his chest down his gut, straight to his swollen cock.

The scent of their arousal grew thicker on the air dragged the tip of his tongue lightly around one of her areolas. She hummed and sighed as he drew her nipple into his mouth and let his free hand return to roving over her body. He caught her stare when he looked back up into her face and lightly held the taught bud between his teeth, laving it with his tongue. The eye contact she gave him shot a strong jolt throughout his body and he reflexively gripped her tighter, trying to stay mindful of his claws. He bit gently, staring, then sucked. Her lashes fluttered and he let himself settle into the feeling of her fingers in his hair and at the back of his head, holding his face gently to her breast. Another low growl rumbled against her supple flesh through the heavy purring, and she rewarded him with a shaky sigh and more caresses along his ears.

It hadn't really been very long since they'd last had sex, and it hadn't become an awkward topic between them, but as he sank deeper into the worship of her body, Hordak railed against himself for ever allowing her to feel unwanted. He released her nipple from his mouth with a sigh and nipped the underside of her breast, lifting his eyes back to hers. She jerked slightly and giggled at the sensation, and he smiled back up at the beautiful sight. "You are… *everything,*" he murmured to her, frustrated at the monumental inadequacy of his words.

“I love you, Hordak,” she whispered, grabbing his head behind his ears and curling forward so she could press a kiss to his forehead. For some reason the simple action made his eyes water and he blushed. She tilted his chin up with a finger and kissed his lips again. “So beautiful.”

She lay back on her pillows and he kissed his way to her other nipple. While he held her ribcage up to his face with one hand beneath her back, he indulged in gently squeezing handfuls of her unbelievable softness with his free hand, running his fingers over every inch of skin within reach. His touch was drawn again and again toward the luxurious valley of softest flesh where her thighs pressed together, but he was too engrossed with her breasts to split his attention yet. While one of her hands stayed anchored in his hair, he felt the other start roaming over his shoulders and upper back, stroking and gripping at what she could reach with her head tilted back, eyes lightly shut while her expressions shifted gently.

When she slung a leg partially over his back, the scent of her liquid desire made his head spin and he groaned with bestial hunger. He finally relented to the draw on his senses and ran a greedy palm up and down an inner thigh, his breathing growing heavier still. Her fingers stilled in his hair and on his shoulder, and for a moment the only sound was his low purr and the hum of her sound dome around them. Then, ever so slowly, he eased his large hand between her thighs to cup her sex, lifting his eyes to watch her face. Her expression was utterly exquisite, twisted lightly between relieved pleasure and raw indulgence, and his cock twitched eagerly when he felt her honey-sweet wetness slip between his fingers and over his hand.

Entrapta took a deep breath and looked back down at him, staring with heavy-lidded eyes as he pulled his hand away, fingers glistening with her nectar. Then, while he continued to observe her expressions, he brought his hand to his mouth and started licking it, uttering a small groan as he did so. He shut his eyes in rapture at the taste of her and when he was finished with his fingers, he shot her a dark look and smirked, moving further down

her body and pulling the covers back over his head to keep her warm. “Hordak,” she sighed contentedly from above him, arching up into his touch as he kissed the burning skin beneath her naval with all due reverence.

Entrapta was usually a fairly forceful partner in bed, but tonight she seemed happy to simply enjoy herself and soak up his attentions, and that suited him just as well. On even footing and under honest circumstances, he found that he very much liked the idea of devouring her, so to speak.

While he didn't know how to express his desire in a way that mattered, he did know that using his mouth to express himself in *other* ways usually turned out well enough. He lowered his head between her thighs and brought his mouth near her fragrant slick. “You are the most precious aspect of my existence,” he rumbled, and could only hope she believed him. “My wonderful, wonderful partner. I would not change anything about you.” He heard her gulp thickly before he leaned forward and kissed both lips between her legs gently. Although he was in an awkward position for it, he palmed both her inner thighs and pressed down, spreading her legs open wide with enough force to make her gasp. He brought his face to hover scant centimeters from her entrance, panting softly while he moved his hands from her thighs around to her hips, lifting them up to his face.

Finally, Hordak buried his tongue in her core and drank deeply. They groaned in tandem and she graced him with a breathy little cry. The cry turned into a strangled groan as he curled his tongue firmly upward and dragged it back, gathering as much of her intoxicating essence in his mouth as he could before closing his lips around her clit for another long, firm kiss. The delectable taste and smell of her flooded his senses and began to overwhelm him with foggy euphoria. His purring surged again as he started licking her slowly, closing his eyes in rapture and letting himself slip deeper into the spell she cast around them.

A trancelike state settled over him as he listened to her sighs and gasps turn to open moaning, laying on his chest with her lower

body cradled in his arms. One arm was wrapped around a warm thigh, which he held up against his ear. The other was wrapped behind her lower back, forearm propping her up for easier access and palm wrapped tightly around her waist and hip. He let his eyes roll back and close lazily, alternating between licking, suckling and nibbling at his leisure, drinking greedily through his heavy breathing as he did so.

It felt like he'd only been feasting for scant moments when her moans changed in pitch and he felt a slight tremor in the thigh against his ear. He grumbled and readjusted as if to pospone an alarm, quite unwilling to break his reverie. He let her clit be for the time being and instead gave in to the animal pleasure of working his tongue up into her dripping channel. She gave a sharp cry and he held her hips steady as they bucked against his face, growling into her savagely. He licked and probed, tasting everything he could of her complex inner textures as he drove his tongue ever deeper. Her back arched rigid and she gasped breathlessly when he extended his tongue as far as his jaw would allow, and growled his indulgent satisfaction against her dripping sex.

The muscles within her clenched and rippled around his tongue and he moaned helplessly into her, cock jumping at the sensation. Then he withdrew far enough to start massaging the tip of his tongue up into their favorite, yielding rough patch at the front. "Hordak," she whimpered. His mouth was full so he simply growled in reply. "*Please*, hurry up and fuck me!... Oh… haaah, I want to watch you-" She dissolved into jerky whimpers through her panting.

With a loud groan he reluctantly tore himself from her crux and took several steadying breaths above her, blinking hard and shaking his head slightly to try and clear it. He licked his lips and lifted his gaze to see her staring at him with sparkling eyes and flushed, parted lips. She was so breathtakingly beautiful that he quite forgot what he was in the middle of. Her hair fanned out around her head where she lay back on their pillows, hands fisted in the sheets beside her. Her face was shining, her cheeks glowed

dark pink, and her chest heaved with heavy breathing. Instead of reflecting mischievous hedonism, her eyes shone big and round with startling earnestness. Even though she cast searching glances down at his obnoxious erection, she did not ogle as lasciviously as usual. As the silence began to stretch and the cool air between them flushed her dewy body with gooseflesh, she searched his face with laser focus, drawing him in like a moth to a flame.

Ignoring the stab in his leg when he used it to brace his weight, Hordak moved slowly up the bed. Entrapta continued to watch his face as he nudged his hips up between her thighs and rested his elbows on either side of her head, completely engulfing her in his comparatively massive shadow. His own sharp inhale sounded between clenched teeth when he felt her feather-light fingertips start trailing over his abdomen, tracing the lines of scarring, bone, muscle and metal there.

Entrapta pressed her lips to his in one more soft kiss before she shimmied down the bed a bit. When she pressed a kiss to the long bulging scar that ran down the center of his chest over his hearts he shivered hard. He curled his body over hers, burying his nose in the hair at the crown of her head and drawing his pelvis up further between her thighs. She shifted, lifting both knees up over his hips and hooking her ankles behind his lower back.

Hordak shuddered again when she took his throbbing, dripping cock in her small hand and guided it toward herself. He shut his eyes tight when she lifted her dripping heat to his own and coated his shaft in a mix of her sweet fluid and his precum. Then she held him in her hands and he shifted forward slowly, gritting his teeth as his tip pressed deeply against her before slipping past the ring of her entrance. They both groaned raggedly, and she let out a long breath she’d been holding. Short legs tightened around his waist and tilted her head far back, lifting her face so they could meet each other’s eyes. Then, once she'd nodded one last time, he breathed her name as he slowly sank home.

Her responding moan was loud and desperate, the sound fanning the flames in his body and further clouding his mind. As she clung tighter against him and buried her face in his chest, he lowered himself until she was pinned beneath his weight, her thighs open wide beneath his hips. She shifted her legs a bit higher, tilting her core back, and he slipped deeper.

The deep purring in his chest had morphed into something more ragged, more fervid and Hordak vaguely registered that something about Entrapta's unusually submissive behavior seemed to have triggered something primal and brutish within him. He longed to drag his tongue along her neck, tasting her racing pulse, perhaps even smelling the adrenaline racing through her blood. If he weren't so wildly aroused, he might have been alarmed by the primitive lust still building within him. As it was, however, he was far too intoxicated with Entrapta to pause for thought. Instead, he hooked a claw beneath her chin and tilted her face up so he could watch it as he slowly pulled himself out of her, nearly all the way, then sank back to her limit in one forceful, fluid motion. She tossed her head back and cried out, his hips bucked reflexively up into hers, but she quickly returned her eyes to his, determined to keep watching his face.

The raw intimacy between them stoked his lust and he began pumping into her in a slow, firm rhythm. Tingling waves made his stomach flip and breath catch, he felt himself swell further inside of her, and he had to struggle to keep a feeling urgency from speeding his movements. Below him, Entrapta was panting, flushed and beautiful. He reared back on his knees, thigh burning, and wrapped his hands around her forearms to draw them up over her head. Then he tucked his own forearms beneath her shoulders, lifting her chest against him and making it easier for her to crane her neck back as they looked into each other's faces. He watched her expression flicker as he withdrew slowly and surged up into her again.

Her moaning pitched up and she shut her eyes briefly. "Yes," she breathed, opening them again. "Yes, *yes*, fuck me."

“Entrapta,” he groaned again, thrusting home a bit harder.

“More,” she commanded through a choked moan.

He finally lost his composure and set to rutting into her with shuddering, rolling hips and savage growls. He'd moved a hand to fist in her hair, holding her neck open to him. He hunched over above her so he could reach her throat and licked the fragrant skin there, feeling her pulse thud beneath his tongue before he whispered into her ear, “Touch yourself while I fuck you.”

She whimpered and moved to obey immediately, and he felt her core tighten on his cock the second her fingers made contact. He snarled viciously into her neck as she arched up against him, bearing down on her orgasm fast. Control forgotten, he thrust into her with all the urgency and passion roiling within him.

Her interior muscles clenched him so tight that he gasped and froze, completely lost in the exquisite feeling, hips twitching and jerking. She stiffened in his arms, eyes tight shut, teeth gritted, and face screwed up against overwhelming sensation. For several long seconds, she quivered silently against him, then the tension burst and she cried out, trembling violently through her orgasm and gasping for breath. He let out a hoarse roar of triumph and started fucking her again, holding her tight while she shook and he rolled his hips against her.

When he finally started to shudder out his own release, Entrapta wrapped her limbs around him and held tight, squeezing him with shocking strength as his orgasm crested and his cock surged within her. He growled long and low, spasming into her wet heat with every wave of pleasure that crashed over him, abdomen clenching hard enough to steal his breath. At last, when he was able to catch his breath and regain his bearings, he realized he’d collapsed on Entrapta with her head above his shoulder, and she was slowly stroking his hair with her lips pressed to the side of his neck.

He immediately tried to roll off of her but she tightened her arms and legs around him, signaling him to stay put. So carefully, he readjusted his weight slightly and lay back down between her legs, his arms wrapped around her, heavy head resting on her chest. She kept stroking over his hair with one hand and the other drifted to fondling his burning ear. Eventually she heaved a long, deep sigh. “Hordak?”

“What?” he grunted, voice muffled by the soft flesh his face was squished up against.

She chuckled weakly. “I can feel your leg bleeding on my foot.”

“Grow the fuck up and do it anyway,”

Chapter Summary

> Catra, Scorpia and Imp approach the others about the way Entrapta's been treated in the past. Then Catra and Adora have a conversation about her rising anger and its effect on She-Ra. Finally, Etheria receives an ominous message from beyond their orbit and an unexpected visitor traps Hordak in his lab.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“It's been a weird evening, let's drink.” Catra tipped back the entire contents of her glass before sighing, taking another glass, and leaning against the wall. “Scorpia, do you think anybody else should be here, or do you think this is fine?”

“I think word will probably get around,” Scorpia said, watching Perfuma show Imp the bracelet she’d made of the scrap he’d given her.

“You said we need…?” Glimmer asked, wrinkling her nose at the algae down Catra’s front.

“To talk about Entrapta,” Catra finished for her.

“Why? Is she worse?” Bow asked straightening up and frowning his concern.

“No no, she’s fine,” Catra reassured them. “This is old business.”

Several people exchanged confused looks and Catra sighed again, thinking about how to start. “Maybe,” Scorpia began tentatively. “Maybe we should just start with what she said? From Imp, I mean.”

Catra nodded. “Yeah. Yeah, we were talking about the old days and we asked her if there was anything she missed about the Fright Zone.” She looked around to make sure everyone was paying attention, then nodded at Imp.

He opened his mouth and replayed Entrapta’s voice. “...I guess I kind of miss the rank thing… From the vents, it was easy to tell that everyone was just afraid of Hordak. But in person-to-person interactions, the way people treated me felt almost like respect.”

Imp closed his mouth and fluttered down onto the table, where he crossed his legs and waited patiently. Quiet filled the room until the air felt thick and heavy. Adora looked deeply disturbed and pressed a fist to her mouth, staring at the table in front of her. Many other princesses were blinking, stunned, as if they’d just been slapped in the face. Melog was the first to break the silence with a low, mournful meow.

“Oh wow,” Perfuma said softly, leaning forward to place her head in her hands. “I feel like an absolute asshole.”

Catra shrugged. “Honestly, speaking as a lifelong, expert asshole? You probably should.”

Mermista rubbed her face and Sea Hawk scowled at the table. Frosta’s face was more or less blank and puzzled, but Glimmer and Bow seemed appalled. Imp looked around at them all, then cocked his head at Catra as she downed a second glass of pink drink.

Scorpia finally broke the silence as she addressed the group with a slow and gentle voice. “Look, I know acceptance and togetherness are your thing.” Frosta gave her a hurt look and she put her claws up hastily. “And you’re really good at it! You guys taught me about what friendship is supposed to be like and it’s the best thing that ever happened to me.” Catra had to try hard not to roll her eyes. “I’m just saying, like anybody with anything, you still have a lot of room for improvement.” She looked around at the group, who nodded in vacant ascension. “Hordak wasn’t

completely wrong about everything, you know?" This sentence caused a more significant reaction among the group. Several princesses straightened and crossed their arms firmly. Mermista and Bow narrowed their eyes. "I mean, Mermista has a really good point with that stuff about beautiful Etherians and the whole 'ugly' or 'scary' Etherians not usually showing up in the same places. Well, besides Salineas and Dryl." The reception her words received remained chilly. Catra's temper stirred, and she stepped closer to the group to stand and analyze their reactions as Scorpia continued. "Look at everybody in the Crimson Waste. Most of them came from the Crimson Kingdom because the Scorpion Dynasty was so class-conscious. And the Scorpion Dynasty fought with the other kingdoms because they were so 'normal' conscious. I think the grudge kind of piled up over the years, especially when the family bloodline started petering off." She shrugged, frowning sadly.

A few people wore newly surprised expressions and Scorpia blushed. "Bows dads gave me some reference material. I read."

"Look at all the people that joined the Horde willingly," Catra said to re-center the conversation.

"Look at how much trouble some of the clones are still having with a lot of Etheria's traditions," Bow added, looking down at the table.

"I agree," Perfuma spoke up, her head still in her hands. "The more I think about it, the more I wish I'd thought harder about the gaps in our inclusion. We've got a lot to learn." Scorpia nodded and the rest of the princesses finally showed signs of contrition.

Nobody seemed to know what to say. Catra's stomach grumbled and she leaned forward to grab some snacks, tossing a few to Imp. Bow and Glimmer both leaned away to avoid the grime she was covered with, wrinkling their noses again. Adora hadn't moved, still pressing her fist to her mouth and glaring at the table.

Scorpia heaved a massive sigh. “I know you all had reasons. People always have reasons.” She gave everyone a compassionate smile.

“But your reasons were dumb,” Catra jumped in. “You wanted her to make weapons for you because she was your friend, and then you acted like it was a moral failing when she did the same thing for new friends.”

“At the time,” Scorpia said slowly, cringing with sympathy. “It kind of seemed like… and this was just me, but it seemed a little bit like you were mainly offended she stayed with her new friends instead of ditching us for you. And you took it really, really personally.”

“Why *did* you take the shit she did so personally?” Catra asked, looking at the many sheepish expressions around her.

“Because she nearly got us all killed with what she did for you,” Mermista answered, though her voice was calm and matter-of-fact.

“Yeah but she’s not *like* that,” Catra answered, frustrated with their sensitivity yet again. “You should have known she *also* had reasons.”

“But why would she do so much destructive stuff?” Frosta asked, a hint of destress in her voice. “She’s so cool, but I can’t figure out why she did it.”

“Apparently she was trying to get us out of Despondos or whatever. She didn’t realize the consequences, but when she learned about what was going on she tried to stop it, remember? That’s why I knocked her out and sent her to Beast Island?" Catra said, rubbing her neck. “Regardless, you assumed a lot of malice. But she's not me. She doesn't have a malicious bone in her body."

Several people nodded before Adora added, “She knows right from wrong, she’s just interested in scary stuff.

“And it’s a good thing she is,” Glimmer sighed, “because it turns out the Universe is a pretty scary place full of scary things.”

“If you'd been there to bounce ideas off of, she might never have done the damage she did,” Catra said, speaking a bit lower. “All she needed was friends-” she frowned at the floor, “good friends- to keep her grounded.”

The group sat in silence for a few moments while everybody thought. Perfuma’s head was still in her hands when she spoke up, saying, “Oh my goodness. I’m just now realizing… all those things she mentioned at the Pan-Etherian meeting, about us leashing her and making her act a certain way. We must have hurt her feelings so many times.”

“Did somebody actually leash her?” Catra raised an accusatory brow.

“That was me,” Perfuma said miserably.

“Even I’ve pulled her around by her hair,” Bow added.

“What the hell, guys,” Catra said, unfolding her arms to put her hands on her hips.

“You guys kept acting like you were martyrs for ‘*putting up with her*,’” Scorpia waved her claws vaguely in what Catra recognized as an approximation of air quotes, betraying a hint of Scorpia’s own frustration.

“So what if she doesn’t belong on the front lines?” Catra said, exasperation pushing on her patience. “We never would have survived Prime if it wasn’t for her.”

“Even in a front lines situation,” Adora broke in, “she can handle a lot.”

“She’s saved my life in battle before,” Sea Hawk said.

"It's just… it's really hard to adjust to such… *different* behavior," Perfuma said, though it sounded more like an effort in self-soothing than an excuse.

"Grow the fuck up and do it anyway," Catra said flatly.

"It's almost never easy or comfortable to adjust to different things, right Perfuma?" Scorpia cushioned. "Even when we know it's the right thing to do. Patience is hard work, but learning to know and communicate with different kinds of people is what we're supposed to be helping our people do, right? Well, let's do some work on ourselves while we're at it," she said, her sunny, can-do attitude back in place.

"Is that why she had a breakdown?" Frosta asked quietly. "Because we've been so awful to her?"

"No," Bow reassured gently at the same time Catra said, "Kind of."

"She… got so... burned out," Scorpia minced, "because of the pressure she'd put on herself."

"She was pushing herself way too hard and when she couldn't do it, she got all angry and abusive with herself, you know?" Catra tried to explain.

"Why would she do that?" Frosta asked, voice still thick.

"Because," Perfuma broke in, sighing heavily, "when you have to try twice as hard for half the respect, it's easy to lose perspective and normalize totally insane standards." Several people exchanged strained glances. "Not that anyone here would know anything about that," she added, looking around at Catra and Glimmer.

"Called out," Glimmer muttered, frowning and shifting in discomfort.

"Look," Catra rubbed her temples slowly, thinking longingly of the shower near her bedroom. "Bottom line is, Entrapta is not a

burden. Without her, we wouldn't be alive, and on top of that she's cute as shit and she's super fucking nice."

"Most important of all," Scorpia jumped in, "she's valuable even without the science or the tech. She's our friend and that's enough. She doesn't have to worry about earning our favor."

"We need her. She should be allowed to need us, too." Adora looked around at their nodding peers.

Catra allowed herself a glare. "I've treated her worst of all. I know that. I owe her more than my life, but that's why I'm making this my business." She paused for affect once more. "So know that I mean it when I say: if I ever see her treated like a burden again, I'm going to make sure it's the last time."

Everyone kept nodding. "We all have a responsibility to fix this," Glimmer said slowly.

"And we need to be there for her while we deal with what comes next," Bow said.

"Should we go talk to her?" Glimmer asked, glancing around.

Bow shook his head. "She'll need sleep first, I think. She spent the whole day up and running around and she seems pretty tired."

"Soon, then," Adora said, frowning at the table again while the others nodded.

"Soon," Imp repeated in Hordak's voice.

* * * * *

A freshly bathed and groomed Catra sat on the bed a couple of hours later, scratching passively at Melog's mane as they rested

their chin on her leg. They watched a stark-naked Adora chew at her lip while she rummaged around in Catra's drawers for bedclothes. Catra felt a small zing of satisfaction at the two small scabs on the backside of where Adora's neck met her shoulder before Melog meowed up at her, rolling slightly so they could see her face. "I don't know," Catra answered, eyes still on Adora.

"What did they say?" the blonde asked, pulling on a pair of shorts.

"They asked what you're so agitated about."

Adora rolled her eyes and scowled.

"You just going to avoid it then?" Catra asked, hoping she wasn't kicking up a fight.

Adora turned her back and her shoulders slumped. Catra gave her time to think, watching her bowed head and wiggling toes. "I'm not trying to avoid it, per se," she started. "I'm just trying to keep it from affecting my life." She turned around to frown at Catra, who patted the bed next to her. Adora joined her, crossing her legs and twisting her hands. "I just keep getting caught up on how these feelings aren't, like, mine, but…" She shook her head slowly and blinked hard, as if wrestling with a concept, "but they honestly seem really, really fucking logical and that's making it hard to ignore."

"How do you mean?"

"Like… I'm so angry, but it's not aimless, you know? Like it's real stuff that's making me angry, I just can't control it. I'm mad about the First Ones doing what they did to She-Ra, I'm mad at Etheria for being so sheltered, I'm mad at Hordak and Shadow Weaver for our childhood, I'm mad at the stupid, stupid *stupid* war, and I'm mad at Prime and the wider universe for being so shitty!" Catra nodded slowly while Adora's agitation rose. "I'm fully aware that being angry about things we can't do anything about isn't productive or helpful. And, if I'm actually being logical, then obviously it's not like I'm the only one who's right and everybody

else is wrong," she rambled, taking her hair down and growing more animated, "so *clearly* this is an Adora problem. And, what makes it way worse?" she gave a little laugh, sounding slightly hysterical. "I didn't tell anyone this, but I tried turning into She-Ra yesterday and I couldn't do it!" Catra's mouth fell open and Adora immediately looked contrite. "I was able to do it again later, I… I can still turn into She-Ra," she assured her. "It's just… It's gotten kind of tricky. And iffy. I think it's got something to do with the rage."

"...Okay," Catra began slowly, "that is definitely bad news. But it's okay, we can still handle this."

Adora sighed and shrugged, wearing a dejected expression and staring at one of Catra's knees. "I have to figure this out. This anger is starting to get hard to manage."

She fell silent and Catra took a deep breath. "Why are you acting like this anger is some kind of disease?"

Adora looked at her like she had just suggested an enema. "Because it's a literal virus."

"Okay yeah, but like you said, the stuff you're angry about is real."

Adora was already shaking her head. "I have it way too good to be this angry."

"Your life is good, but it's also been super unfair. You have shit to be mad about, Adora," Catra reasoned, "not to mention a whole planet full of people to be mad for. Maybe you should let yourself be mad."

Adora squinted at her. "That… feels like a really bad idea."

Catra shrugged. "Maybe, I don't know. All I know is trying to push down my anger didn't make it go away, and it didn't keep it from affecting me. I had to let a bunch of it out and sort through that shit before I could even think straight." '*Maybe Hordak was right about the experience thing*,' she added silently to Melog. Adora

didn’t answer her, chewing her lip again and looking down. “Honestly,” Catra continued, “it sounds to me like you feel exactly how we all should. Everybody should be super fucking angry. They can’t be, obviously” she amended, “which is like, the whole crux of this issue because it’s not going to be great for you long term either, but do you get what I’m trying to say?” she asked, frustrated with her atrocious communication skills.

“I… I think I need to think about it,” she said quietly.

“Fair,” Catra said, shrugging again. She flipped positions and crawled toward the head of the bed, then noticed Adora wasn’t moving. “You okay?”

She glanced up at her with worried eyes. “There’s… there’s another part to this that I haven’t mentioned.” Catra nodded. “Something else that’s been bugging me.” She was silent for a moment before she heaved a sigh and rubbed her eyes with weary knuckles. “I need to explain a little bit. I, um, I approached Hordak, and I told him I can’t stop thinking about what happened to you. How… how I wish I could help and how I’m scared I’m letting you suffer alone when you don’t have to be.”

Catra’s body had gone cold, she could feel her heart clunking in her chest and she clenched her hands to ease the sudden shaking. “What did he tell you?” she breathed.

She shook her head. “He said it wasn’t his story to tell, and that I should ask you.” She paused for a few seconds. “Prime said to me… he said, ‘Her mind was ensnared in rage and grief and pain, she was afraid in the end, and she suffered.’ That’s what he said to me.” Her voice broke and tears slipped down both cheeks.

Catra’s eyes stung too and she swallowed thickly. “Yeah,” she croaked, then cleared her throat. “Yeah, I was afraid, and I did suffer.” Catra leaned forward and grabbed Adora’s hands. “But I survived, and I’m here now, and we have it pretty fucking good.” Adora nodded, but gave her the same pleading expression. Catra

had to look away for a few seconds to collect her thoughts. "I… I don't think I'm ready to talk about what happened yet. I'm sorry."

Adora squeezed her hands. "That's alright. I just wanted you to know, and to say that I'm here anyway," she whispered.

"But when I can talk, I will, okay?" Catra asked, looking back at her.

Adora nodded and squeezed her hands again.

Catra looked out her tiny window, at the light rain that had started to bead up on the glass. Melog meowed and she shot them a dirty look. They growled right back and flicked their tail. '*Fine*,' she told them before speaking up again. "I um, I've also been thinking," she admitted slowly.

"Yeah?"

"I've been thinking about that thing you said… about us having second chances at the lives we never got to live." She nodded, but Catra started shaking her head slowly. "I don't think I can do that," she confessed, eyes stinging again.

"That's okay," Adora said in a small voice. Catra looked up at her, reminded of other times she'd comforted her, crying in some dark corner and panicking over her various paranoias. "Even though we never got that, we had our own sweet moments and achievements and lessons. Perfuma says we can figure out more smiles to share over our memories, too." Catra smiled weakly and Adora cupped her face gently with one hand. "Everybody that was there for the war is part of that. It's a mixed connection, but it's a real one."

Catra leaned forward so they could press their foreheads together. The connection of shared suffering was a lifeline, but it wasn't perfect. She'd had experiences that, while not the most extraordinary kind of suffering in the world and nothing she was treated differently for, made enough of a difference to her that it created a separation between her and other Etherians. Glimmer

had spent time with Prime, though she'd never been personally punished, and that… that was something she would never be able to make them understand.

She sighed and leaned against Adora a little more heavily as Melog picked their head up and meowed at her again. '*Oh yeah*,' she replied, '*Hordak*.' He knew. He knew Prime's cruelty even better than she did. There *was* one person in her social circle that could understand what she'd been through. For some reason, reexamining the fact was enormously comforting, and seemed to fill a small bit of the aching emptiness that haunted her. The next thing she felt was gratitude, and Melog nuzzled her leg, purring.

Catra placed her hand on the back of Adora's neck and pulled her in for a warm, lingering kiss. Adora responded readily, moving her mouth gently against Catra's and sighing. A purr started up in her throat and she smiled gently against Adora's soft lips, luxuriating in the sound of their lips moving against each other. She impulsively leaned forward, guiding Adora backward and crawling until Adora was on her elbows, and she was on her hands and knees before her, still kissing her slowly.

Adora swiped her tongue against Catra's mouth and she opened it for her, deepening their kiss and reaching for Adora's neck again. When the other broke for air, she took the opportunity to kiss her way down to Adora's jawline, then on to her neck. She mouthed the sweet-smelling skin there, grazing her teeth gently over her pulse point. Adora shivered and she growled at her breathy groan.

Melog meowed loudly and Catra stilled. After a couple of seconds they meowed again and she rolled her eyes hard, breaking away from Adora and growling with frustration. "Alright!" she ground out, running her fingers through her hair distractedly and taking a deep breath. "Adora," she looked back at her girlfriend, whose mouth was tantalizingly pink and swollen and who still seemed a bit dazed. "I'm going to take a quick walk, first," she said, fixing her with a heated gaze, "but I plan on fucking you senseless when I come back." She pulled away and hopped off the bed, leaving Adora looking confused and flustered. "So uh, do what you will

with that info." She headed for the door. "Come on Melog, let's give Adora some privacy."

When she walked into the lab, she found Hordak tinkering alone at a work table. He turned around as she entered and winced, gripping his leg. "That bad, huh?" she asked.

"Unfortunately I've injured it further," he said dismissively. "There was... an accident," he waved his hand vaguely.

Melog meowed at him and he frowned back, but Catra decided not to press the point. She opened her mouth to speak, but was suddenly struck with embarrassment. "I just stopped by to, um," she stalled, gritting her teeth and bullying herself into staying put.

"Entrapta is fine. She's sleeping, because it is very late, Catra," Hordak said pointedly.

"No I know," she shut her eyes and huffed a quick sigh. "I just wanted to say, before I forgot, that I'm glad you're with us." She opened her eyes again and he stared back in baffled shock. "I know suffering didn't purify you or whatever, and you're a little worse for wear like anyone else, but… but that means you're down here with all the other basket cases who've been through the ringer. And it's not so bad once the dust settles some, you know?" He narrowed his eyes in confusion. "I'm glad you're around, and that there's someone else that understands what it was like, with Prime." He nodded faintly. "Right," she said awkwardly. "Right. Going to bed now." She patted the work table a couple of times for some reason before she turned and fled, Melog chasing behind.

Once she was safely on the other side of the lab doors, she groaned and gripped her hair. Melog twined themselves around her legs, purring loudly. "Shut the fuck up, Melog, that was awful." They trilled through the purring and rubbed their face on her

affectionately. “Yeah,” she admitted. “Yeah, I am glad I said it.” They chirruped and kept purring as they escorted her back to her bedroom.

* * * * *

It felt like Catra had only just fallen asleep when Glimmers voice sounded through her bedroom door, accompanied by harried knocking. “Guys? Guys, wake up.”

Adora jerked awake and bolted upright. “Wusapening?” she slurred through a serious case of bedhead.

A poof of glitter marked Glimmer’s arrival in the middle of the room. “Guys,” she repeated in a strained voice. She looked worried and Catra felt a thrill of trepidation. “We just got a scary message from Outer Space.”

“What?” Catra asked, instantly more alert.

“Watch,” Glimmer said, holding out an unfamiliar piece of pink and purple tech from which sprang a hologram of a stately looking woman with no hair and a high, spiky collar.

It almost looked like she was entirely made of shimmering stone, but she moved smoothly as she spoke. “Greetings Etheria, I am Sivtria, Queen of Tarsis.” Her voice was lilting and fluid, oddly soothing. “I am delighted to inform you that I will be arriving with our ambassadors in approximately five Etherian hours. We would be honored to present gifts of gratitude for your victory over Horde Prime, and are eager to meet those who achieved such a feat.” She smiled slightly. “I’m sure you are eager to make a real first impression on the world of intergalactic diplomacy, and we are eager to survey this new addition to our Universe.” Catra’s hair began to lift. “As a bit of friendly advice,” she continued, “I would

personally recommend that you not bother with hostility. You would only be making things harder for yourself." Again, that sinister little smile. "In the diplomatic arena, of course. I look forward to meeting your reception in five hours." The hologram ended and Glimmer lifted her eyes to theirs.

Catra heaved a long sigh. "Seems like a real bitch," she said simply.

"We've got this, Glimmer," Adora said firmly, reaching out and gripping the other woman's shoulder. "I'll be with you."

"You already parlayed with Prime, I'm guessing she won't be worse," Catra added, and Glimmer seemed to calm some.

Glimmer opened her mouth to speak again, but before she could, the datapad on Catra's table pinged and she heard Hordak's voice calling her name. "What?" she asked, rolling out of bed to retrieve the pad.

"I need you to come to the cellars this instant," he said tersely, looking harassed and impatient.

She bristled immediately. "And why the fuck would I follow an order from you?"

"Because of this," he snapped in reply, shifting his screen so they could see over his shoulder. In the background behind him, a blue aquatic Etherian with fins at her ears cowered in a corner, pressed into the stone and shaking badly. The three women in Catra's bedroom looked each other in confusion before returning their eyes to the screen. "She won't move from that corner, not to use the doors and not even when I retreat to my bedchamber." He scowled harder than she'd seen him do in a while. "The child remains quite resolutely stationary. Entrapta left early, and there is nothing I can do for the situation because any time I so much as turn toward her-" he rotated in place so that the background slid sideways behind him. Sure enough, upon his movement an ear-splitting shriek made the speaker on her pad crackle, succeeded

by frantic crying. He spun back in place so that he was facing away from the girl again, pressing his eyes shut as the crying subsided. “Please come make that stop,” he growled.

Catra looked up at the other two. “Melog can find me if you need me,” she said quickly, jumping out of bed to change fast. Then she pointed her finger at the others in turn, who still looked worried. “And don’t take shit from that alien lady. This is motherfucking Etheria.” They nodded blankly before she tore out of the room and broke into a run on all-fours.

Chapter End Notes

1- I'm probably going to take a break between this one and Responsibility: Pick a Nightmare and Run with it (that capitalization doesn't seem right) so I can read what the fuck I've actually said over the past five stories and plot some things out before we get darker with things. But I do plan to continue because, somehow, I'm still into this.
3- That being said, if you've got any thoughts or feedback about what it is you've read, any interaction is greatly appreciated.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!